

Microcopy

The Complete Guide

Kinneret Yifrah

Your users will fall in love

A handbook for UX writers, designers & friends ★ All the tools you need to write smart microcopy yourself ★ Over 300 screenshots from actual websites, apps & other digital products





Karma is Priceless

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Kinneret

NEMALA

Microcopy

The Complete Guide

Extended and updated

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WHAT IS MICROCOPY AND WHAT'S IN THIS GUIDE

How microcopy was born

In 2009, Joshua Porter wrote a blog post with the title "Writing Microcopy" (Bokardo blog). In the post he described a checkout form he created for an e-commerce project, where 5%–10% of the online transactions were failing because of billing address errors, hence causing financial damage. What did Porter do? He added one sentence next to the billing address field: "*Be sure to enter the billing address associated with your credit card*".

"*And just like that, the errors went away", he wrote. "It was clear the right copy meant I didn't have to worry about that problem anymore, thus saving support time and increasing revenue on the improved conversion.*"

Porter shared with his readers an idea that he had been mulling over for a while – just adding a few words in the right place at the right time could completely change the user experience. Not only that, he created the name for this type of copy: microcopy.

At a lecture he presented at the UXLX conference, he recounted that this post, which took less than 20 minutes to write, became a phenomenal success, the type of success bloggers dream about, and that he received many replies from UX readers thanking him for giving a name to these small but powerful words.

Porter's post was the first step in defining a new area of knowledge, microcopy (also known as UX writing and UX copy). This was a central element of the user experience that hadn't received enough attention or benefitted from having a methodology to implement it. Since then, the definition of microcopy has been developed and refined, setting it off from content and copy. Following is the definition that I like best, and that was used to write this guide:



Microcopy: the definition

The words or phrases in the user interface that are **directly** related to the actions a user takes:

- The motivation **before** the action
- Instructions that **accompany** the action
- The feedback **after** the user has taken the action

The role of microcopy in the user experience

For many years, the trend was to make the interface "clean", with as few words as possible. Many people claimed that words overload the interface and are perceived as threatening by users. Others minimized the importance of words and asserted that no-one read them anyway.

But the simple truth is that communication is based on words, and anyone who gives up on using them is removing a very basic component of the relationship between people. In other words, if you want to create a digital product that sounds human and relates to the people using it, you need words. At the end of the day, **people** are going to use your product, and there are some things that you can only convey to them by using words. This book contains a lot of them.

What can microcopy add to your digital product?

1. **Create a positive experience and engage the user**

   Microcopy reduces the alienation between people and machines, and changes the relationship from a robotic functional encounter to a human personal experience.

   Accurate microcopy adds a rich palette of colors to the experience you are trying to create, and adds depth to your product. Where needed, words will reach out to your users, and enable them to perform an action. Words engage users and can make them laugh or calm their fears.

   Good microcopy changes the connection between the product and its users into a mutual relationship, a conversation, that can be rich and even moving. Microcopy will create a dialog with your users that is full of character, such that it makes them want to work together with your product, and return another day. Microcopy can make your users fall in love.

2. **Increase usability**

   Microcopy greases the wheels of the interface and reduces friction with its users.

   Well written microcopy, appearing exactly where it is needed, will prevent problems in completing an action, and will save the user valuable time, frustration and a feeling of helplessness. A few small words that appear exactly where the user needs them will prevent a bad experience and unnecessary damage to their relationship with your brand.

3. **Enhance branding and differentiation**

   Microcopy written with a full understanding of your brand and target audience highlights the brand's character and differentiates it from other brands.

   Instead of a boring and predictable product, one that your users encounter all over the internet, your product will be unique and full of personality. It will support your vision and the values of your brand, sharpen the key messages to your target audience, and create an authentic and unified experience throughout the whole interaction with your audience.

The enormous potential of microcopy and the critical influence it has on the relationship between your brand and users, are becoming clearer to more and more user interface professionals. However, the subject is often overlooked during the design stages of the digital product. This is sometimes because of lack of time, lack of funds, or lack of awareness, and sometimes because the team just doesn't know where to begin.

The aim of this book is to give you the knowledge and tools to write microcopy; and no, you don't need to be a copywriter. All you need appears in this guide.

Who should read this book?

- Microcopy (UX) writers and copywriters
- UX designers
- Visual/web/UI designers
- Product managers
- Website and app owners
- Digital marketing professionals
- Optimization experts
- Small business owners
- Bloggers
- Advertisers
- Sales personnel
- And anyone who is interested in great interfaces

What's in this book?

The book **Microcopy: The Complete Guide** provides a methodology for writing microcopy for websites and apps after designing the voice and tone of the brand. It provides insights, guidelines and practical tools that I have gathered over many years of writing microcopy for websites, apps, and other digital products for corporations, start-ups, and small businesses.

It doesn't matter if your website or app is already up and running, or if you are planning or upgrading it, this book will take you step by step through the entire process of creating microcopy.

The first part of the book covers discovering the **voice and tone** of the brand, and what you need to decide **before** you actually go ahead and write the microcopy.

The second part covers the power of microcopy to create **engagement** with your users and to provide a **positive and rich experience**.

The third part of the book concentrates on the impact of microcopy on **usability** and also deals with **accessibility** and **complex systems**.

The 19 chapters of this book are written as practical guides with a method that you can immediately implement on your digital product. Each chapter starts with an understanding of the basic ideas and provides the steps required to implement them on all the elements of a UI. All the guidelines and tools are presented with the logic behind them, and the goal they are trying to achieve; and of course there are dozens of examples to learn from.

We are almost at the start line

This book will change your digital experience, both as a user and as a person providing the experience. The verbal connection between the digital product and its users – the piece that completes the puzzle of the user experience – will forever capture your eyes and heart, and will be important and meaningful to you. And that's a good thing. We spend a large part of our lives interacting with digital products, and it is only fitting that these valuable hours are spent in a pleasant way.

Good luck on the journey and enjoy the read,

Kinneret



Note about the copyright of examples used in the book

This book contains a lot of screenshots from within websites and apps. Naturally, the screenshots include elements covered by copyright, such as fonts, design and copy. Therefore, based on written legal advice, I have dealt with them with extreme caution. For instance, for each example I present only the minimum necessary to deliver the message. Wherever a screenshot was not essential, I have not provided it. Whenever websites or apps have provided the names of the designers, I have quoted this information.

Despite this, if the book contains examples that their creators are not interested in having published here, please contact me at microcopy.guide@gmail.com and I will remove them in the next edition.

PART 1:
THE VOICE AND TONE

Things you need to know before writing your first word

Writers for digital products know well those first few moments before writing a title, call to action, or any other sentence that demands we step into the shoes of our users and speculate: What will drive them? What exactly describes the value we are providing? And how can we prove to them that the best solution is our product or service? Then come the next set of questions: How do we phrase it? Should we use humor? What about slang or maybe wit? Do we need to write formally? Do we stir someone's emotions or rather try to calm them? Are we nostalgic or tech-y? Urban-cool or addressing the wide public?

These considerations are very important and indeed necessary to ensure that every word we write is effective and does a good job. The thing is that instead of **speculating** each time afresh, we should **know**. The main messages you'll impart to your users to motivate them to act and to connect to the brand, and also the voice and tone of what you write, should be defined beforehand. Luckily there is a method to achieve this.

After reading the first three chapters of this book, and if, as a result, you make important decisions and follow them, you won't need to speculate what will influence your users and the best way to phrase it. The answers will be clear and available whenever you need them.

Chapters in part 1:

1. Voice and tone design
2. Conversational writing
3. Microcopy that motivates action

CHAPTER 1

VOICE AND TONE DESIGN

IN THIS CHAPTER

How language influences users

What is **voice and tone design** and when to do it

The complete step-by-step guide to designing voice and tone

What do you mean when you say innovation?

A large communications company, one of my earliest customers, stated that the main way they differentiate themselves from other companies in this very competitive field is with the digital innovation of their products, self-service options, and how they provide a relevant and personalized experience for their customers. Their approach is to think young, up-to-date, and one step ahead of everyone else.

This message is emphasized at all board meetings, and they have documented it in the brand book and in their UX concept. They are focused on being leaders in their field and on bringing to market new innovative products. Like many other companies, they have invested a great deal in branding so that it broadcasts this important differentiation. They have designed a logo that matches their values, and they have created a high-end website and several apps. They paid a lot of attention to their choice of colors, fonts, and the many other elements that make up the user interface. They provide a user experience that makes their customers feel that the competitors are trailing far behind.

They turned to me because they realized that their voice and tone, the words that appear on the various digital products, hadn't been updated for the last 15 years. It had been left behind and they didn't know how to update it so that it fitted their innovative approach.

To get an idea of their current voice and tone and the microcopy used, I browsed the site and used some of the apps. As I do with all my customers in order to reveal their microcopy secrets, I registered on the site, completed self-service processes, recovered my password, made contact using their form, found their 404 page, and deliberately filled in each form with errors.

I concluded that the customer was, once again, right. Their differentiation and sense of innovation were lacking continuity and quite confusing:

- They declare themselves as innovative, but write in worn out clichés ("*Your inquiry is important to us*" or "*Your registration has been successfully completed*").
- They should persuade the user that signing up is simple and easy, but they sound like an insurance company ("*If it is your intent to register*").
- They want us to believe that their products are cutting-edge and relevant, but they use words that nowadays can only be found in dictionaries ("*Your search yielded the following results*").
- They want to evoke a young and dynamic feel, but they write like a robot ("*loading data, Please wait*").
- They try – oh, how they try – to motivate users to action, but forget to speak to their users' strongest motivations.
- And most important, they strive to be different, but sound just like everybody else.

This is how I started one of the most fascinating voice and tone designs I have ever worked on. The change was so great that after a short while the competitors started a similar process, except the company I was working for could back up its assertions – it was again one step ahead of everyone else.

Voice and tone in digital products – the human connection

The Man Who Lied to His Laptop is the name of a book written by Professor Clifford Nass of Stanford University, together with Corina Yen. Professor Nass was one of the leading researchers in the field of interaction between humans and computers, and in this book he and Yen summarize 100 experiments where he researched this interaction.

He found that people treat their computers according to social norms we apply when communicating with other human beings. Research proves again and again that we respond to computers and digital interfaces as if they were human. We are polite to them and expect them to respond politely, such as praising us if we manage to complete a task. In fact, if the computer provides warm and positive feedback, shows emotion that we relate to as

authentic, or behaves in a similar fashion to us, we'll be more productive in the tasks it asks us to do, we'll agree to more of its requests, and will believe more of what it is telling us. And conversely, if the product does not conform to our social conventions, and does not behave in the expected way, we are liable to get angry, disappointed, and even offended.

What's happening here? Before the digital age, the only entities that used language to communicate were humans. Thus, when someone addresses us using language, our brain immediately responds to the other party as a human.

Language is therefore the main factor that makes digital products more human-like, it endears them to users and creates an emotional connection that motivates us to act. But for this to happen, the product needs to conform to social conventions and feel natural and authentic.

Users' trust hinges on your voice and tone

Professor Nass researched how humans relate to digital products that present an inconsistent personality, especially where there are non-verbal elements (such as tone of voice) that are not consistent with the verbal elements (such as the content). He found that users related to the product as if it were unauthentic and unworthy of their trust. The story that this personality presented did not manage to persuade the users or evoke any emotion. On the contrary, the product sowed confusion and suspicion.

On the other hand, when the verbal and non-verbal elements were consistent and supported each other, the users felt that the personality was intelligent, fun and persuasive. They also understood the messages better, had an emotional reaction to them and were influenced by them. The more the users trusted the personality communicating with them, and believed that it was authentic, the more they were persuaded by its messages and agreed to act accordingly.

Nass explained that the reason we react in this way is because we try to create a coherent picture of the personality communicating with us. If we cannot create such a picture, we become suspicious and feel a sense of rejection.

That's what was happening in the example that opened this chapter: The product reflected innovation in its non-verbal elements, but the language was outdated; the product was dynamic but the language was heavy; the product was simple and clear but the language was cumbersome; thus, users lost trust, understood less and were less persuaded by the messages.

How voice and tone design solves the problem

Voice and tone design defines the language the brand will use when communicating with its users across all its digital products. This voice and tone design keeps the language the brand uses in line with its core values and supports them, so as not to create dissonance and unreliability.

Voice and tone design defines the language in two main ways:

1. Personality

What characteristics do you wish to convey to users with your language? What is the right tone, degree of formality, degree of humor (if any), use (or non-use) of slang, pace of speech, warmth, friendliness, etc.?

2. Messaging

What are the main messages? What will you highlight to get them to act? What should you say so that they feel good about themselves and your brand? And finally, what can you say to create a desired relationship that benefits you both?

After you have defined your brand's voice and tone, and you actually use it in your written materials:

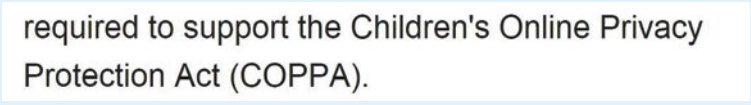
- Every word you write will be deliberately chosen, focused and influential.
- Your target audience will easily understand the value of your offering and the need it fulfills for them.
- The call to action will be simple and more effective.
- The brand will be more relatable and will come across as credible and compelling.

Example: How character sounds like

If we ask two people to state the same message in their own words, we'll receive two different versions. If we ask five people, we'll get five versions. We each have our own character, unique way of thinking, different experiences that shaped us, and distinctive goals in life. Therefore even if we talk the same language, what any one of us says will be in a slightly different tone.

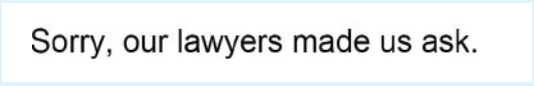
For example: two different American e-commerce sites ask their users to provide their date of birth when signing up, and each provides the reason they need this information – because it's required by law.

Famous and serious **Nike** says this:



www.nike.com

Whereas **J. Peterman**, that sells unique vintage products from all over the world (and Elaine's boss on Seinfeld), puts it this way:



www.jpeterman.com

Exactly the same message (we are required by law) is written by two different brands, each with its own unique character, thus the voice and tone used differs. If J. Peterman had used Nike's voice and tone, they would have spoilt the warm and intimate atmosphere that they have created with every word and in every nook and cranny of their delightful site. Whereas if Nike used J. Peterman's voice and tone, they would harm the image they try to create as a company that takes itself very seriously.

Each of these brands has a different relationship with its users: J. Peterman tries (and succeeds) in creating a warm, very service-oriented relationship with its customers, the type you might have

between a seller and regular customer in the neighborhood second-hand shop. On the other hand, the relationship created on the Nike site can be seen as being between a corporation that plays in the big leagues and potential customers who dream of getting there too. The voice and tone of each brand supports these different relationships.

7 stages in the lifecycle of a brand when it is worthwhile to stop and design a voice and tone

As with all things connected to branding, voice and tone design follows the rule of **the sooner the better**. The earlier you define the voice and tone, the more consistent your texts will be, and the verbal elements of your digital products won't look like patchwork. On the other hand, it is never too late: a change of voice and tone can result in an improvement to the bottom line, and that is always a good thing, isn't it.

Following are 7 critical stages where I recommend designing a voice and tone, if you haven't yet designed it:

- Creating a new brand – together with the visual branding, before the first word is even written. If you design the voice and tone right up front, you will benefit from a brand that communicates in a uniform way, and is persuasive from the word go. You'll also get used to communicating in the brand's voice and tone, and won't need to overcome bad habits.
- Releasing of a new or upgraded product.
- Sharpening your brand's differentiation.
- Setting up a new digital campaign.
- Creating or upgrading the organization's written communication infrastructure (email, chat, and social media).
- Before entering a new market with a new target audience.
- If you understand that the words you currently use simply don't work.

The guide: How to design a full and effective voice and tone

Voice and tone design is a short process where you fully and accurately define the personality of the brand and the messages that will influence its target audience. You can do this in-house or with the help of external content and branding experts. The whole process should take 1–3 weeks.

The end product of this process is a written voice and tone design that enables you to write microcopy (you can also use it when writing copy, content, status updates in the social media, and anything else written on behalf of your brand).

For medium and large companies and for freelancers that write microcopy for these companies, the full process includes 4 stages, and at every stage you'll discover important insights. If you lack the time or budget, or **if you own a small business or a blog**, stages 2 and 3 are the ones you should definitely do. In the following pages you'll discover exactly how to accomplish each stage and where you get the required information.

Stage 1 – Get to know the brand

Read the existing design and branding documents, and extract essential information. Some documents you can read at this stage:

1. Company vision, mission and values
2. Brand book (and any other branding documentation you can lay your hand on)
3. Briefs that were made for designers or for advertising purposes
4. Presentations made for introducing the business
5. UX concept and personas made for it
6. Research on brand perception and customer satisfaction

Stage 2 – Listen to what your users say

Extract good quotes, authentic phrases, words that repeat themselves, and what users see as motivators and setbacks. For a list of resources, see tip 5 on page 39.

Stage 3 - Complete the story with updated information fresh from the field

Hold a structured group interview with the organization's key personnel (marketing manager, digital manager, service and sales senior reps, and sometimes advertising people). **In small businesses** this is probably **you**, and you can hold this session with team members, a strategic consultant, or a close friend whose advice you appreciate.

In this session, ask a series of questions about the brand and its target audience. All the questions are provided further along in this chapter (see page 50).

This interview usually lasts about 3 hours, and sometimes you'll need two, 2-hour sessions: the first will be about the brand (with the marketing team), and the second about the users (with the service and sales teams). By the end of the meeting you should have a rich, detailed portrayal of the brand's personality and its target audience.

It is highly recommended to make this a **group** interview, as opposed to conducting several one-on-one interviews, so that conflicting views are immediately resolved.

Stage 4 - Put all the pieces together and produce the document

This is basically a working document that organizes and brings together all the information you had gathered in the previous steps, used from now on to guide the actual writing. What does it look like? See page 48 for directions.

The following pages provide a practical handbook to designing your voice and tone. The more questions you answer or information you gather, the more consistent, rich, precise and effective your voice and tone will be.

The first part of voice and tone design: The brand

1. Define the vision and mission

The change the brand wants to promote and the way this should be achieved

Usually we don't explicitly tell our users the vision and mission, but everything we write should implicitly reflect and promote them. Thus, it is important that the vision and mission are clear and familiar to all the writers.

Defining the vision might sound like a simple task (it seems obvious why the brand was created, doesn't it?), but in my experience it is often complicated and confusing. Invest as much time as required to define this and don't cut corners. The effort will be worth it.

See page 50 for the list of questions used to identify the vision and mission.

TIP

01

Ask why

The best way to reveal the vision is to ask the brand's key personnel **why** it was created. For every answer they provide, make it hard on them and keep asking **why**. After a few rounds of **why**, you'll get to the heart of the matter. For example:

Why was the microcopy studio, Nemala, created? In order to write better microcopy and teach others how to do it.

Why? So that digital products will provide a more pleasant and human experience.

Why? Because people spend most of their day in front of these digital products and if our experience is warmer and more pleasant, our lives will get better.

Nemala's vision: To create a human, bonding and heartwarming digital experience for people and improve their lives.

Examples of vision and mission taken from brand websites

Ikea

Vision: To create a better everyday life for the many people.

Mission: We shall offer a wide range of well-designed, functional home furnishing products at prices so low that as many people as possible will be able to afford them.

TripAdvisor

Vision: To help people around the world plan and have the perfect trip.

Mission: To offer advice from millions of travelers and a wide variety of travel choices and planning features with seamless links to booking tools that check hundreds of websites to find the best hotel prices.

Samsung

Vision: Inspire the World, Create the Future.

Mission: To develop new technologies, innovative products and creative solutions.

World Wide Fund (WWF)

Vision: To build a future in which humans live in harmony with nature.

Mission: To conserve nature and reduce the most pressing threats to the diversity of life on Earth.

TIP

02

Search the attic

The vision and mission are usually defined at an early stage of setting up the organization. It's probable that they have been phrased and documented in the brand book, UX concept guide, the elevator pitch, in presentations to investors, and in other foundation documents. Find them there, make sure you still hold them to be true, or change them.

2. Define values

Ideals and principles that guide the brand's actions

Select the 5 most important values that the brand cannot do without. If you're not sure what "values" are, take a look at the list on page 29.

For each value, write 1-3 line description and then ask: **how does this value sound?** What kind of language will convey this value? For example, if one of your values is **Leadership**, you might want your language to be charismatic, sharp, and recruiting. Address the users directly, and convey a clear vision in your messaging.

If **Community** is important to you, use inclusive, connecting language, with warm tones and soft humor, and with messages of sharing and caring.

This way, the values will be explicitly expressed, creating a coherent personality.

TIP

03

Prepare your word toolboxes

Every characteristic and value can be described using words, expressions and phrases that are connected to them or carry relevant meaning. Prepare a toolbox of words that you can pull out whenever you need to express a certain value. Use a thesaurus and also collect the terms you have heard directly from your users (more on that later).

For example, here is the toolbox of words for the value "practicality" for the voice and tone of an academic institution:

Relevant, entrepreneurial, daily, tools, management, practice, platform, changing / dynamic reality, advantage, decision making, real time, toolbox, applicable, practical, flexible, apply what I have studied, wages, the job market, career, employment, employers, graduates, post graduate, a set of tools that will help me.

Examples of values taken from brand websites

USA National Public Radio (NPR) (5 core values out of 10)

Accuracy – Our purpose is to pursue the truth. Diligent verification is critical.

Independence – Our primary allegiance is to the public.

Respect – Everyone affected by our journalism deserves to be treated with decency and compassion.

Accountability – We take full responsibility for our work, so we must always be ready and willing to answer for it.

Excellence – We take enormous pride in the craftsmanship of our storytelling and in the quality of the words, sounds and images we use to help illuminate the world.

Whole Foods Market (first 6 core values out of 8)

We Sell the Highest Quality Natural and Organic Products Available – We appreciate and celebrate the difference natural and organic products can make in the quality of one's life.

We Satisfy, Delight and Nourish Our Customers – Our customers are our most important stakeholders in our business and the lifeblood of our business.

We Support Team Member Excellence and Happiness – Our success is dependent upon the collective energy and intelligence of all of our team members.

We Create Wealth Through Profits & Growth – We are stewards of our shareholders' investments and we take that responsibility very seriously. We are committed to increasing long term shareholder value.

We Serve and Support Our Local and Global Communities – Our business is intimately tied to both the neighborhoods and the larger global community that we serve.

We Practice and Advance Environmental Stewardship – We wholeheartedly believe in active environmental stewardship so that the planet continues to flourish for generations to come.

Cut out & keep



116 values

This list will give you food for thought when defining your brand's values. Select those that are most important to you to uphold and promote. Don't hesitate to add your own values if they're not mentioned here.

Sustainability	Altruism	Sharpness	Love
Relevance	Dedication	Elegance	Sensitivity
Community	Professionalism	Decency	Enthusiasm
Curiosity	Ambition	Sincerity	Generosity, giving
Accessibility	Joy	Mystery	Intimacy
Adventure	Perseverance	Belief	Knowledge
Aesthetics	Determination	Authenticity	Service orientation
Fun	Versatility	Softness	Solidarity
Accuracy	Humor	Pleasure	Team work
Achievement	Charm	Discovery	Health
Empathy	Transparency	Familiarity	Nostalgia
Courage	Passion	Justice	Success
Competitiveness	Contemporary	Communication	Spirituality
Courtesy	Relevance	Diversity, variety	Personalization
Excellence	Innovation	Freedom	Quality
Friendliness	Clarity	Loyalty	WOW factor
Peace, calm, ease	Affinity	Proactivity	Tradition
Internationality	Coolness	Economic	Convenience
Creativity	Respect	Independence	Richness
Leadership	Intelligence	Imagination	Expertise
Caring	Brilliance	Logic, rationality	Change
Security	Growth	Safety	Commitment
Reliability	Development	Learning	Value for money
Practicality	Optimism	Flow	Stability
Simplicity	Organization	Originality	Flexibility
Accountability	Excitement	Liveliness	Focus
Connection	Provocation	Satisfaction	Challenge
Customer focus	Harmony	Effectiveness	Gentleness
Dynamism	Openness	Inspiration	Moderation

3. Describe the personality

If the brand was a person, it would...

Imagine that your brand is a person (yes, yes, just imagine for a minute...), then write down their personality traits: the way they behave around others, their sense of humor (or indeed if they have a sense of humor), and so on. Even describe the way they dress, their hobbies, personal preferences, anything that will help you characterize their personality, and from it - the way they talk. To make it much easier and fun go to the list of questions on page 50.

Note that the brand's personality is not your user's personality, and indeed might be very different, depending on the relationship you wish to conduct with your users (see also page 46).

TIP

04

Where are you on the scale

In addition to using the personality questionnaire (on page 50), I usually use this characterization tool developed by Pamela Wilson from **Big Brand System**. Ask your brand's key personnel to rate the brand's personality on the following 6 scales. Sometimes their answers are surprising and insightful.

Personable and friendly	⟷	Corporate, professional
Spontaneous, High energy	⟷	Careful thinking, planning
Modern or hi-tech	⟷	Classic and traditional
Cutting edge	⟷	Established
Fun	⟷	Serious
Accessible to all	⟷	Upscale

Example: a charismatic mom

During the three hours over coffee that I spent with a sleep consultant to design her voice and tone, she told me a lot about her target audience – first time moms. These young mothers are exposed to a constant stream of information that makes them feel insecure in their own intuitions and in their ability to understand the child and know what's best for him or her.

Based on this description, we constructed together the brand's personality:

If the sleep consultant brand was a person, she would be a 35-year old woman, a mother, and she would wear comfortable but fashionable clothes. She would read the Parenting and Health section of the newspaper first, and would spend the limited free time she has in DIY projects, running, and socializing. She is generous and devoted, attentive and empathic, but authoritative and precise. She's funny and happy, and radiates that nothing is really catastrophic. She has abundant knowledge, but she listens instead of preaching, and respects rather than patronizes. She combines authenticity and sincerity with professionalism and experience – and that creates trust. Her formal knowledge is plentiful and up-to-date, but she also respects a mother's intuition.

How is this personality reflected in the voice and tone?

- Despite the anxiety that surrounds the subject, it is important not to fall into the trap of sounding too serious; on the contrary, add humor and keep it light and natural.
- Keep the professional material flowing, conversational and authentic. Don't let the style become know-all and preaching on what's allowed or forbidden. The voice and tone should generate a good experience, encourage curiosity and also challenge the mother.
- Generosity and devotion are conveyed by presenting organized lists of everything the mother receives at each meeting and during the whole counseling process. Thus she can easily see the wealth of help provided.
- To express attentiveness and respect, the new mother should be the focus of the texts.
- On the scale between friendly and professional, the personality is bang in the middle: she'll talk to the mother as an equal, but she won't be her best friend.



Humor in your microcopy:

A common misconception about microcopy is that if we want to sound human, being funny will do the trick. This approach has brought up quite a few cases of "trying too hard" microcopy. In these cases, we feel like the writers were trying so hard to be Joe Cool that they forgot they were writing for UX. So what's the right way to use humor in your microcopy?

1. Only if it fits your personality

Is your brand or product deliberately designed as cool or funny? Why? What in its vision or values backs that up? Humor, sarcasm and wit can support your branding and strengthen the relationship with your users, but it can also damage them. For example, if your brand is supposed to promote the value of sharing, sarcasm may drive away users looking for a connection. So, before writing cool copy, let your brand values dictate why and how.

However, it's important to be careful when making assumptions up front. For example, if your app monitors the diet of diabetics, you might think it should sound very serious, because it affects the quality of life of many people. But you shouldn't take this for granted just because "health matters are serious". You can also choose to make the app humorous, to explicitly help your users get through their challenging day with a smile.

2. Only the way best suited for the target audience

Will your target audience understand you? Does your choice of humorous language connect to your users' culture and age group? True, there will always be users annoyed by the slightest mention of fun. Still, you have to know enough about your core users to know what shade of humor is relevant for them. For example, people under the age of 17 use a unique vocabulary when being funny. When you're writing for kids or teenagers, it's important to have a "translator" from that age group look over your copy and see if it sounds authentic (unless you're 17). Same goes for writing for any other culture or dialect that isn't your native tongue.

7 guidelines to doing it right

3. Make sure wit isn't your writing's only characteristic

If the only thing you can say about a writing style is that it's witty, then it's probably flat. Microcopy can also be nostalgic, energetic, warm, modest, arrogant, relaxed, poetic, sharp, sentimental, hippie and so much more, it all depends on your brand's values. If your microcopy doesn't convey anything other than wit, it means something has gone wrong.

4. How much is too much?

Did you make them laugh at the beginning and end? You don't have to be funny in the middle. Does your message close with a punchline? Start it off with a simple sentence letting users know what's happening. If possible, write the entire flow as a coherent sequence, instead of considering each screen separately; this will help you disperse your precious humor and wit with a gentle hand. Ultimately, choosing the right dosage of humor is the name of the game. And as Google say in their voice and tone design: **If you have a unicorn in the forest, you don't need a hula hooping monkey too.**

5. Nothing comes at the expense of clarity. Ever.

If your users have to pause and read your microcopy again to understand it, that's a bad sign. Usability rules. Humor can be a great sidekick to microcopy's other qualities (concise, clear, helpful), but never a substitute.

6. Be sensitive to the situation

Uh oh, your system crushed. We don't have the foggiest why. If your work is not saved, oops, it's all gone forever! But hey, there are kids in Africa who don't even have internet!

7. Be mindful of how frequently users see each joke

When writers enjoy their own jokes too much, they run the risk of using humor in texts frequently seen by the user. This isn't ideal, because it will get boring fast; by the third time your user sees your joke, it's probably not funny anymore.

The second part of voice and tone design: The target audience

1. Define the demographics

The demographic characteristics of the target audience: who will your brand be talking to?

With young people you can use contemporary language and slang, whereas seniors might not follow you. Youngsters also usually need fewer explanations on how to use the interface, whereas with older people you need to provide more instructions, **but this too is changing fast and has to be reexamined for each case.**

If your audience is of a specific age and style of living, you can spice up your microcopy with quotes from popular television shows, while other groups might not understand where you're coming from. There are audiences that will enjoy and be flattered when you address them in a sophisticated and witty way, yet other audiences will be offended, feel left out, or lose patience altogether.

So you see, it is extremely important to understand who you are addressing. The main characteristics you need to define are:

- Age
- Gender
- Where they live
- Level of education
- Marital status
- Other areas of interest
- Technological inclination

Of course, any other information you gather about your target audience will also help in designing the voice and tone.



Is everyone your target audience?

Some brands have a wide target audience that covers a large part of the population (such as banks or Waze), or relatively large (such as Starbucks), whereas others have a distinct and easy to define target audience (such as Snap).

The more defined the target audience, the more the voice and tone can and must take on a specific style that suits it. On the other hand, if your target audience is wide-ranging, the voice and tone will be more conservative and less sophisticated so as to meet everyone's needs.

That doesn't necessarily mean the voice and tone has to be boring or lack a distinctive personality. It still needs to be well defined, rich, welcoming, and fit the general persona you have defined.

A good example of a brand that addresses a very wide audience but still has a clear personality, is **Ikea**. It uses a voice and tone that is very simple, unsophisticated, not particularly humorous, sometimes even banal; but it displays a consistent and pleasant personality, provides a warm and homely atmosphere, and has a practical tone with conservative messages that nearly everyone can find appealing. For example:

"*The perfect compromise - he wants a sofa with a high level of firmness, you want a sofa you can sink into. With this sofa you combine both and live happily ever after*".

2. Define the needs and problems of your target audience

The practical challenges and emotional worries felt by your users – in their own words

Every product or service should improve the user's life, make it easier, answer a need or solve a problem. The better you understand the problem that the product or service is solving, and its influence on the lives of its users, the easier it is to more precisely address their motivations in the various messages, calls to action, and instructions.



Is your target audience made up of several – very different – groups?

Let's say you run a marketplace for second-hand goods. On the one hand you write for people that want to sell their items, and on the other for those who are looking to buy new-used items. Or: you have a cellular company that offers different digital products to teenagers and families.

In the next few pages we'll ask questions about the target audience, like: what are their needs, hopes, and objections, and what is the nature of the relationship we would like to have with them. It's obvious that for each of these distinct target audiences – buyers and sellers, youths and families – you will come up with completely different answers to these questions.

What should you do then? Find the distinct answers given by each group, and come up with a separate messaging array for each. If you are preparing a voice and tone design for a large organization, you might need to confer with different sales and service teams that work with the different groups.

At the end of the day, the brand characteristics from the first part of the voice and tone design will remain the same for all target audiences, with minor fine-tuning at most, but the messaging will be completely different according to what you'll find out in the second stage.

You will also find it easier to gain the trust of your audience, and show them that you listen to them, understand them, and that you offer the best solution to their problem or need.

Let me emphasize that this is not manipulation: Your product or service will not succeed if it doesn't provide real value to your users and solve their problems. The real challenge is to accurately pinpoint these problems, and describe them with your users' words to motivate them to choose your solution.

Example: how we made it (a bit) easier for job seekers during a challenging period of their lives

Looking for a job is a sensitive and especially painful process, as it touches a basic, existential and urgent need: our livelihood. In the interviews conducted with job seekers, which I listened to when writing microcopy for an online job board, I heard a long list of difficulties and hardships that they endured during this period. Following is just some of the input, and I'll show how it influenced the voice and tone and how that affected the relationship created between the job board and its users.

Hardship	Influence on the voice and tone
The average period someone looks for a job is 60 days, and during this time the job seekers provide their details and upload their resumes on dozens of sites and for many positions. We're talking about a daily disheartening task that seems interminable.	Wherever possible, we explained to the users **why** we need them to provide a certain piece of information or to fill out a form. We described the benefit **to them**, and reminded them that this action would bring them one step closer to **their** goal, making it a little less discouraging. But we were careful not to be repetitive – job seekers encounter many such forms every day. Our voice and tone was brief, professional and straightforward, with many active verbs demonstrating progression and speed.

Hardship	Influence on the voice and tone
Job seekers rightly feel that thousands of other applicants are applying for the same job, and that it is nearly impossible to stand out from the crowd and catch the eye of the potential employer. And this is quite depressing.	This fear of being swallowed up by the crowd, was used by us to motivate users to add a cover letter to their resume. We wanted them to add a cover letter as employers respond to these much more, so it was in **their** best interests to provide it; but often they would skip this because they lacked patience, were disheartened or simply lazy. So just before the cover letter form, we spoke **directly to their hardship** and reminded them that a cover letter is a good way to stand out from other applicants.
Loneliness is one of the strongest feelings that job seekers experience. Alone, they have to face one of the hardest periods in their lives while everyone else continues with their daily routine.	To relieve the loneliness, it was important to us to provide a very human product, supportive and understanding. We used a **conversational and soft** voice and tone, we reflected feelings and concerns, and showed a lot of **empathy** in our texts.
In usability testing, it was found that because job seekers usually don't receive a reply from employers, they are not sure if the form they filled on a job board was actually sent, and if sent, was it with all the right attachments, and was it received by the employer.	In order to address these concerns, we added clear unambiguous feedback throughout the process that it was proceeding well – that the form had been successfully received, that the resume was sent to the employer, that the current stage of the process had finished successfully, and so on.

TIP

05

Users are the best copywriters

When you are expressing what your users think, it is best to use **their** words. They will always be more precise and use the most authentic phrases. Take the words of your users, and use them to describe the benefits of your brand and to get users to act.

Where can you hear what your users say?

1. Online chat transcripts
2. Answers to open questions in surveys you conducted
3. Online communities (e.g., Facebook groups) about relevant matters
4. Feedback/comments made about your brand or your competitors on social media
5. Usability tests recordings
6. Listening to call centers' incoming and outgoing calls
7. Transcripts from focus groups
8. Any other platform your target audience uses to discuss relevant issues

Lacking any of these resources? Interview 5–10 of your potential users, even from your friends and family. It only takes a few hours and it can entirely change the way you think, and write, about your brand and product.

What will you find? Treasure. You'll find excellent, precise wording that you would never find on your own when analyzing in a professional, planned and rational manner. Simply take your users' words and embed them in your copy.

3. Describe the hopes and dreams of your target audience

Their purpose in using your digital product

In the previous section we looked at what negative things would be solved by using your digital product. This section looks at the positive outcomes, what the users gain from using it. People need a good reason to act, they need to believe that the action will bring them closer to their goals, and will make their dreams and hopes come true. These hopes are the reason that they got to your product, and they will be the drivers to sign up, share, buy an item, or do anything else you want them to do on your product. Therefore, these hopes and dreams are what you'll talk about when you want the users to do something or when you want to give them the feeling that they are in the right place and doing the best thing for them. And for that to happen you need to know the users' words to hit the right spot (**see tip 05**).

Example: let's talk for a minute about your budget

When a big bank uploaded to its website a new tool to manage a customer's budget, it was easy for me to connect to the hopes and dreams of the target audience: while I regularly keep an eye on my bank account, I'd still love something simple and efficient that will give me an overview of my budget, and show me where I spend more, and where less. This tool might help me finally achieve some of those goals I've put on ice because I haven't had the time to arrange a budget for them (such as to finally travel and see the northern lights).

As part of the voice and tone design for this new tool, we learned about the hopes and dreams of the bank's customers concerning their budget. We discovered three key groups of aspirations: **1. Peace of mind and long term financial security**, realized by putting money aside; **2. Control**, by tracking and understanding the big picture; **3. Quality of life and**

realizing dreams, realized by careful planning of the budget and by accumulating savings.

Now we just had to show the users how this budget management tool would move them closer to achieving these aspirations:

- When we wanted to motivate customers to check out and use the tool, we spoke about peace of mind, security, and realizing dreams: *"So that you can realize a new or old dream and be prepared for anything life puts in your path*".
- So that users would set themselves objectives in the various expense categories, we spoke about being in control: "*Keep your finger on the pulse and at any point in time see where you stand in relation to your life goals*".
- The need for control and being informed was also used as a motivator to get users to correctly categorize each expense: "*A good budget is an accurate budget – expenses that you don't categorize stop you from seeing the big picture*".
- So that they would use the follow up and comparison tools, we spoke about achieving goals: "*To plan forward and achieve goals, you need to also look back. Here you can see your budget over the whole year*".

As you can see, you don't need to rack your brains to find the phrases or messages that will motivate your users to act. They visited your website or app to achieve something that would improve their lives. You just need to find out what that is and remind them of it.

4. Define the objections and concerns of your target audience

The barriers that will stop users from actually using your product or service

Objections need special attention, and on no account should they be ignored. On the contrary, you need to address them, at least implicitly, dispel them or prevent them from occurring in the first place. There are some well-known and constant objections, such as reluctance to spend money or provide personal details; and then there are those unique to a specific product or service. Either way, map out and fully understand the objections and concerns, and provide your users with compelling reasons so that they overcome them and trust you.

Example: will you marry me?

We all have a clear picture of what a classic marriage proposal looks like, drummed into us after watching thousands of hours of romantic dramas: one man, one woman and a diamond ring. The man on bended knee, the woman weeping with joy, and the ring's a perfect fit. A photo of the ring is uploaded to Facebook and they live happily ever after.

A large and well established diamond company decided to challenge its traditional business and put up a website focused entirely on engagement rings. The target audience is male – those selecting the ring, not those who will wear it. On the website the men are offered an extensive catalog with a large selection of designs to choose from, and then they can select a diamond according to their budget. In this way anyone can create online the exact ring they want that also fits their budget.

A man selecting a ring and diamond – usually for the first time in his life – has many concerns, but only one dream: a fairy tale marriage proposal and one happy and very satisfied woman. True, the sky won't fall if his fiancée wants to change the ring or alter its size, but that

will be an unromantic twist in an otherwise glittering picture. So some of the man's concerns are about his girlfriend: can he find something to suit her taste? How does he know the correct size? Other fears concern the diamond: based on what criteria does he select the diamond? What does he need to examine and question? How does he know that the diamond is genuine and of high quality? And the biggest concern of all: what will he do with the ring if she surprises him and says no... On top of all that there are the usual concerns of buying online: security, shipment or pick-up options, and so on.

Any one of these concerns is enough to cause the user to abandon the online process and look at another site, or go to a brick-and-mortar shop. But this company really studied its target audience, and in its online selecting and purchasing processes it provides clear reference to each one of these concerns. Before selecting a ring, the site offers links to short articles that suggest to the user that he take a look at his girlfriend's jewelry box, see what other rings she has bought herself, and measure the diameter of her favorite ring. Later on there is a promise by the company to change the size if necessary, with no extra charge. Every technical term, such as color or clarity, is accompanied by an explanation and illustration. There are references to the certificate of authenticity and assurance that comes with the ring; and towards the end of the process the security of the site is emphasized, and a full refund is promised if the ring is returned within 30 days.

Preparation of an organized list of objections and concerns, and the provision of a solution at exactly the right moment, enables a user to finish the process of selection and purchase of an item smoothly and with peace of mind, without abandoning the site or turning to support. It's better for both the user and the website operators.

5. Make a list of the preferences of your target audience

The main reasons that your target audience will choose your brand and not that of your competitors or similar brands

What differentiates your brand and makes it better than others? In professional terms it's called "competitive advantages", and you should flood those messages on the website and highlight them.

TIP

06

Put your users in the center

Keep in mind not to write about the brand's advantages, but rather the advantages important to your target audience. For example, if you use an emerging technology, that in itself does not interest your target audience, it does not provide a competitive advantage, and there is no point writing about it. But if this technology enables your users to do things they couldn't do previously anywhere else, then that's the bit that interests them. **They don't care how you do things behind the scenes to get their desired result, it is the result itself that is important.**

A competitive advantage is only a real advantage if it provides your target audience with a distinct benefit that your competitors cannot provide them. So focus on what interests your target audience, not what interests you.

Example: Israel's Harvard

Israel has nine universities and about 50 colleges of higher education. Thus, when one of the leading academic institutions decided to upload a new website, brand differentiation was the key challenge. Naturally, the voice and tone needed to meet the challange, as did all the other elements of the site.

During the voice and tone design, the college admissions advisor described to me the mood of candidates when they access the site: On the one hand they are flooded with information from all the academic institutions plus other sources, and on the other hand they feel as if they don't have enough information to make a decision. They are subject to uncertainty, are confused and afraid to make the wrong choice about something that will determine the course the rest of their lives will take. **Based on what they will read on the website, they want to make a decision. They are searching for a clear answer to the question: why this institution? Why should I choose to study specifically here?** It is our job to provide a simple answer to this question and lay out, in a clear and transparent manner, the competitive advantages that our institution has over others, advantages that give real value and are important to future students.

On completing the voice and tone design, we had a list of the main competitive advantages that this academic institution has over the others in Israel: exceptional opportunities; social and professional networking; an international experience; personal attention, always, for everyone; a clear connection between theory and practice and their future careers; leading professors; a well groomed and intimate campus; values of social responsibility and giving to others; great people come and study here, and there are numerous extracurricular activities.

As we saw in the section on target audience hopes and dreams, you need to explicitly highlight the competitive advantages if you want to motivate and arouse curiosity in your target audience, and get them to feel that you have something unique that your competitors lack. For example, to motivate candidates to read more on the site, you can lay out for them the competitive advantages from the list we prepared, thus:

"*You are more than welcome to read about our excellent professors, the entrepreneurship programs that will open every door for you, and the beautiful green campus that will be your home for the next few years. Soon you'll discover that we offer an enormous range of opportunities for personal growth, more than anywhere else, and that our graduates are at the top of the 'highest earners' lists.*

We recommend you read about the international experience (why not start right away networking globally?), the top-notch students who will attend classes with you (and will become your friends for life), the practical curriculum (a career is waiting for you at the end of this road) and everything else we offer, apart from academia (endless experiences)."

After you have prepared your list of competitive advantages, you will no longer need to think time and again about how to persuade your users to stay on your site or select your product or service. Simply ask yourself what you are better at than your competition – and say it.

6. Define the relationship between the brand/ product and its users

The long-term relationship you wish to create

Everything you write needs to fit the relationship you aim to create, so as to establish and support it. Following are some examples of relationships:

- Friends
- Best friends
- Mentor and mentee
- People with a shared goal
- Parents
- Acquaintances
- Business partners
- Leader and led
- Salesperson and buyer
- Celeb and fan
- Couple
- Manager and personal assistant

Example: the two of us against the high cost of living

Every few years, someone invents a new way of buying online that dramatically reduces prices. Users of **B4Upay** go to this website after they've done the market research, register the lowest price they found, order the product, and give B4Upay the permission to buy it for them at an even lower price. The site promises not to charge the user's credit card if they can't obtain exactly the same product at a lower price than the one that the user found. Once the order is placed, B4Upay contacts many suppliers and asks them for their best quote for that product. Since the suppliers are aware that the product has been ordered and paid for, they are strongly motivated to close the deal straightaway. This leads them to lower the price for the guaranteed purchase to below its regular market price.

The relationship we wanted to create between B4Upay and its users was very well-defined: the users and the site are a team, fighting on the same side against the high cost of living, and act together to get the lowest price. To create such a relationship, we emphasized at every opportunity this cooperation and the fact that the site is working with them, and for them: "*Tell us the lowest price you found, and we'll get it for you at an even lower price*"; "*Now you can sit back and relax while we contact the best suppliers*"; "*Your item doesn't appear on the list? Give us a moment to find it for you*"; "*Thank you for ordering with B4Upay! We were happy to help you save money at the click of a button*".

Done: what a voice and tone design looks like

The voice and tone design can be written in a number of ways and styles, and each brand should produce a design that best suits its purposes.

For most brands and organizations it is enough to prepare an **internal working document** that summarizes all the sections we have discussed in this chapter. This will be used by the content people to create microcopy, copy or content.

But for a large corporation that prepares a voice and tone design as part of its branding effort, or that wishes to instill a new voice and tone to many writers on various media (site content, microcopy, social media, newsletter, contact with users via chat or email, and so on), it is worthwhile to produce a formal guide, branded, well designed and with many examples.

The format is also flexible: Word doc, Google doc, well designed presentation, a website – whatever best suits your needs.

On the Internet you can find many examples of voice and tone designs. Three of my favorites, and that differ considerably from each other, are the guide of the University of Leeds (https://goo.gl/JvvbZw), Mailchimp's guide (www.voiceandtone.com), and Salesforce's guide (read more about this one in Chapter 19). Read these three documents and learn a lot about written communication in general and voice and tone design in particular. Discover and enjoy.

The beacon and anchor: how to use the voice and tone design

Voice and tone design includes answers to two of the most important questions in writing: **what style** should you write in, and **about what**. That is why you should constantly refer to it when writing content for your website, app, newsletter or social media.

The beacon: When answering the question in **what style** to write, the voice and tone design sets the course, provides the character, and maintains

the voice and tone you'll use so that it fits the values and personality of your brand. Once you have a good understanding of the voice and tone design, you'll only need to consult it occasionally to brush up on the spirit of it and get into character.

The anchor: When dealing with messaging, the voice and tone design provides all the direction needed. Whenever you ask yourself how to motivate to action, what are the barriers and how to remove them, or what messages will do the best job, simply open and browse the voice and tone design – the answers will always be found there.

A personal note to end this chapter

The voice and tone design is not an end in itself. I have seen organizations that have created great voice and tone designs, beautifully decorated in the brand's colors, but failed to write according to what's in it.

Why does this happen? Writing is a habit that is hard to break. It is much easier to run with the usual words in familiar sentences, with our set thought processes. These threaten to return again and again.

The voice and tone design requires us to shake off old habits and start thinking afresh every time so that we write texts that fit our values, emphasize what's important to our users, and achieve the goals we have set.

The voice and tone design is only the beginning, and once we have completed it we should write accordingly – to get out of ourselves and write as if we are the brand.

It's challenging, fascinating, and it can improve your writing skills, taking you one large step forward.

So don't be tempted to return to your old ways. If you persevere, you'll quickly turn the voice and tone design to your new second nature.

The questions that will lead you

* Incorporate these questions in your branding process or conduct a group interview with key personnel.

Part 1. The Brand

The vision

- what change does the brand aspire to promote in the world? How will the world be a better place if it succeeds?

The answer lies in the **future**, and doesn't necessarily need to be attainable, but rather serve as a beacon to point the way and highlight the ideal outcome.

The mission

- What are you doing to fulfill this vision? How are you promoting the change?

The answer relates to the **present**, and should concisely describe your main ways and areas of action.

Values

- What values are important for the brand to maintain and act accordingly?
- What values are important for the brand to promote in the world?
- From these values, which are the **five** most important for you and the brand?
- Describe each value in a few words. What does it mean to you and what does it mean to the brand?

The personality of the brand

- If the brand was a person, and they walked into the room, what are the three things we'd think about them **at first sight**?
- If they sat down to coffee with us and we got to know them better, what else would we discover about them?
- If the brand was a person: How old are they, how do they dress, what is their marital status? When they open the newspaper, what section do they read first – Sports, Arts, News? Which type of smartphone do they use – Galaxy or iPhone? What are their hobbies and areas of interest?
- Do they have a sense of humor, and if so, when do they use it?
- What are they **absolutely not**?
- Which famous personality best represents your brand?

to your voice and tone

Part 2. The Target Audience

Needs and problems

- What **practical** problems are solved by your product/service?
- What **emotional** worry or stress will your product/service directly ease or solve for them?

Hopes and dreams

- What do your users want to happen because they used your product/service?
- What excites them about the idea of the product? What hope does it give them?
- What are the important values in their lives that will be furthered because they used your product?
- What promise does the brand offer? What does it promise to deliver over time?

Objections and concerns

- What could be the reasons that someone who needs your product or service, and who knows your website or app, won't end up using it? What could prevent them from trying it out?
- What are the main concerns users might have throughout the process (before starting, during and after)?
- What could confuse or not be fully clear to users?

Preferences

- Who are the main competitors of the brand?
- Does the brand have competative advantages **with genuine value for users**?
- Your users could have received a similar product or service elsewhere – why should they come to you?

The relationship between the brand and its users

- What is the relationship you want to create between your users and the brand?
- What do you want your users to feel when they are on the website or app, or in the brand's presence?
- What do your users like to think and feel about themselves? Which self-perceptions do you want to encourage?
- When asked about your brand, what do you want your users to say about it?

CHAPTER 2

CONVERSATIONAL WRITING

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why digital products need to talk

What is conversational writing

How to achieve this – rules and tricks

How much will you invest in your customer service representatives?

On the day that the digital product you are currently working on – website, app, SaaS, expert system, interactive kiosk, and so on – goes live, it will become an official representative of your brand to your customers. It will invite them to visit, greet them when they enter, show them the product or service, explain to them how it works, and bid them farewell when they leave.

What type of customer service rep do **you** like to find in front of you? What type of customer service rep will get **you** to trust that the brand really is good for you and that they see you? Personally, I much prefer reps with a sincere, natural smile and a genuine willingness to help; who are service-oriented, talk pleasantly in a manner that respects themselves, their brand and me; and who make little jokes that break the ice (and who react to nonsense on my part); in short, skilled representatives that provide me with such personal service that I totally forget that I'm one customer out of thousands.

To create in writing the experience of trust and closeness that flesh and blood customer service reps provide, you need to recognize that **the written words of the interface are actually your conversation with the customer.** And the more authentic, warm and human it sounds (yes, even if you are an insurance company), the better the customer experience will be.

To learn more about the benefits of conversational writing, even for traditionally dry industries, see Kate Moran's article "The impact of tone of voice on users' brand perception" (Nielsen Norman Group).

Are you ready to shatter a myth?

As we saw with the Clifford Nass experiments in the previous chapter, the more human the interface, and the more it abides by our social norms, the more users connect and respond to it, and are persuaded by what it offers them. Therefore, it is important that the voice and tone of the digital product is as close as possible to a human conversation.

In practice, most digital products are far from sounding human. The writing is often robotic, formalistic and meager, and creates no sense of personal attention. It offers a formal voice and tone that is rigid and aloof, where you can hardly find a smile, invitation, warmth or sincerity.

Examples

- Error. Please try again
- Log in to perform this action
- Enter a valid e-mail address
- If you do not have an account, you must create one and verify your identity on this page in order to continue and complete your transaction.

Why does it happen? Because from a young age we are taught to write and speak in two different styles. **The written style** is usually formal, more complicated, and considered respectable; whereas **the spoken style** is lighter, flowing, more commonplace, understood and accessible to all. In the past, written style was used in delayed communication, when the recipient read the content after receiving a real piece of paper (such as a letter), which often arrived many days after it was written. However, spoken style was only used in face-to-face communication or on the phone. In other words, it was used in personal communication where the message was heard at that moment and got an immediate response.

Then the internet came along and messed things up. Emails reduced the gap between delayed and immediate communication; the advent of instant messaging closed it almost entirely. When we communicate via Facebook or WhatsApp, are we writing or talking? And accordingly, what style do we use for a chat app: written or spoken?

Carmel Wiseman and Ilan Gonen presented a lovely answer in their book

Internet Hebrew (published in Hebrew by Keter, 2005). They expressed it as follows (page 21):

> ***The Internet breaks down the age old boundary between the written and spoken language, and gives rise to a third option: conversational writing.***

So we are not looking at a written or spoken language, but rather a new one that combines elements of both.

So, are you ready to shatter a myth?

You are allowed to write as you speak, using a spoken style.

But we can't talk to our customers using incorrect language!

True! No way should you speak to your customers in substandard language, but the spoken style is not necessarily substandard. When you are holding a formal conversation with your boss, customer or important supplier, you use the spoken style, and it's not inadequate.

What's the difference? An inadequate style is rough, riddled with mistakes and leads to misunderstandings. The sentence structure is confusing, and it's inconsistent and sloppy. That is not what I mean. Spoken style is polite, respectful, and grammatically correct (unless you purposely decide otherwise – like with intelligent use of slang); it is consistent, precise and unambiguous. Don't be negligent or confused, conversational writing needs to be excellent, but excellence doesn't imply rigidity and aloofness.

In other words, interfaces can and should be both: both representative and pleasant; both professional and smiling; both respectful and relating as equals. Look around you, humans are like that too.

Yes, I know, in reality it's not that simple. Many of those who write for digital products have a hard time giving up these distinctions between the two language styles, and the concept that one is respectful and the other isn't. Thus they stick to the formal written style, even when the character and style of the actual product requires a different voice and tone entirely. Sometimes, it is only a matter of not having the right tools for using conversational writing. In the following pages I provide tools that will help you with that.

Don't write something you wouldn't say out loud

Even if your brand is really serious, such as a big bank, insurance company or government office, you still don't need to make users feel that you have sent your lawyers to talk to them. It is better to send the customer service rep. You don't want to make your users feel alienated or threatened, rather give them the feeling that the product is a worthy substitute for a human attentive customer service rep.

Written style includes words or phrases you simply wouldn't say out loud, even in a formal situation. To create the experience of a service-oriented authentic conversation, you need to refrain from using formal stiff phrases. **The rule is: don't write what you wouldn't say out loud**. In the following examples I have underlined words that I recommend you remove from your digital dictionary. In their place I offer an alternative in suitable conversational writing.

- Enter the phone number you would like to dial >> What number do you want to call?
- If you have previously registered for this site, please provide your email address and password >> Already signed up? enter your email and password
- For verification purposes, an email will be sent to the email address you provided >> A verification email is on its way to your inbox (or more formally: was sent to your email address)
- It is also possible to make a purchase by phone >> You can also call in your billing info
- The products you wish to purchase >> Your shopping list
- Your sign in information is detailed below >> Your email and password are:
- In the event that you forgot your password >> If you forgot your password

A sentence isn't constructed that way

Two other things we do when writing, that we tend not to do when speaking, are related to sentence structure.

1. Use the active rather than the passive voice

When writing formally you might come up with the following sentence: **Please select the preferred payment method**.

But "preferred" is the passive form and we wouldn't put it this way when talking out loud (the preferred method instead of someone preferring it). We'd simply ask the person standing in front of us in the active form:

How would you like to pay?

Or request:

Please select a payment method.

The active structure of the spoken sentence is better because it focuses on the person you are talking to. So always use it when writing microcopy.

2. Don't drop the connecting words

When we talk we connect the parts of the sentence together using prepositions, so that it's clearer and because it is more natural and personal that way. But in writing these connections seem to disappear. This makes the sentence more complex and hinders the flow of the message.

Examples

- Order details >> **Your** order details
- Close map >> Close **the** map
- Number of items in basket >> Number of items in **your** basket
- Save settings >> Save **these** settings
- Select item >> Select **an** item

Sentences written using passive voice and without connecting words sound forced or awkward, and hinder understanding. So write in active voice and make sure to properly connect all the parts of your sentence.

Tricks for excellent conversational writing

1. Just say it

Are you undecided about how to phrase something? Imagine the user is standing right in front of you, how would you tell them that? Try to be as natural and spontaneous as you can, without processing or structuring beforehand. It helps when two people do this – one asks and the other replies with the first answer that comes to mind.

2. Read it out loud

Does it sound natural? Does it flow? Does it sound as if a real human said it? Great.

3. Avoid boring formats

What's fun about a real conversation is that you never know what to expect, and you can't have the exact same conversation twice. To make your texts feel like part of a real conversation, you need to converse. Instead of using the usual formats (*The transaction completed successfully; Please wait; Error, try again*, and so on), ask yourself: what do I **really** want to say to the user in this specific context?

4. Ask questions

Questions create a feeling that the conversation flows, as if someone asks and the other responds. So instead of "*Type the email address you want us to send the password to*", you could say "*Where should we send the link*?" This form of sentence also propels the user to act because humans find it difficult to leave a question unanswered when they can answer it. But you need to be careful not to ask too many questions, because then it sounds like an exhausting interview.



6 attributes of conversational writing

- ✓ Addressing the user directly
- ✓ Natural
- ✓ Short and to the point
- ✓ Using everyday common words
- ✓ Using active voice
- ✓ Flowing

TIP

07

Slang - allowed or forbidden?

Language spiced with slang sounds more human and authentic. That's great, but your digital product, like any customer service rep, needs to stay representative. So you have to keep within the framework of mainstream and acceptable slang. How do you know if the word or phrase is acceptable? If you write in your mother tongue, you will know. Trust yourself and your instincts. If you write in a language different from your mother tongue, have the text checked by someone who is a native speaker, to make sure that the slang used is light, gentle and representative.

Second, don't use culturally specific slang unless writing for a mono culture.

And if it is not obvious: slang that is hurtful, sexist or racist is completely off limits.

CHAPTER 3

MICROCOPY THAT MOTIVATES ACTION

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Benefit is the greatest motivator
- Excited users are more prone to act
- Sometimes you just need to open a door
- Social proof works

4 Important principles to motivate action with writing

Just before we look at each UI component in depth, here are 4 principles that will help you motivate to action with every component, and in fact wherever you write to your customers, even outside the digital products.

1. Talk about the value, not the method

It only takes a few seconds for a user to decide if the page, website or specific action is relevant to them. That means that you only have a few seconds to make clear to them the value of staying and performing the action. For that to happen, everything needs to be extremely simple, clear and persuasive. Explicitly point out: what they'll receive from using your product or service, what problems you are solving for them, or how it will better their lives. If you created a voice and tone design (see Chapter 1), this is the time to open it and look inside. Everything is written there.

How do you do that? Change the focus of your texts to what users will gain rather than what they need to do to benefit.

Examples

Instead of the heading: A variety of tools to properly manage your finances

Write: Put your debts behind you

Or: Get rid of your debt once and for all

Instead of the heading: A new way to purchase a second-hand car

Write: Buy your next car with peace of mind

Or: Second-hand car – no hassle, and with a full warranty

Ask yourself: What will change for the people who have used your product or service? What can they do that they couldn't before? What problems have you solved for them?

And talk about that.

Note that we are naturally inclined to talk about our brand, product or service: how good it is, what it provides and its relative advantages. These are indeed important questions that need answering, but when you want users to act, stop talking about yourself, and **talk only about them**, not what you give, but what they receive; not how **you** solve their problems and fulfil their dreams, but how **they** will get rid of their problems and fulfil their dreams.

Sometimes it is entirely a technical matter. Check who is the subject of the sentence, who are you talking about.

Instead of writing: Registration will allow you to quickly go through checkout (the subject is registration)

Write: Sign up to checkout quickly

And instead of writing: The gift card will let you buy things in 25 selected stores

Write: With this gift card you can shop in 25 selected stores

2. Amuse me, excite me

Clifford Nass (see Chapter 1) discovered in his research that **humor** makes people feel better about themselves, like and appreciate the interface more, and especially, cooperate more and accept its suggestions. With that being said, he emphasizes that it is important not to use humor that is too intellectual or to use a complex play on words that can leave some of your users out of the picture and make them feel stupid. Here too, as with slang, avoid using racial, sexist or otherwise offensive humor, and never refer to pain or hardship endured by the users. Stay within the boundary of good innocent humor (see the 7 guidelines on page 32).

Excited users are also easy to motivate: they are more focused on the half full glass, willing to take more risks, and are ready for action. Actually, Nass found that they want to do something so much that they prefer to make any decision rather than no decision at all. So if you succeeded in exciting your users, the conversion is just around the corner.

3. Respect your users: invite them to act

When I'm talking about a Call to Action, I sometimes call it an **Invitation** to Act. Why? Maybe because I myself don't like it when people tell me what to do (on the contrary, I immediately don't want to do it). I prefer that they clearly point out the benefits to me of taking the action, open the door for me and let me decide if I want to enter.

Aggressive service or selling techniques work in the short term, but don't serve the relationship that we want to create on websites or apps. Our objective is usually to establish a relationship of trust, continuity, and an emotional connection to the brand; provide pleasant memories and create a long-term relationship, not just for this encounter, but for continuous use, forever. Think about the well-known brands you love most – their appeal, elegance, and the sense of mutual respect.

How do you do that? Explain to your users how they benefit from performing the desired action, then invite them to do it. Write in an active and attractive but not aggressive voice, and leave out the dirty tricks (see tip 08).

Ask yourself if the invitation provides your users with something that is important to them, if it respects them, and if it fits the type of relationship you want to create with them in the long term.

4. Social proof: and what if everyone jumps off the bridge?

Humans are social animals, and sometimes it's amazing to see how much so. Social proof is a psychological phenomenon where people decide how to act based on the actions of others (also known as the herd mentality). For example, we'll always prefer to visit a crowded restaurant rather than a deserted one, and we'll "like" those statuses that have already received a few likes rather than a status no one has reacted to yet.

The fact that others were at this same crossroad, and decided to act in a certain way, reduces the level of uncertainty in the situation, creates confidence, and makes us feel that we belong to an imaginary community of those who've already taken this action.

Research has found that social proof dramatically increases the conversion rate (take a look at the book **Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion** by Professor Robert Cialdini). Positive social proof can be placed right next to buttons so that they act as click triggers (we'll deal with this more in Chapter 11 that focuses on buttons), or as part of the call to action at the beginning of the process. Many more examples of social proof will be presented later in the guide.

Types of social proof

- **Numbers tell** – How many people have already bought this product today or in total; how many people use this service; how many people are looking at this right now; how many people have downloaded the guide; how many hours was this video watched cumulatively.
- **Concrete facts** – The name of the last person who used the service; in which state the product was bought most. In general, the more concrete the social proof (name, photos, quotes), the more reliable it is.
- **Opinions, reviews and testimonials** of other users.
- **Ratings**, for example using stars or quotes from rating sites such as TripAdvisor.
- **Official awards and good reviews in the press.**
- **Social media** – buttons to share or like, with the number of users that have clicked them so far.
- **Other customers** – the logos or names of respected customers who already use the product or service.

TIP

08

No thanks, I want to stay stupid

A trend that is currently popular is the use of *confirmshaming* or *manipulink* – buttons or links that seek to provoke self-doubt and undermine user confidence, telling them that if they don't do as asked – they are apparently stupid.

Examples

- No thanks, I want my sales to remain low
- No thanks, I don't want to save money
- No thanks, I prefer to miss this opportunity

Whenever I see such a button, I'm amazed. What logic brings brands to make their users feel bad about themselves? The answer of course lies in the logic of conversion rate. The more users click the button, the better the sales. This works, but only in the short term. In the long term, you're sacrificing your credibility and users' trust. The users will remember that their last interaction with your product left them feeling stupid, or that they did something they didn't want to do just because you told them they would be stupid not to.

When you write microcopy, be on the users' side. Make them feel good about themselves, don't belittle them. Create a place that they love to visit and return to. This might result in a reduced number of immediate conversions, but also with many more loyal users that return whenever they need your product or service.

So instead of writing buttons that callously push your emotional ones, invest a bit more in motivating to action through highlighting value.

PART 2: EXPERIENCE AND ENGAGEMENT

Every word is an opportunity

In the first part of the book, which dealt with voice and tone design, we saw how to define the main messages that we need to share with our users so that they are motivated to action. What advantages are worth stressing, which concerns we should address, how we want them to feel when in our company, and so on. In part 2, you'll see how to actually do this on your digital product.

In each chapter I'll cover one popular element that we find in sites and apps, and how we can turn a regular page to one full of character, a page that is distinctive to your brand, one that communicates directly to your users' hearts and motivates them to act willingly.

In the following chapters, you'll see that every word, every page and every form on your site is an opportunity to prove to your users that they are wanted and loved, to increase their activity and to establish your brand's differentiation. Every heading, every field and every button, even the most annoying errors, are an opportunity to surprise your users, to excite them, and to show that you thought about them and that you have something really, really good to offer them. Within each chapter you'll find clear principles that are easy to understand, that you can use when writing, and that you can implement immediately.

Chapters in part 2:

4. Sign up, login and password recovery
5. Sign up for a newsletter
6. Contact us
7. Error messages
8. Success messages
9. Empty states
10. Placeholders
11. Buttons
12. 404 errors: page not found
13. Waiting time

CHAPTER 4

SIGN UP, LOGIN AND PASSWORD RECOVERY

IN THIS CHAPTER

An excellent sign up form in 3 steps

Signing up using a social media account

Login for registered users

Password recovery

Sign up forms

When you ask users to sign up to your digital product, you are basically telling them that this won't be their last visit, and that you expect to create some sort of relationship with them.

They have at least two good reasons **not** to sign up:

First, signing up usually includes a form or connecting using a social media account. Users really hate filling out forms. It takes time and requires typing, they'll be asked to provide personal details, they'll need to remember, or create, yet another password, and they also risk an unintended commitment or payment. The ability to connect using a social media account has become widely acceptable, but even here users sometimes prefer to skip the registration because of privacy concerns.

Second, a relationship is a commitment, and who likes to commit to something if they don't really have to? Why should users register on a site if they can simply visit it and then peacefully carry on with their lives?

How much do users hate to register? A lot! They'll even pass on the items they put in a shopping cart, and then look for that exact same item elsewhere, if they are forced to register before checkout. After a large company removed the requirement to register before purchasing anything, their profits rose by $300,000,000 a year (read the article "The $300 Million Button" by Jared M. Spool). That's how much people hate to register.

If so, whether the registration is optional or mandatory, it's in our interest to remove these obstacles so that users will sign up willingly, and will understand why **they** want a relationship with us, and how signing up will benefit **them**.

The following form, similar to dozens of others on the Internet, does **not** help users. There is nothing to support a decision by a user to sign up or not, and it doesn't say anything that will stop them from giving up and leaving. The site simply displays a form, which they hate, and doesn't say a word. So why should they sign up?



It's not enough to design and display a sign up form, you need to also motivate users to register. And to achieve that, follow these three steps:

1. Change the title

Never call your users "users", so don't write **New user**, **Existing user**, or **Login for registered users**. It's essential to write **Sign up**, **Register** or **Create an account**, so users understand where they are and what they're expected to do here, but you shouldn't be just technical. Appeal directly to your users and welcome them using conversational writing.

Add something like:

- Nice to meet you
- You haven't signed up yet? You're in the right place.

- Good to see you :)
- Join now and start to... (edit photos, find friends, make an album, or whatever it is users do with your product)
- New here?
- Let me in!
- Not a member? Let's fix that!

On the other hand, don't take the creativity too far. You want users looking to register to know that they have arrived at the right place.

Note that I only encourage you to spice up the title of your sign up form. Don't alter the **sign up / log in** links that appear in the navigation bar. Users are looking for exactly those words, and every change will make them harder to find. Be creative only on the actual sign up page.

2. Tell your users why it's worth it for them to sign up

Even if registration is required, give your users good reasons to invest the next two minutes of their lives in registering on your product. First, prepare for yourself a list of all the advantages users have after signing up that they won't have if they don't sign up. Then, at the top of the form, or next to it, write one crucial advantage or 2-3 important advantages in a bulleted list. Don't go overboard, 2-3 is enough.

Examples

- Fast checkout
- Create a wish list
- Only enter your details once
- Track orders, delivery, and purchase history
- Track the progress of a process
- Access to a restricted area of the site, or to special features
- Monetary perk available only to registered users

Don't be careless, select significant advantages that will really benefit your users.

3. Remove the obstacles

Why don't **you** register on every site you visit? Let me guess:

1. Because of the time and effort involved in filling out the form.
2. Because you don't want to give them your email and be swamped by spam.
3. And sometimes because you are worried they'll request payment at some later stage.

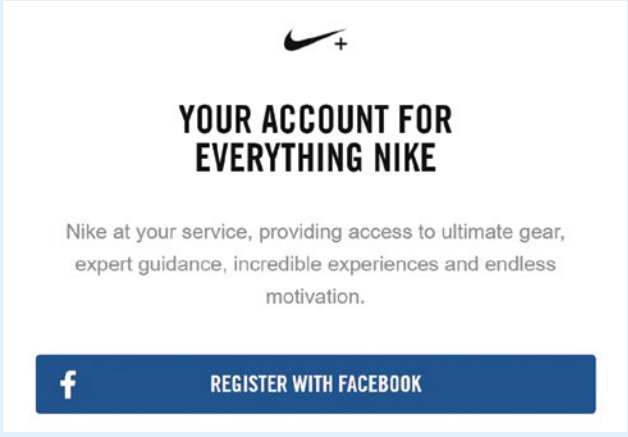
All users fear this, so talk to them and ease their fears. Clearly promise them that the sign up process is short and simple, that you won't pass their email address on to anyone else, and that you won't send them too many emails yourself.

Finally, don't forget the button, the success message and the error messages

Signing up for a digital product is one of your most important processes. Don't forget to add a call to action on the button (**see tip 19 in Chapter 11**), and an excellent success message that makes users feel that signing up was the right thing to do (**see Chapter 8**). Naturally, you also need to provide clear and pleasant error messages (**see Chapter 7**).

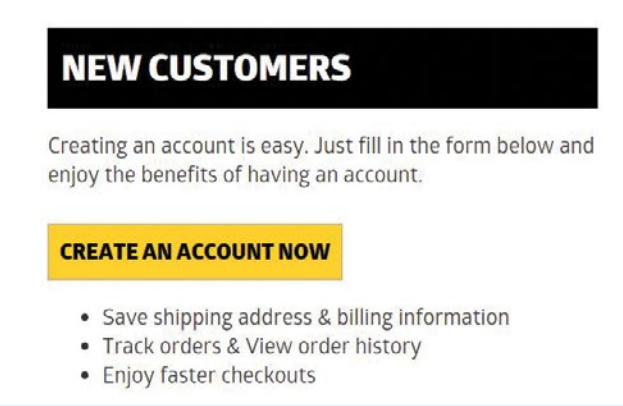
Examples

Nike offers a lot of sporting and personal value, conveyed in a dynamic and convincing way that sport lovers understand.



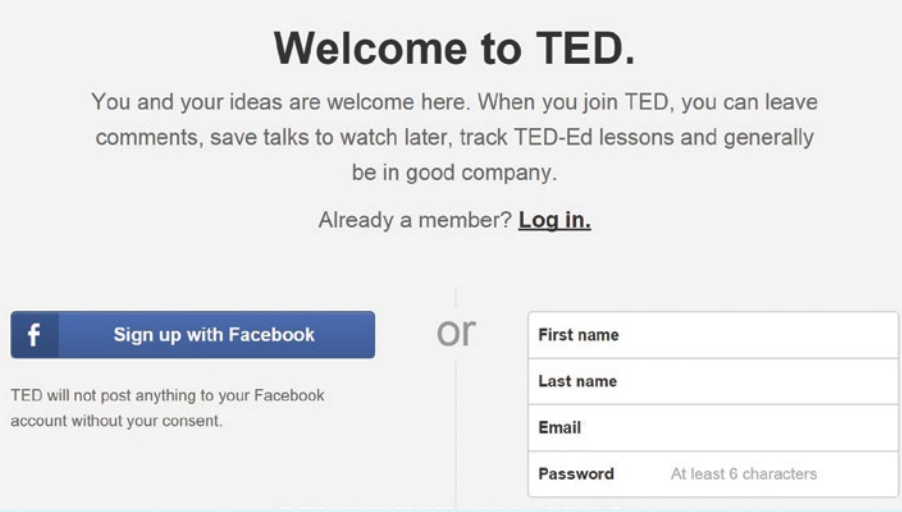
www.nike.com

Life is Good, the T-shirt site, provides three classic reasons to register in a bulleted list, and points out that the process is easy. However, they could spice up the title a bit and make it more fun to sign up.



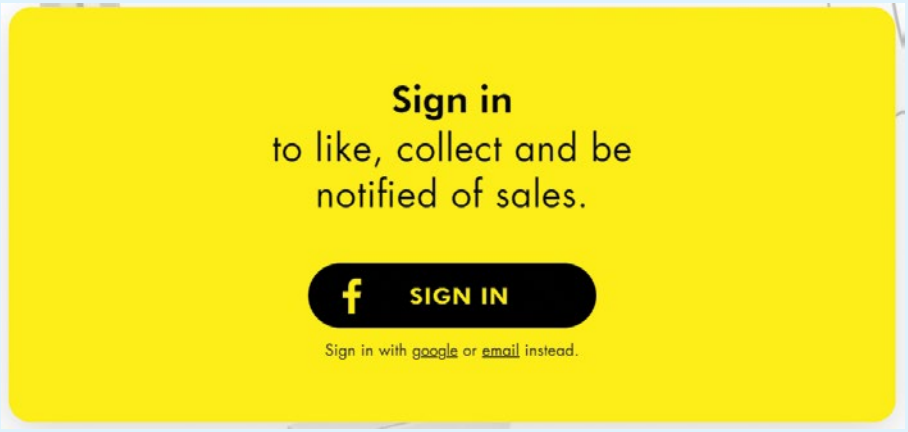
www.lifeisgood.com

TED. The title and first sentence work well together and give users the feeling that they are really welcome. Then come the benefits (carefully selected), presented in a simple and clear style. For those signing up with their Facebook account, there is also a promise not to post anything without their permission (see more about signing up using social media accounts later in this chapter).



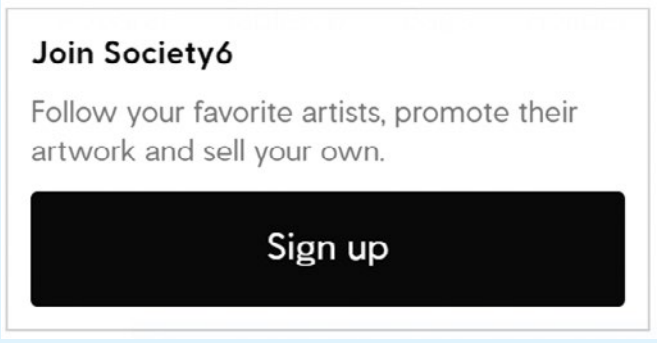
www.ted.com

Thieve curates special items from AliExpress. Their sign up call to action is super straightforward and to the point. I love it. But note that because of the design (black button for Facebook connection, no form), the unusual flow (signing in is actually signing up), and the laconic phrasing, users might not fully understand that by clicking, they connect their social media account with this website they just encountered. I think it's worth mentioning it more clearly.



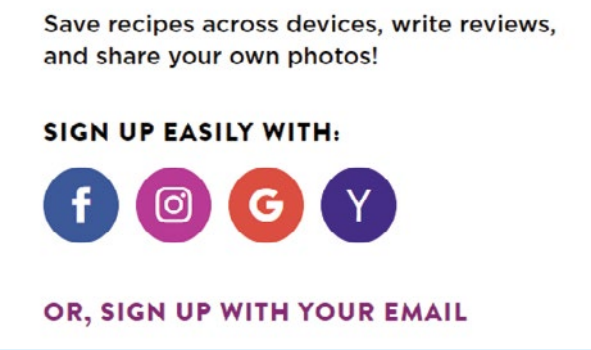
www.thieve.co

Society6 also deals with designed items. The benefits they offer users to encourage them to sign up are part of their model that supports artists. In this call to action they trust users to have the same love for art and for the ones making it.



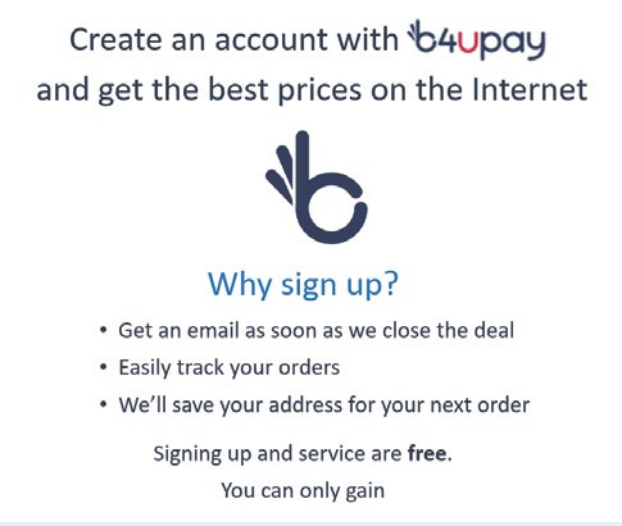
www.society6.com

food.com. You don't need a title, you can get straight down to business. In this way, instead of alarming users by declaring that this is where they register, the users read benefits that are important to them, and thus keep on reading. If you're into food on social media – this is an offer you can't turn down.



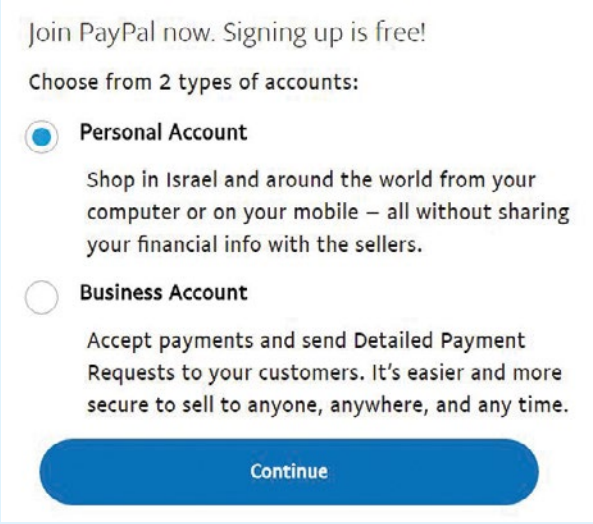
www.food.com

B4Upay is an Israeli company we already mentioned in Chapter 1. Even though signing up to their service is required, they explain why it's good **for the users** and how filling out the form will make their lives easier later. And at the bottom, they promise that signing up and the service they provide is totally free.



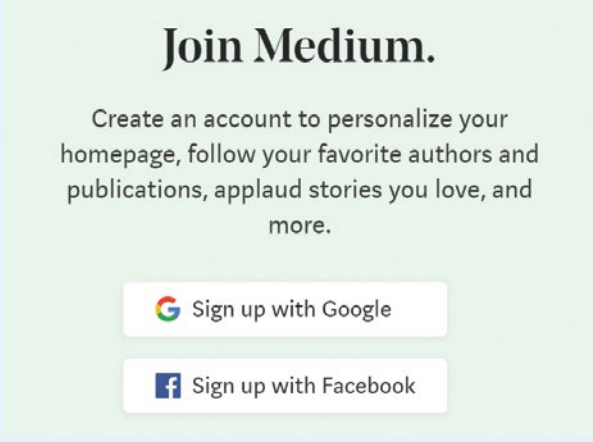
www.b4upay.com (Design: KRS | Translated from Hebrew)

PayPal tells their users what they can do after they have created an account, things that they couldn't do beforehand. They clearly explain what will change and how their users' lives will improve after signing up, and that's an excellent way to present the main value. The title also assures the user that signing up is free, thus removing the payment barrier.



www.paypal.com

Medium, the blogging platform, describes the many benefits registered users have over non-registered ones. These benefits are specific to the platform, and crucial for fully enjoying it.



www.medium.com

TIP

09

Register vs. Sign up vs. Join

Sign up indicates to the user that this is a simple and quick digital process; whereas **Register** would be more appropriate when the user needs to fill out a form and provide loads of details, such as for a bank, health insurance or a TV provider.

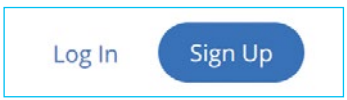
I recommend using **Join** if you are trying to create a sense of community, and not just invite individuals to receive content or services.

Sign in vs. Log in

You need to think about not only how the user joins or registers, but also how they access the site later. It's preferable not to use **Sign up** and **Sign in** side by side. Users find this confusing and need to stop for a second, and we want to make access as easy and intuitive as possible. So if you use **Sign up**, pair it with **Log in**. Different colors can be helpful too. These are the links on **PayPal**:



And these are **Coursera's**:



Log in vs. Login

Note that **Log in** phrase is **two** words, but when referring to the page or process it becomes one word – Login page or Login process.

One last point, if you use **Register**, make sure your text talks about registering or registration to ensure consistency. The same goes for when you use **Sign up** or **Join** – just keep it consistent.

Signing up using a social media account

Signing up via social media lets users register without filling out a form, and enables us to get much more information about them – a win-win situation. Today, this is considered the standard, and in many digital products this is the main sign up method.

Still, users need to give up a certain measure of privacy, therefore, at the top of the page, you should still write about why it's worth the user's while to click the sign up button.

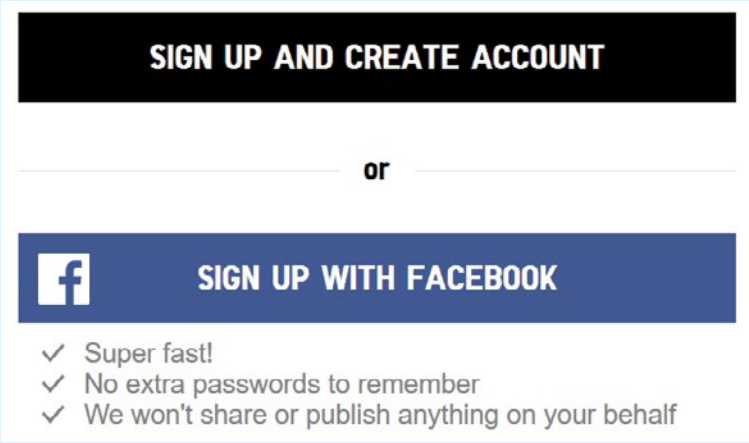
Because the concern over privacy is a real problem, and because we ask the users to provide much more information than just their email, it is wise to add at least one of the following:

1. **A promise that you won't publish anything on behalf of the users.** I know, this appears again, immediately after, in the Facebook settings; but if you want your users to get that far, you need to write it here also, next to the sign up button.
2. **The benefits of signing up via the social media:** It's the fastest, simplest, and most up-to-date way.
3. **Your users' privacy is important to you and you will do everything in your power to protect it.**

Today, in most cases, there isn't enough (or even any) mention of these issues. In the near future maybe we can give it up, because this way of registering will be so commonplace, but as for now it is still important and necessary. I saw with my own eyes users give up on registering using their social media accounts only because the site didn't promise to guard their privacy.

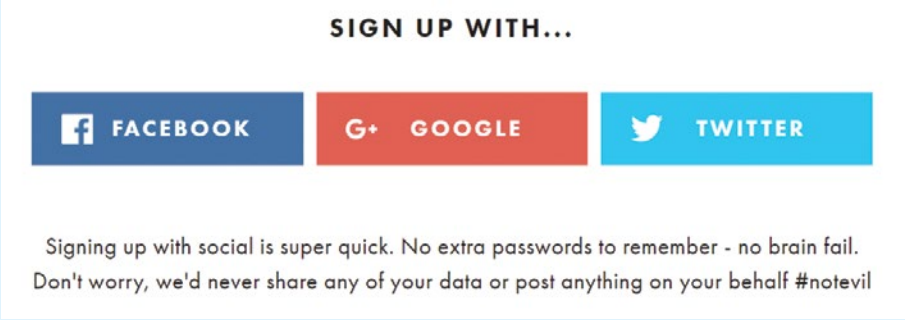
Examples

Stating the benefits of signing up with social media and alleviating concerns. **Uniqlo** does it right:



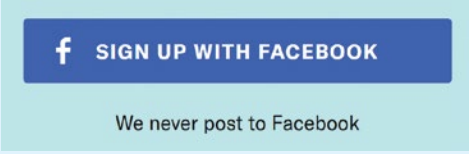
www.uniqlo.com

#notevil. **Asos** has you covered too:



www.asos.com

OkCupid is short and direct. The promise never to post anything in the name of a user is extremely important to sensitive products such as dating, diet, pregnancy and birth, medical, and financial products.



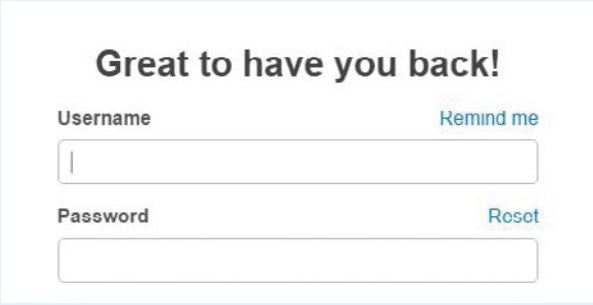
www.okcupid.com

Login for registered users

Returning registered users can be seen as regular customers of the website or app; and just as in brick-and-mortar shops regular customers are welcomed with warmth, so they should be treated online. Instead of writing only **Log in** or **Registered users**, you can say something that will raise a smile and show your users that you are happy they chose to return, that they are welcome and loved here.

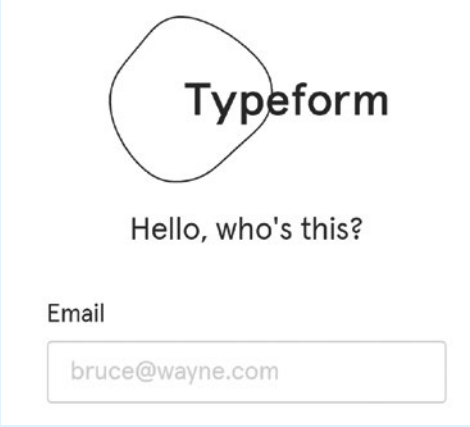
Examples

envato are glad you returned.



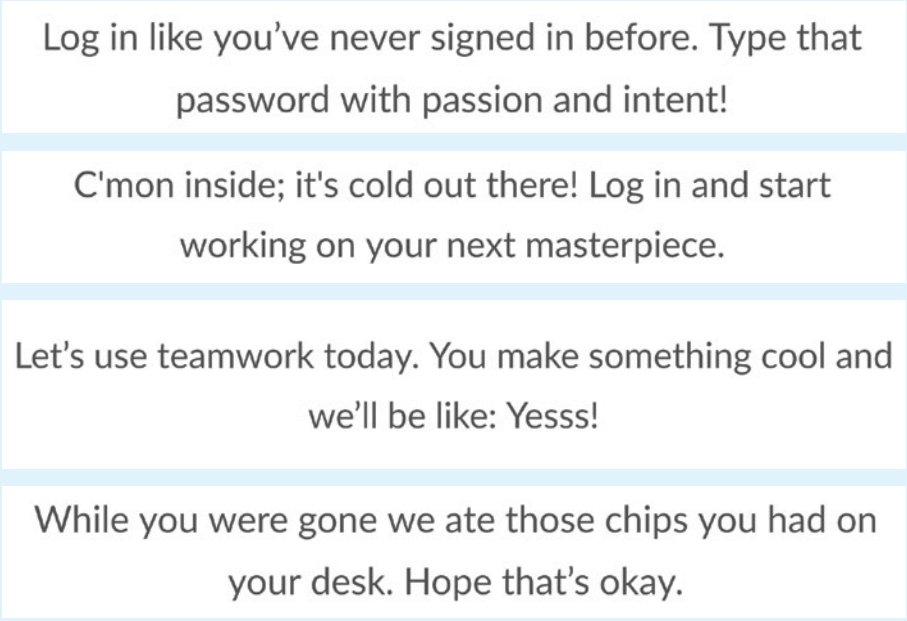
www.envato.com

Typeform makes users feel like they just knocked on a friend's door.



www.typeform.com

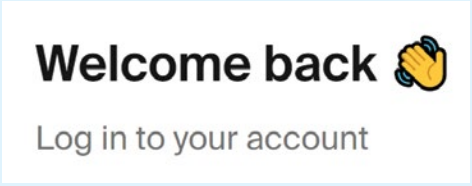
PicMonkey writes something funny on top of the login form, and changes it each time the user comes back. LOL



www.picmonkey.com

But there's no need to go this far. It may even become annoying after a few times. So just be nice, not too clever.

emojicom is a feedback service based on emojis. So, it's only natural...



www.emojicom.io

Password recovery

Users who want to log in but have forgotten their password are not interested in anything else except getting a new password. This is not the place to be clever, and there's no need to elaborate. Keep it short, simple and effective.

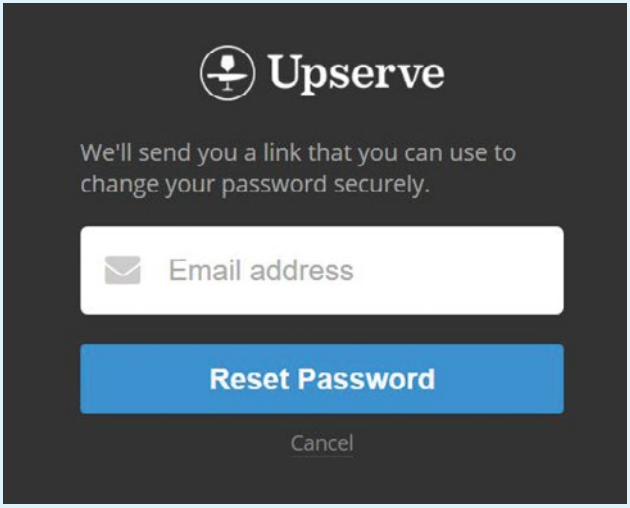
Examples

Tumblr proves that extra words are superfluous when most of your users already know their way around.



www.tumblr.com

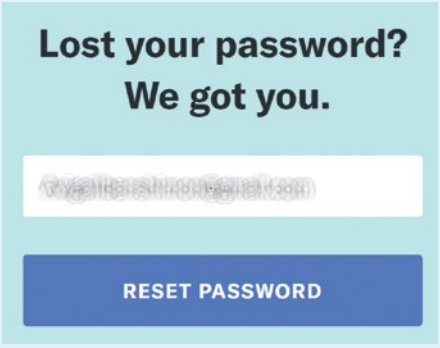
Upserve. If you are concerned that your users don't fully understand how it works, you can add a short explanation.



www.upserve.com

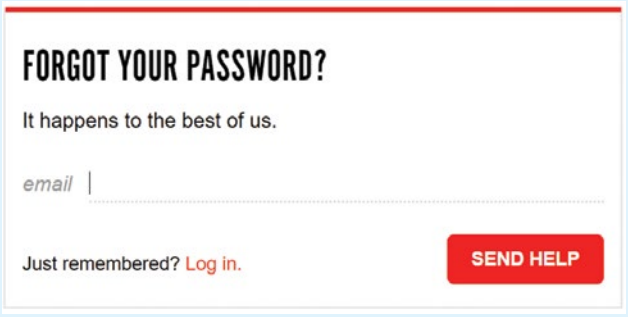
You can still soften the process just a tiny, tiny bit without burdening the user.

OkCupid reassures users they can always trust them to be there.

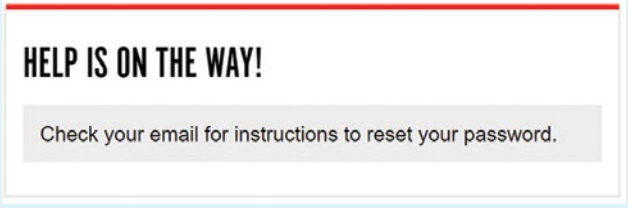


www.okcupid.com

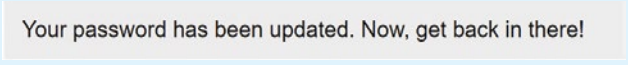
TeuxDeux, the to-do app, shows empathy and gives a helping hand.



After clicking *Send help*:



Success:



www.teuxdeux.com

CHAPTER 5

SIGN UP FOR A NEWSLETTER

IN THIS CHAPTER

3 styles of CTAs to sign up for a newsletter

A persuasive invitation in 3 steps

Why should I sign up?

To you it is obvious why a newsletter is necessary. It delivers value to your customers over an extended period of time, keeps them aware of your brand, and develops a relationship with them based on familiarity and trust; it keeps them up-to-date on new developments, and of course – it sells. As a result, nearly every business tries really hard to generate a mailing list and distribute a newsletter on a regular basis.

The problem is that however much we want our users to sign up, they likewise don't want to. They see it as an invitation to spam them and receive piles of unwanted information. They need a really, really good reason to risk signing up.

The invitation to sign up for the newsletter appears in a variety of ways: a pop-up displayed when the user accesses the product or after they have scrolled down a bit, a check box when signing up, a form in the footer or on the side bar, or all of the above (see tip 10).

Invitations shown today can be divided into three main categories:

1. The boring

A drab one sentence invitation using a well-worn template that can appear on any website, and doesn't arouse any interest.

Examples

- To sign up for our newsletter, please provide the following details:
- Sign up for our newsletter!
- Sign up here and get our newsletter delivered directly to your inbox
- Join the X mailing list

Even if you put such a sentence in a beautiful well-designed pop-up, you need to remember that your users see a dozen similar pop-ups each day, and they need to decide which one they should sign up for. Why would such a sentence cause the user to give you their email address, something they guard zealously? When have **you** recently signed up for such a newsletter?

2. The keeping-you-up-to-date

Receive updates, be the first to know, stay in the loop and don't miss out! How many variations there are to the promise, and they all say basically nothing.

Examples

- Don't miss a post! Enter your email address to receive notifications of new posts by email.
- Be the first to learn about new products, sales, and promotions!
- Sign up for our newsletter and be the first to know about coupons and special offers.

On the one hand, if the users are already on your site, they know what it has to offer, right? And if you offer to keep them up-to-date via the newsletter, they'll know what will be updated, right? And they'll definitely want to never miss a thing, yes? Well actually no. That is to say, they basically know what the site deals with, they generally want to stay updated, and they more or less know about what they will be updated, but that isn't enough.

Users see these update invitations, like the first boring category, all the time. The invitation could appear on practically any site, and it leaves the users guessing how they'll benefit from signing up for that specific newsletter.

But our users don't have the spare time, patience, or overview of your business to understand by themselves what you offer in the newsletter and how they benefit from it. You need to explicitly tell them.

3. The persuasive

The invitation to sign up for the newsletter must be exactly like any other sales pitch. Do you want your users to give you their email? Give them a good reason why! A good reason is one that is good for **them**, one that will add something to their lives, and will change them even if ever so slightly. Don't present a general and vague reason that anyone else could have written, rather tell them exactly what they'll receive in their inbox from your specific newsletter that is worthwhile and help them overcome their aversion to providing their email address.

If you have created a voice and tone design, you already know what the users want to happen to them as a result of using your product or service. Use this knowledge to phrase your invitation.

TIP

10

Excuse me, have we met?

If you display the newsletter invitation pop-up immediately after users land on your site, it is like a complete stranger coming up to them from out of nowhere and offering a relationship. Strange, right? At this stage they have no reason to sign up, they don't know you yet, and they certainly don't trust you.

Invite users to sign up for the newsletter only after they more or less understand what you have to offer them. For example, after spending a minute browsing the site, after they have read about half a post, perhaps only after they access another post, or scrolled all the way down to the footer. The point is that you should have some sort of an indication that the users understand what the site is all about.

This is how you can motivate users to sign up for the newsletter

1. Change the title

Sign up for our newsletter or **join our mailing list** are not effective titles because they tell users what we are **asking** them to do (sign up) rather than what we are **giving** them. In other words, they tell the users the road they will be taking rather than the benefit they will be getting. So write the value the newsletter provides in the title, tell them up front how it will alter their lives.

For example, if your newsletter deals with relationships, instead of writing *"sign up for our newsletter"*, write:

> **Were you told that a successful relationship is hard work?**
>
> **Make it an exciting adventure!**

2. Tell your users what's in it for them if they sign up

Only after your users understand from the title that the offer is interesting, can you invite them to sign up and tell them what they'll receive. Updates, news or the latest offers are not enough. Be more specific and relevant to your unique brand. What **exactly** are you planning to send your users? Naturally you should choose those elements that you think will interest your users most. Remember that you are selling your brand's newsletter, so this is the place to demonstrate your marketing writing skills.

Offer benefits that users can immediately understand and say:

Yes, that's something I really want to know. I'd be happy to receive this in my inbox.

Continuing with the previous example of a newsletter about relationships:

> **Were you told that a successful relationship is hard work?**
>
> **Make it an exciting adventure!**
>
> Sign up now and every week you'll get:
>
> - Tips on rejuvenating relationships that you won't find elsewhere
> - Exclusive interviews with leading couples counselors
> - Recommended romantic spots, and more

3. Remove the obstacles

Spam is the most common obstacle that stops users from signing up for a mailing list. And spam for your users is not only emails that they didn't ask for, but also too many emails that they did request (i.e. yours). To deal with these two concerns:

a. Promise them that the frequency of your newsletter is low, and you can even mention how often.

b. Promise that the email addresses are well guarded and that their privacy is important to you.

Finally, don't forget the button, the success message and the error messages

Signing up for a newsletter is like any other digital process. You need to provide text for the button so that it motivates the user to click it (**see Chapter 11**), and an excellent success message that will leave your users curious and expectant to receive their first newsletter (**see Chapter 8**). It is also worthwhile to invest a bit in writing a gracious error message, in case the user made a mistake when entering the email address **(see Chapter 7**).

TIP

11

Free content! Download now!

If you offer free content for download or by email, the invitation to download works in exactly the same way as when signing up for a newsletter.

1. Provide an attractive title that offers a specific value.
2. Tell the users about the benefits they'll receive from the content – how their lives will improve after reading it.
3. Guarantee privacy and that you won't pass on their email address.



Are you concerned your users won't read? Don't worry

The secret of persuasion is to always tell your users how they'll benefit. Michael Aagaard of **ContentVerve** tried it on his site and published his findings in the article "How to Write High-Converting Sign-Up Form Copy".

The control form had:

> **Get Fresh Updates from ContentVerve.com**

The non-generic version had:

> **Get Fresh Updates**
> • Case Studies & test results
> • How-to videos & articles
> • Podcasts w/thought leaders

Actually, Aagaard only provided a very short list of what his users would actually receive if they read his newsletter (and I assume he carefully selected those items that most interested his customers).

What was the impact? An 83.75% increase in sign-ups.

Worth it, don't you think?

TIP

12

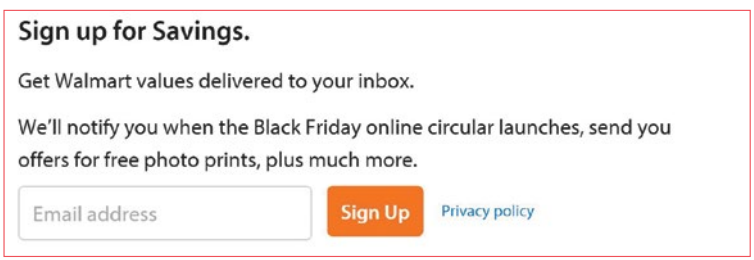
But we really do only offer deals....

If your newsletter is strictly a sales channel, and simply provides updates about discounts and offers, then first of all you should think about upgrading it to be more magazine-like and include added value, such as recommendations from professionals ("*our stylist will turn you into the office star*"), an interesting list that you have assembled ("*the five top restaurants last month*"), interviews, success stories, and even in-depth articles.

If you don't have the time or budget to change the newsletter, then at least add a few specifics to the sign up form. Remind the users of the brand and make it your unique invitation. For example:

- Not only "*You'll receive a discount*", but rather "*Receive a discount on [brand's name] new awesome summer collection*".
- Don't just write "*We'll send you offers*", but rather "*Receive special offers for the best rooms in the most sought after hotels*".
- Don't write simply "*Updates*", but rather "*Receive updates on new job openings before they are uploaded on the site*".

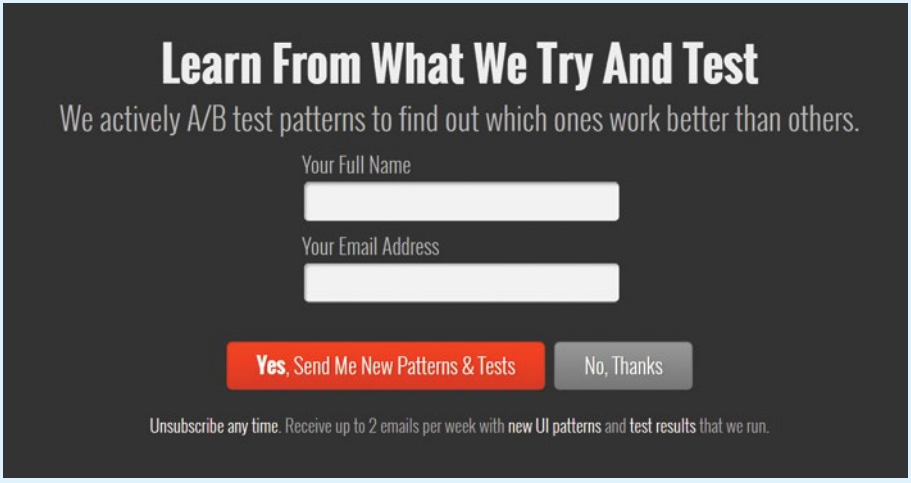
This is how **Walmart** did it:



www.walmart.com

Examples

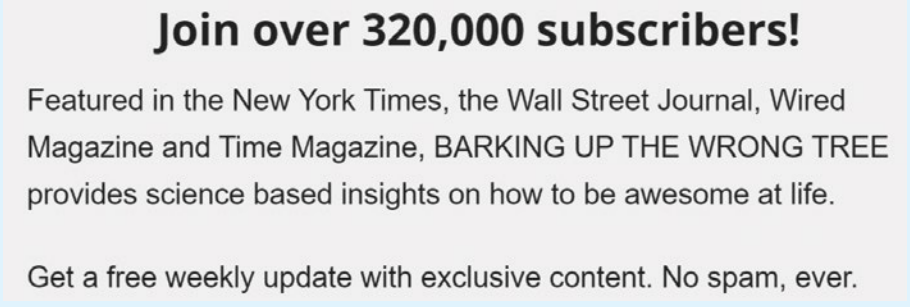
GoodUI tests patterns of interfaces to find out which work better. In their newsletter invitation, they don't even mention it's a newsletter. Instead they state the benefits for the user – they'll get the findings. In other words – we do the work, you get the results. Awesome. The button also delivers value (see Chapter 11), and beneath it they have a reassuring message and the specific frequency of their emails, to alleviate spam concerns.



www.goodui.org

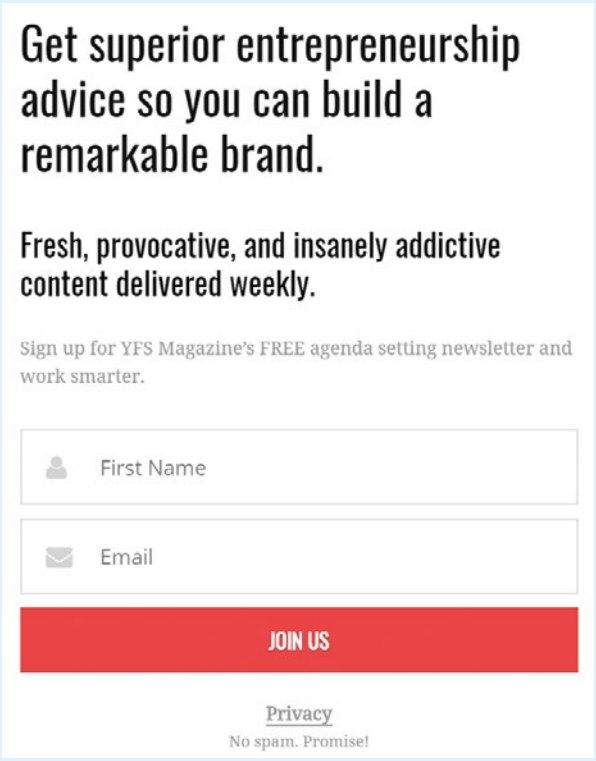
Barking up the Wrong Tree offers on the newsletter sign up form:

- Social proof (Featured in + over 320,000 subscribers)
- A value for its subscribers (to be awesome at life)
- Precise frequency (weekly)
- A promise that there will be no spam (ever!)



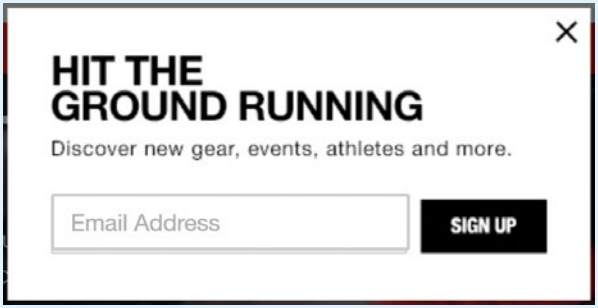
www.bakadesuyo.com

YFS Magazine provides clear value: their superior advice will help you build a remarkable brand. The frequency of the newsletter is clear (weekly), and beneath the button they promise not to spam.



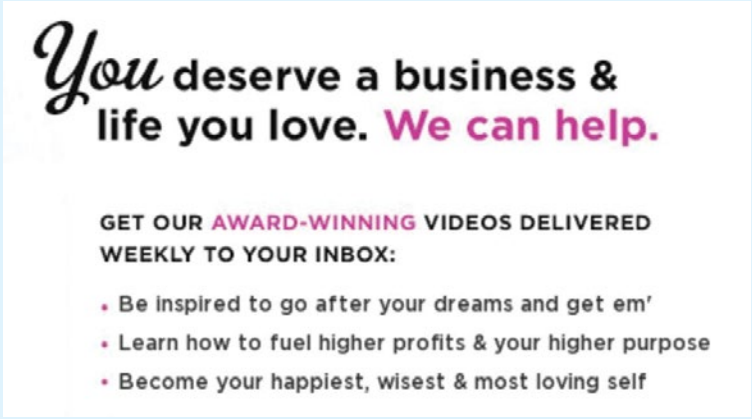
www.yfsmagazine.com

The North Face uses much less words, and speaks the language of extreme sports lovers.



www.thenorthface.com

And finally, the invitation to sign up for a newsletter that I like best is from **Marie Forleo**, the American life coach (Forleo already replaced it, but it's still my favourite).



www.marieforleo.com (a previous version)

What's so good about this invitation?

1. **The title, which offers a precise, super attractive value** – we'll help you create the life and business you'll love.
2. **The value is shown, not the act of signing up** –The invitation uses words and values that the users are looking for. Forleo doesn't hide behind long explanations on how you'll get there, but rather focuses on the ultimate goals, to fulfil your dreams, increase your profits, become happier and wiser, and to love yourself more. Note that the invitation hardly mentions Forleo and her business, but instead focuses entirely on the users.
3. **The frequency of the emails is clearly stated** – weekly.
4. **There is social proof** – winning an award.
5. **You can feel Forleo's personality in every word she writes** – charismatic and sees you as a peer, she sets demanding goals but is warm and empathic, business-like but human, and very, very feminine.

In her current newsletter CTA, Forleo takes the path of social proof, and then gives users the feeling that by signing up they join an exciting exclusive community.



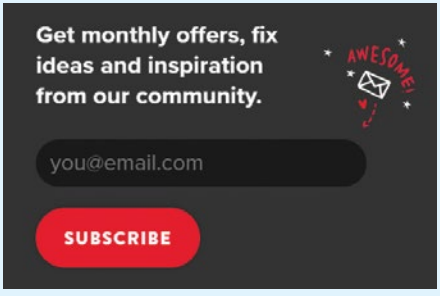
www.marieforleo.com

By the way, have you noticed that 5 out of 6 examples shown here don't mention the word newsletter, but it's still perfectly clear that's what it's all about? This is because users might be intimidated by this word, and you can just leave it out – as long as you make it clear in other ways.

In the margins but not marginal

Even secondary invitations to sign up for the newsletter, those that always appear in the footer or on the side bar, need to be more than just "*Sign up for our newsletter*". Despite the limited space, try to say in a few words why it is worthwhile to sign up and state the frequency.

Example



This is how **Sugru**, the magic glue shop, puts it in their footer (and adds some design awesomeness).

www.sugru.com

CHAPTER 6

CONTACT US

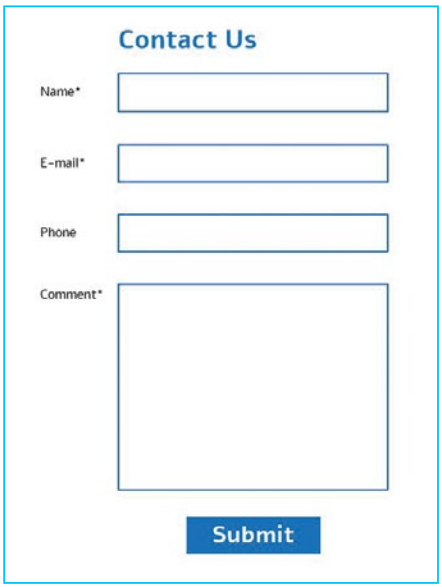
IN THIS CHAPTER

- Why the Contact page is so important
- A Contact page for interested customers
- A Contact page for support

How may we help you?

Your digital product is the virtual version of your organization or business. The Contact page is therefore customer service, the place users turn to when they want to engage with you or need help. In both cases – whether it is a potential customer, or an existing customer who needs support or an answer – the Contact page should be the most inviting and service-oriented page on your product.

That's why it always surprises me when I see the contact form presented as if someone was forced to put it up. They can be well designed, but there is nothing that even hints that whoever provided the page actually wants you to contact them, that they really want to help, or that there is actually someone who reads what was written. For example:



Mute forms like these are like the customer service rep who instead of brightly welcoming you with "How may I help you?" stands in front of you with a vacant expression and simply waits. A bit strange, don't you think?

By the way, sentences like "*We'd be happy to hear from you and answer any question you might have*", "*Your input is important to us!*" "*Our company*

invests heavily in the satisfaction of its customers", or "*Dear customer, please fill in your details and we'll get back to you during the next working day*", are so banal and lack credibility, that it is as if you didn't write anything. Also, avoid one of the many versions of "*In the continuing effort to improve our service, we'd love to hear any question you might have*". Improving your service is not what I'm here for, I need you to solve my very specific problem now, and if possible, receive personal attention, that will help me a lot.

So to write a great Contact page, first ask yourself in what specific situations users who visit your site will need it, and what will they want to achieve using it. Then create a unique message that fits them, and only them.

1. A Contact page designed for potential customers

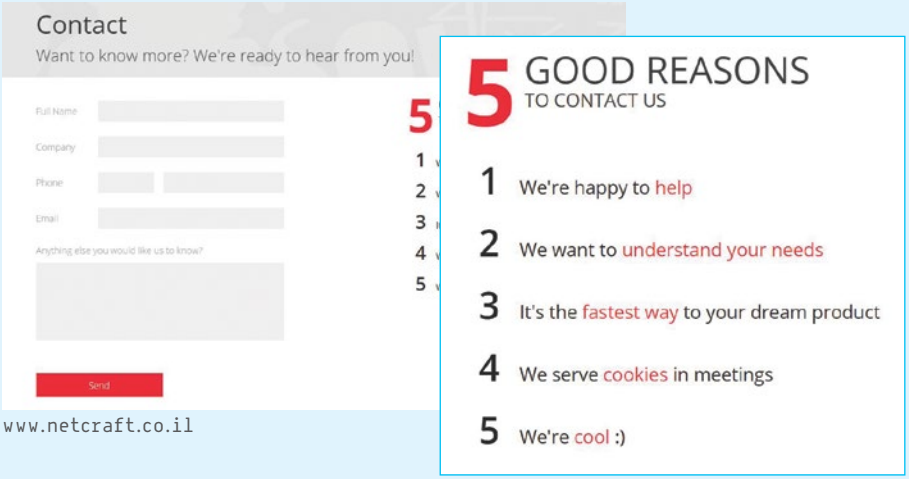
The purpose of corporate sites and service provider sites (such as therapists, studios, agencies etc.) are for users to contact them. In fact, the sole reason these sites are created is so that users will write to them or contact them and start to work together. This can be to arrange a meeting, order the service, check the price, find out more about the work process, and so on. In a way, all the persuasive effort you have invested in the content pages is channeled to the Contact page. There it should turn curiosity or desire into action, such as filling out a form, sending an email, or picking up the phone.

Now is not the time to take your foot off the gas, on the contrary, you need to strengthen the user's feeling that contacting you is an excellent choice, and exactly the right thing to do.

Like signing up on a site or for a newsletter, here also you start by changing the usual title **Contact Us** with a title that provides value. After that, tell the users how they will benefit by contacting you. If you prepared your voice and tone guide, you'll find in it what your users want to achieve most from a relationship with you. If you haven't prepared the guide, now too is a good time to ask this question.

Examples

Netcraft, a UX agency, considers its Contact page exactly as if it were a sales page, and gives users, potential customers, five good reasons to make contact. Reasons 1+2 create trust, reason 3 promises value, and reasons 4+5 are to inject some fun, an inseparable part of their brand. Wonderful!



www.netcraft.co.il

Epipheo, a company that produces videos for their clients, used to have on their Contact page a superb invitation that explains exactly what I mean when I say that you should continue selling right to the end. It creates trust, is authentic and full of character, and most important, it reminds users that Epipheo can help them achieve their business goals. The excellent wording summarizes for the users, just before they make contact, why in fact they should be contacting Epipheo. And still, I think that such a long paragraph might scare users away, and it's better to keep it 2-3 lines short.



www.epipheo.com (a previous version)

2. A Contact page designed for support

If your service or product does not entail the need to contact you, then the Contact page is usually used for support, inquiries, and questions.

And if good service is one of your values, you surely understand that the moment a customer needs support or an answer is exactly the time to be at your most service-oriented, and show them that you are there for them, that you'll be happy to help them, and that the faith they have placed in you is justified. That's what your Contact page should do. How can you achieve this?

1. **Write the invitation honestly, willingly and generously**. Your service will be judged not only when everything goes smoothly, but mostly when your users need you. Don't fake it, it doesn't work.
2. **Be precise**. Switch slogans like "*any question or suggestion*" with wording that is directly related to your product or service. Question about what? Suggestions relating to what interest?
3. **This might sound strange, but even the contact form includes obstacles that need to be removed**. Users fear that their request is one out of a million, that you won't read it, or by the time they do receive an answer they'll have forgotten why they contacted you. Promise them that you read all the support inquiries and mention how long it takes you to reply.

TIP

13

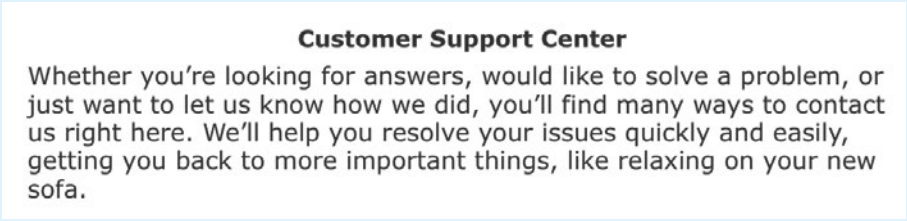
Joking aside

In most cases, a little joke or an authentic smile can break the ice, create rapport, and improve the atmosphere. But if you have a Contact page dedicated to inquiries and support, your customers will sometimes go there when they are angry, frustrated or simply don't know what to do.

If you have written an amusing contact text, reread it as if you are a dissatisfied user, and make sure that it doesn't make you even angrier or might be construed as sounding cynical. It's better to play it safe when it comes to a Contact page.

Examples

Ikea provides a range of possible reasons to contact them. They emphasize that they'll solve the problem quickly and easily, and enable you to get back to relaxing on your new sofa, the reason you came to Ikea in the first place.

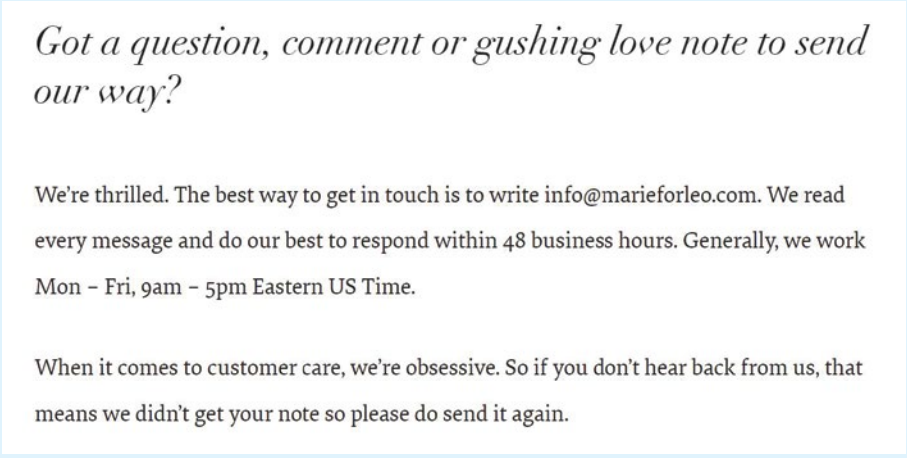


Customer Support Center

Whether you're looking for answers, would like to solve a problem, or just want to let us know how we did, you'll find many ways to contact us right here. We'll help you resolve your issues quickly and easily, getting you back to more important things, like relaxing on your new sofa.

www.ikea.com

Marie Forleo, the successful life coach, warmly invites you to contact her, whether with questions or compliments, and she writes in the voice and tone that fits her personality and brand. Even more importantly, she understands that users are not sure where their inquiries are sent when talking about a virtual company, who reads them, and how long it takes to receive a reply, if at all. Forleo addresses all these concerns and promises that all inquiries are read and that they endeavor to answer them within 48 business hours.



Got a question, comment or gushing love note to send our way?

We're thrilled. The best way to get in touch is to write info@marieforleo.com. We read every message and do our best to respond within 48 business hours. Generally, we work Mon – Fri, 9am – 5pm Eastern US Time.

When it comes to customer care, we're obsessive. So if you don't hear back from us, that means we didn't get your note so please do send it again.

www.marieforleo.com

Oh Happy Day is a cool party shop that does include a small smile on its Contact page (but you need to be careful about this, **see tip 13**). They also promise to reply within two business days max.

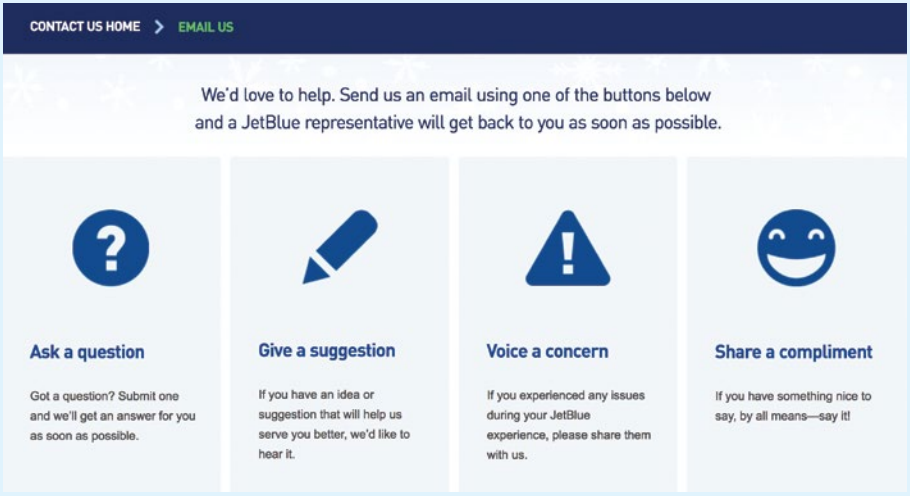


www.shop.ohhappyday.com

But it is better to be more specific than "*If you have any questions" or "Need to return something?*" Connect the sentence to the subject matter of the site. For example:

- Do you have any questions about our colored confetti?
- Does the color of the balloons not match the napkins and you need to return them?
- Do you want to share with us other cool accessories that we haven't thought about?

If you have several different groups of customers, and want to say something slightly different to each group, you can provide a separate link for each one that leads them to the relevant form, like they do in **JetBlue**.



www.jetblue.com

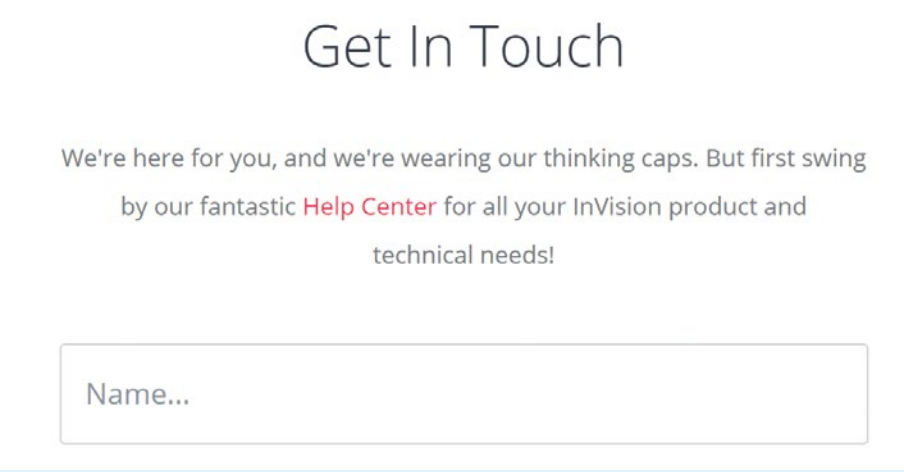
NPR, the US public multimedia news organization and radio program producer, also uses this system, and clicking a button displays a form relevant to that subject.



www.npr.org

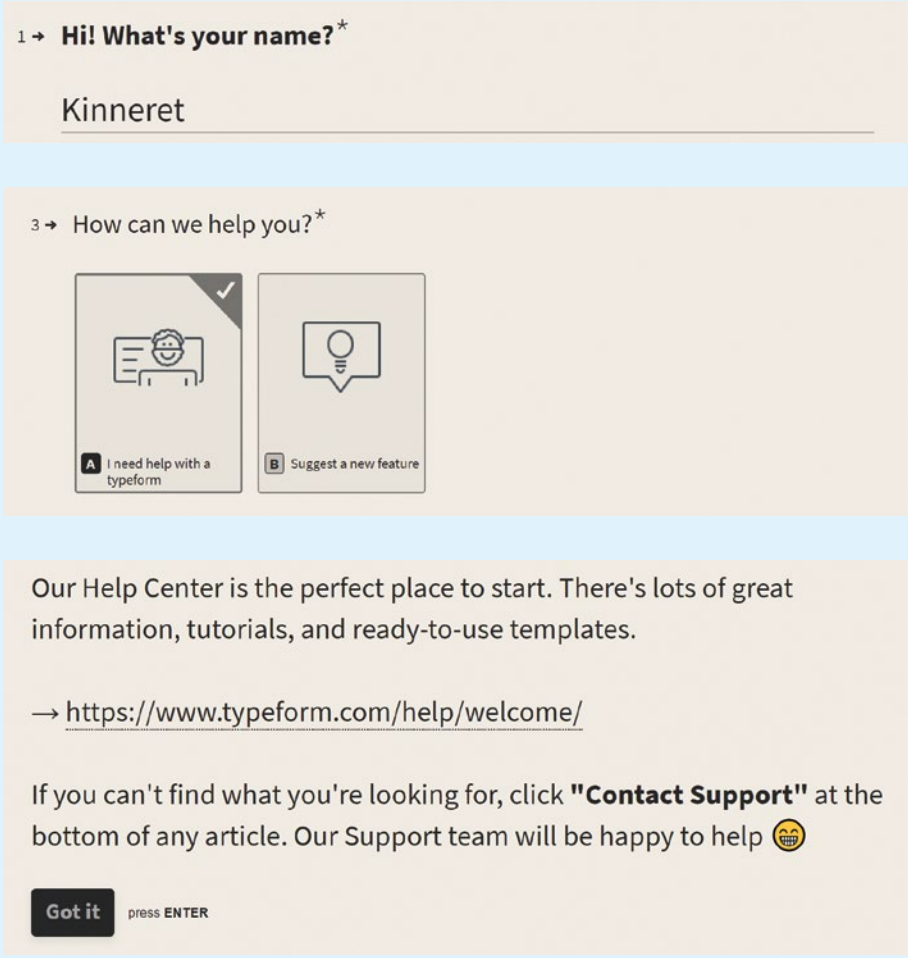
FAQs or online help is a service that many users will be happy to get instead of waiting for an answer from you. Having said that, users might feel that you're trying to shake them off and stop them from contacting you. To avoid that, when referring users to online help, stress that you'd love to hear from them, and that FAQs are really the fastest way to help them.

InVision provides tools to design, review and test products. First they promise they will always be there for you, and only then suggest you try the help center for technical issues. In any case, the contact form is available right below this message and you can choose it easily.



www.invisionapp.com

Typeform uses a typeform on their Contact page :) When users state they need help with a form, they are first referred to the help center, but Typform makes sure you know their support team are also always available.



www.typeform.com

TIP

14

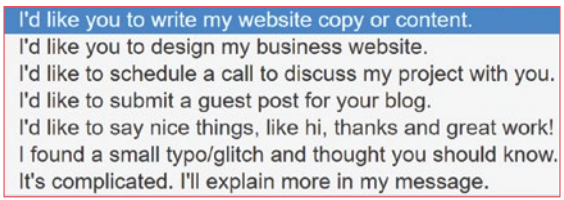
Categorizing inquiries by topic or urgency

When you are creating the subject categories or the level of urgency for the contact form, change your internal professional terminology into the language of your users. In other words, ask yourself what this inquiry is referring to from the point of view of your users, not you.

For example:

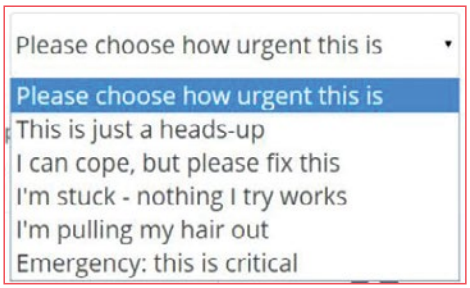
- Ordered products › My orders
- Billing issue › Question about payment
- System error › Problem with the site
- General › Something else

That's how **Men with Pens**, a site that offers to design and write content for websites, did it:



www.menwithpens.ca

If your form includes levels of urgency, this is how **buffer**, a site that provides tools to increase social media activity used to put it. Simply great.



www.buffer.com

CHAPTER 7

ERROR MESSAGES

IN THIS CHAPTER

The 3 goals of error messages

A useful error message in 2 steps

The voice and tone of error messages

The error messages every site needs

First aid for the baffled user

Error messages are the only text we write that we hope users will never see. Therefore, the correct thing is to prevent users making errors, and you can read about that in Chapter 17, which deals with preventing errors and frustration. However, users are most likely to see some of your error messages, and thus you need to word them so that they offer real help.

An error message temporarily stops the process the users are trying to complete. As far as they are concerned, the message delays them and requires them to understand what went wrong and how they should continue. Since their motivation is already fragile, error messages could be the last straw, leading them to abandon the process, especially if messages are unclear, intimidating or make them feel bad.

Therefore, error messages need to fulfill three goals:

1. Explain simply and clearly that there is a problem and what that problem is.
2. Provide a solution so that users can return and complete the process immediately.
3. Turn the delay into an experience that is as pleasant as possible.

Usually, error messages concern technical problems that need resolving, so the emphasis should be on **clarity** and **practicality**. Don't be too clever with the text, and make it as simple as possible. It's also not the place to make fun of the user or to make light of the delay they endure. But that doesn't mean the messages need to be cold. On the contrary, precisely because errors cause discomfort, write the messages in a natural and human voice, so that they will make the delay as friendly as possible, just like a good customer service rep would do if you encountered this problem when meeting them face to face.

The perfect error message in 2 steps

1. **Describe the problem and what went wrong as precisely as you can.**
2. **Provide a constructive suggestion on how to solve the problem and carry on forward.** If the problem can't be solved at that moment, tell the user what can be done to help them, and who they can turn to.

Except when: In the standard error messages associated with the sign up form or login (such as an incorrect password or an existing username), you can sometimes leave out one of these two (description of the problem **or** its solution), because the situation is so well known to users that both the problem and the solution are obvious.

TIP

15

Four things you need to know to write good error messages

1. What was the user trying to do when they got an error?
2. Why did the system respond with an error?
3. What can the user do to carry on and complete the process?
4. If there is no solution, is there an alternative action you can offer them (such as turning to support)?



The more generic, the less helpful

If – due to budget or development limitations – you must phrase a single error message for a few different scenarios, it means it'll be a rather generic message: you can't describe what went wrong (there are a few possible options), and you can't tell the users how to fix it (because you don't know which problem they need to fix). You'll face the same issue if your system can't recognize what exactly caused the error.

There's no magic solution here – for error messages to be helpful they need to be relevant to the context they appear in.

If you can't phrase specific messages, at least be as positive and friendly as you can.

Voice and tone of error messages: human and service-oriented

In Chapter 2, I described how to write in a conversational style, and how to avoid the formal writing style. One very important place to implement this is when writing error messages, so that they'll be really helpful and readable, and prevent users from closing the alert before reading it all the way through.

1. Write without rigidity, threat or giving orders, and generally without sounding like a lawyer.

Not this way:

- Fill in this field
- This field is mandatory
- You cannot proceed, the following fields are incorrect
- You must provide a mobile phone number
- Dear customer, you are not allowed to perform this action

2. Write without a trace of the words error or failure.

Not this way:

- Error! Please correct the field
- Error in one or more fields
- The action failed. Try again

3. Write without using technical terms, such as validation or verification, legal, certified, unsupported action, system, permission or the serial number of the error.

Not this way:

- FATAL ERROR: Unhandled c0001du exception at 31c71014h
- The validation of media ids failed
- There was a problem retrieving the XML data: undefined
- Invalid login credentials
- Illegal email address
- Validation error
- Error 5647GV

Instead of writing such intimidating texts, you need to write error messages that do not blame the user, but simply describe the problem, in the most service-oriented way and in a pleasant conversational tone, and then propose a solution.

One great way to do that is to say what's possible instead of what's not.

Instead of: Phone number is invalid
Say: Phone number should be 10 digits

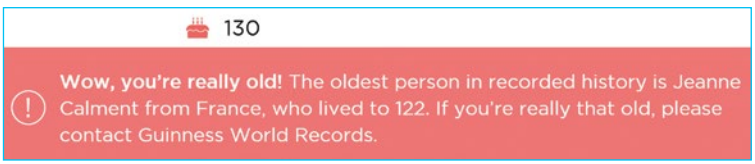
Instead of: You cannot book this flight
Say: Direct flights to Dublin are only available in August

TIP 16

Humor in error messages - yes or no?

The amount of humor you can use in error messages depends on your brand's voice and tone. If your brand is light and flowing, you can definitely write messages that make the user smile; but remember that first and foremost the message needs to be clear and practical, and provide a solution to the problem. Being too clever could delay users and might be seen as belittling their problem. Keep the humor light and make sure it doesn't make it difficult for the user to understand.

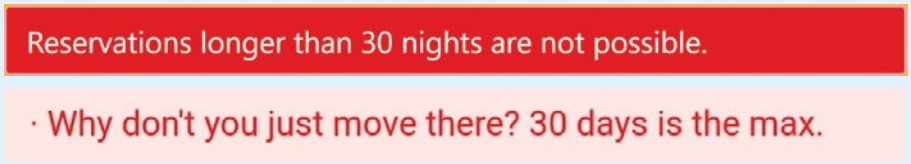
This error message, from the **OurHome** app for managing family tasks, appears if you state you're over 122 years old. It's super funny, and far too long, but it obviously wasn't meant to be practical in the first place, but rather to make users laugh. Worked for me!



OurHome app

Examples

These two error messages say practically the same thing:

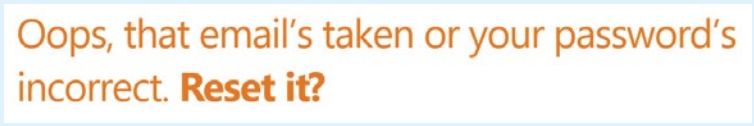


The first takes the negative path (what is not possible), while the second (by **Hipmunk**) takes the positive path (what is the maximum) and adds a wink. The difference in the experience is enormous.

By the way, the wink is great when it fits the brand's voice, **but it isn't necessary**. If your voice is more conservative, it can still deliver a less negative experience by saying what is possible, instead of what's not: *Reservations can be maximum 30 nights long*.

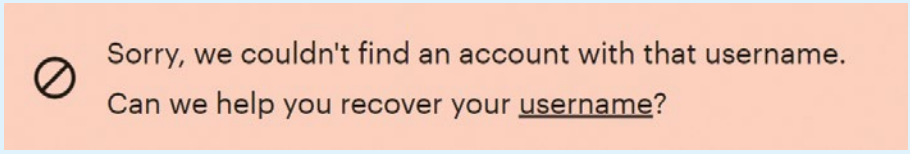
Look how many nice and helpful ways there are to say: *Your username or password are incorrect*

Pinterest says:



www.pinterest.com

Mailchimp says:



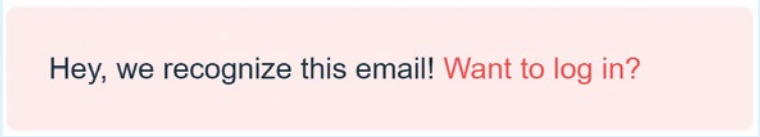
www.mailchimp.com

Tesco says:



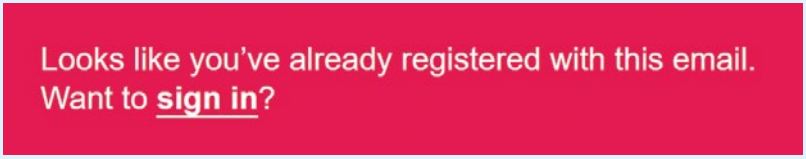
www.tesco.com

This is **Vimeo**'s great error message for existing email:



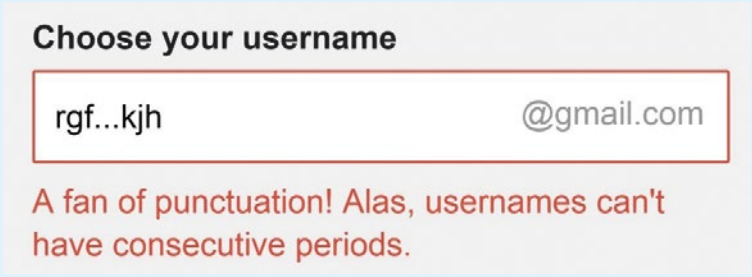
www.vimeo.com

And this is from the **BBC**'s website:



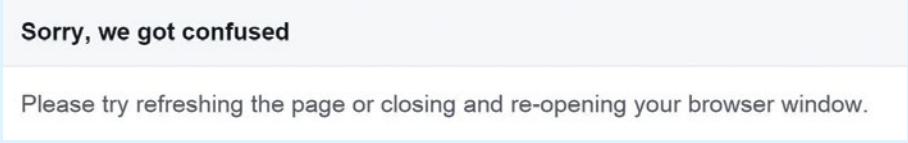
www.bbc.com

Even for this very specific error, **Google** has a special and humorous message.



www.google.com

Facebook. If you open two accounts on the same browser, you receive a very human error message, followed by two solutions to the problem.



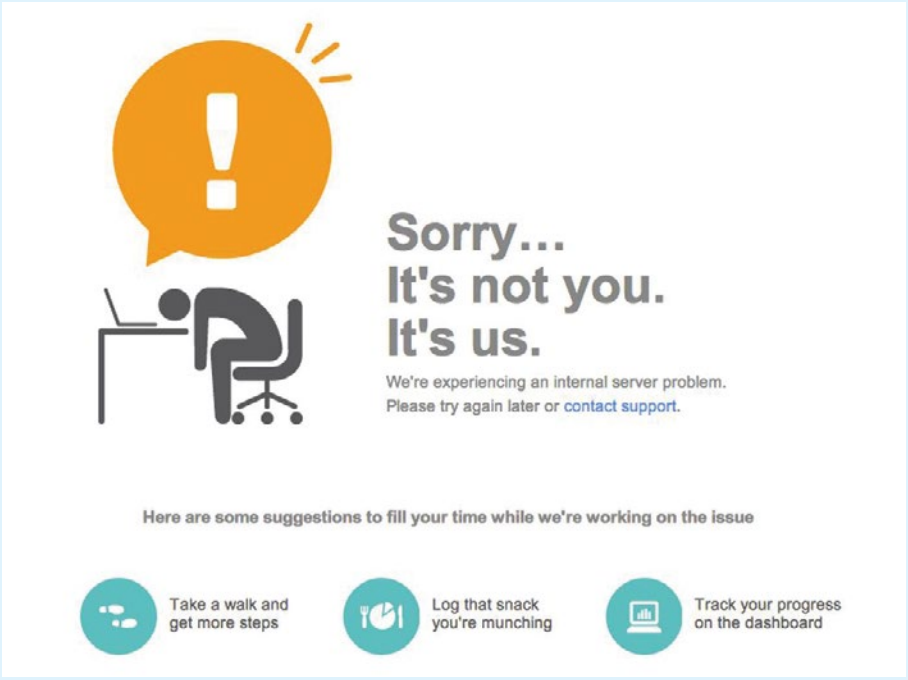
www.facebook.com

Asos' messages are human and excellent, and for each required field they provide unique wording.



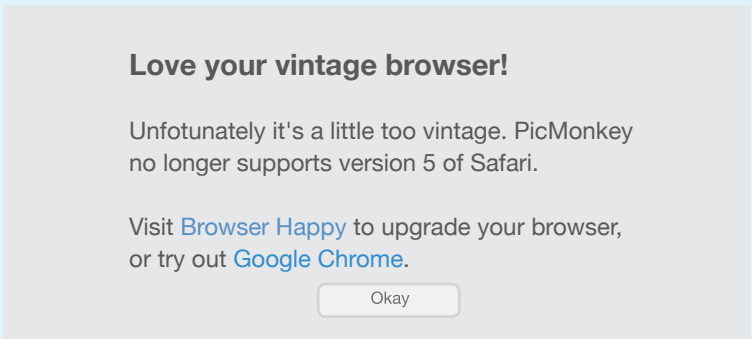
www.asos.com

Fitbit. Even if the user can't do anything to fix the problem, for example a communication failure, it's important to tell them it's out of their hands, so they don't try and fix it, resulting in even greater frustration. Fitbit describes the situation well, both in words and with a lovely graphic. After apologizing and explaining what the problem is, they suggest a few ideas on how to pass the time, and lighten the mood after an annoying experience. This is a good example of a graphic and microcopy that support each other well and fit the message.



www.fitbit.com

PicMonkey. This isn't exactly an error message, but it does relate to a very annoying scenario of the browser being out-of-date and unable to properly display the site. This sort of scenario is a headache both for us and our users. PicMonkey, a site that lets users edit photos, turned the lemon into lemonade, and the frustrating experience into a good laugh befitting the style of their brand. Users still need to install a new browser, but at least they'll do it in good spirits.



www.picmonkey.com

TIP

17

Don't leave it up to your techies

All error messages, both the standard messages and the special ones, need to be written, or at least approved, by your microcopy writer. It is advisable to give the software developers as many carefully worded error messages as possible before they even start working on your system (a list of most common errors that need to be worded is at the end of this chapter). In this way they can easily integrate them. Having said that, you will discover new scenarios requiring error messages as development progresses. Don't leave these to the developers to write. It's not their job to write them, and maybe they'll be good at it, but maybe not. Make sure they know that if they do discover a need for new error messages, they should pass them along to your microcopy writers with a description of the scenario, so that they can phrase them.

Cut out & keep

Errors that need to be worded on (almost) every digital product

Sign up

1. The username or email already exists (if possible, provide a link to the registered users login page)
2. Email address error (usually the system checks if the @ or the suffix are missing, and should tell the users what the problem is)
3. The telephone number, or ID, doesn't fit the rules (tell the users what the rules are)
4. The password doesn't fit the rules (the message must detail the requirements, and if they are strict, it is worthwhile providing them up front next to the field and so avoid the error in the first place)
5. Verification of the two password fields fails because they are not identical
6. A mandatory field was not filled (I recommend you prepare a specific message for each field, and not one generic message for all of them)
7. They didn't agree to the terms of use

Login for registered users

1. The username or email does not exist (try to provide a link to the sign up form)
2. The password is incorrect
3. The username and password don't match. Sometimes, for security reasons, it is unadvisable to tell the user which of the two fields was problematic. In such cases, the message needs to say that they don't match, or that there is a mistake in one of them (without saying which)
4. Either of the two fields, username or password, was not filled

Contact us (and every place where you ask the users for their email, such as when signing up for the newsletter)

1. Email address error
2. The telephone number doesn't fit the rules
3. A mandatory field was not filled

Password recovery

1. The username or email does not exist (I recommend you provide a link to the sign up form, or ask them if they registered using another name or email address)
2. Email address error

CHAPTER 8

SUCCESS MESSAGES

IN THIS CHAPTER

- 3 goals of success messages
- 4 components of a good success message

All's well that ends well

In the first part of this book, I presented the fascinating results from the research of Professor Clifford Nass. He found that when humans use a digital interface, they expect it to behave according to acceptable social norms, even though they understand that they are dealing with a computer. This includes reacting to their actions, complimenting them when appropriate, and helping them when something has gone wrong.

Success messages that users see after they have performed an action are one of the most important responses that they expect to receive.

Following are some examples of actions that conclude with a success message:

- Signing up or joining a site/event/service
- Purchase or order of a product/service/subscription
- Signing up for a newsletter
- Unsubscribing
- Downloading a free guide
- Sending a contact form
- Download/upload of file/program/plugin
- Import/export of data/files
- Validation of email addres
- Opting in for a free trial
- Recovering a password, and so on

Why are success messages so important? They have 3 goals:

1. **Provide certainty**. The message confirms to the user that the action completed successfully and that everything is okay.
2. **Instruct**. The message tells the user about the next optional or mandatory step.
3. **Connect**. The message is the final piece of the process, and it can be moving, funny or even exhilarating. It can add extra meaning to the action and leave users with a good positive feeling about your brand and the pleasant experience they had with it.

You don't have to always accomplish all these goals. Sometimes a simple tick that appears for a few seconds and then disappears is enough. For a frequent and simple action, such as sending an email or saving a document, write a super short and practical success message. But the more important the action is for users, the fuller the success message should be.

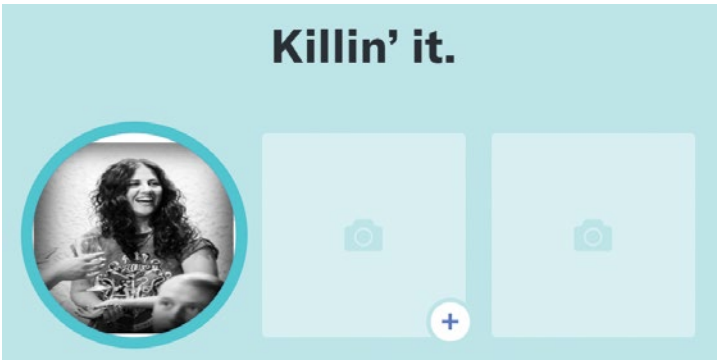
So how is it done? Not this way:

- The transaction was completed successfully
- Registration was successful
- Your order was successfully received
- Your email address was successfully confirmed

The template "*X successfully completed*" serves only the first goal, to provide certainty, and it does it in a boring, impersonal, detached manner. So avoid it or make sure that it isn't the main part of the message, and provide content to achieve at least one of the other goals.

Instead of using a worn out template, do one or more of the following, or even better, do them all.

1. **Talk about or to the user, not about the action they just completed.** Refer to the person who completed the process, and not the process itself. For example, when uploading photos to your profile on the dating site **OkCupid**, you don't see *Photo uploaded successfully*, but a different message for each photo you upload, and all of them are fun and make you feel good.

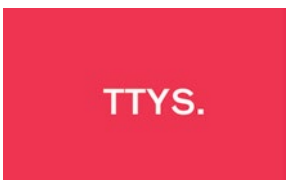


www.okcupid.com



2. **Give a clear indication that what the user wanted to do, did in fact occur**, but you don't need to write using the template "*X successfully completed*". Try to be as clear as possible but slightly different. Note that in the previous example, from OkCupid, this was implied by showing the uploaded photo and reacting to it.

   Following is the tiny success message you get from **The Outline**, the kicking publication, after signing up for their newsletter. This acronym (that stands for *talk to you soon*) serves two purposes: confirming the subscription, and building expectation as to what exactly you're going to talk about. By the way, if you're going for a global audience, try to avoid acronyms – they're guaranteed to send some confused users to Google in search of clarification.



www.theoutline.com

3. **If relevant, include a deeper, meaningful aspect of the action taken.**

   How? Briefly remind users of the value they received from taking the action, how it effects them and is important to them.

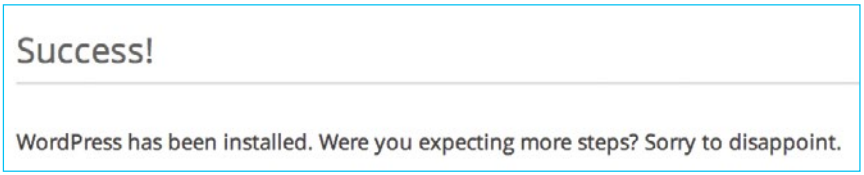
   For example, if they signed up for a newsletter, remind them that treasure will be delivered soon to their inbox, so that they can't wait for the first newsletter to arrive.

   If they bought a leisure product, be excited with them and make them feel good about it.

   If they contacted you via the contact page, make them feel that their faith in you is justified and that you're on the case.

   And so on.

A success message that does this really well is the one provided by **WordPress** after installation:



www.wordpress.com

The message is funny, but also says that they kept their promise for a simple, intuitive platform, and that getting their product was an excellent choice that made your life much easier.

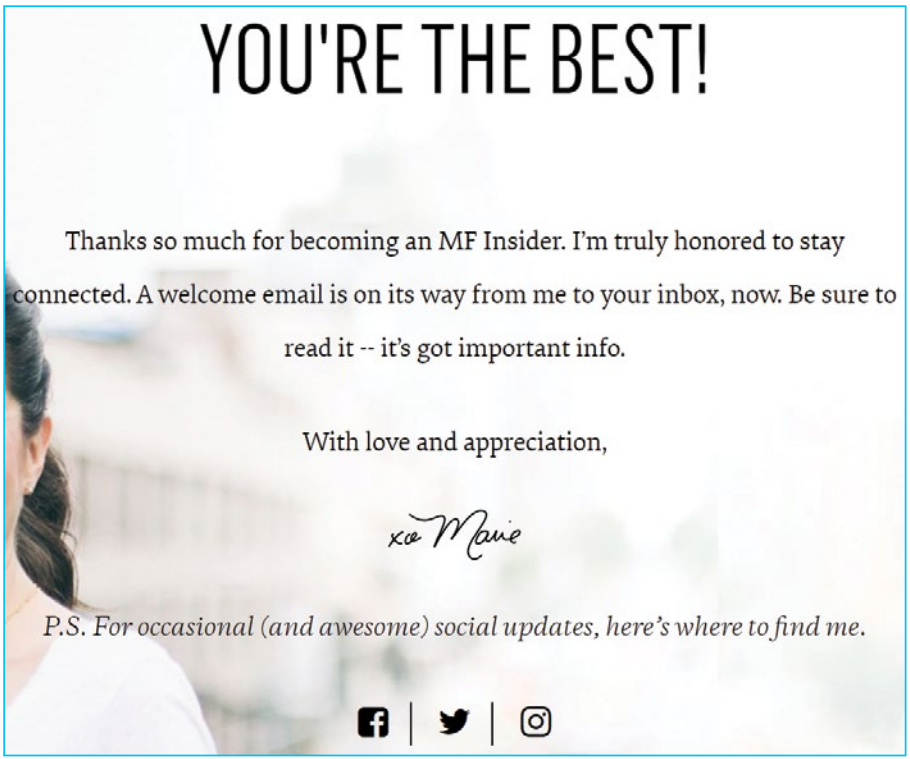
4. **Present and promote the next step for you and your users.** For example:

- What's going to happen now (how long will it take to answer their mail, when you expect to send the purchase, when will the subscription start, if the registration process needs activation, and so on).
- Refer them to their inbox if you are going to send them an email (to verify the address or to see an order summary).
- Further actions that you want users to perform (a link to the page where users start using the product, invitation to download your app, invitation to share or follow you on social media).
- If you don't have another step, send them back to the site to something that really interests and is important to you, such as promotions or blog.

I recommend reading Talia Wolf's post "Use these 7 hacks on your thank you pages to boost retention".

This is **Marie Forleo**'s success message after subscribing to her newsletter. She does everything said here:

1. **Talks to the users** about themselves and her relationship with them, not about the action.
2. **Gives certainty** that the sign up was successful, but without using this technical term.
3. **Gives the action extra meaning** – becoming an insider and connecting with her personally.
4. **Refers users to their inbox** to read the first email, using a great call to action that sounds very honest.
5. **Elegantly promotes the next step** – encouraging users to follow her on social media as well.



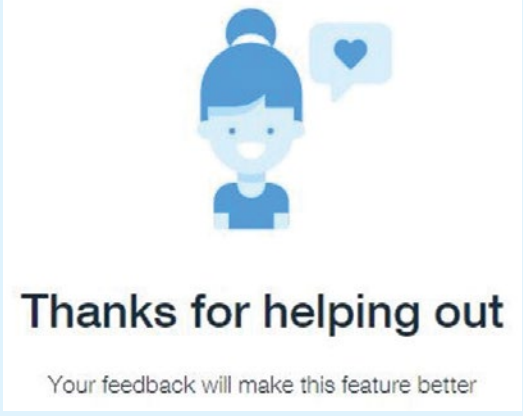
www.marieforleo.com

More examples

Epipheo creates videos for businesses. The goal of their website is to get users to contact them and start working together on a shiny new video. After the contact form has been sent, users receive the following success message that thanks them, promises personal attention from an expert, and immensely increases credibility by introducing the business developers in person, with photos! This is a wonderful combination of personal and professional that makes me feel that contacting them was the right thing to do. And they didn't skip on suggesting the next step – joining their Facebook group.



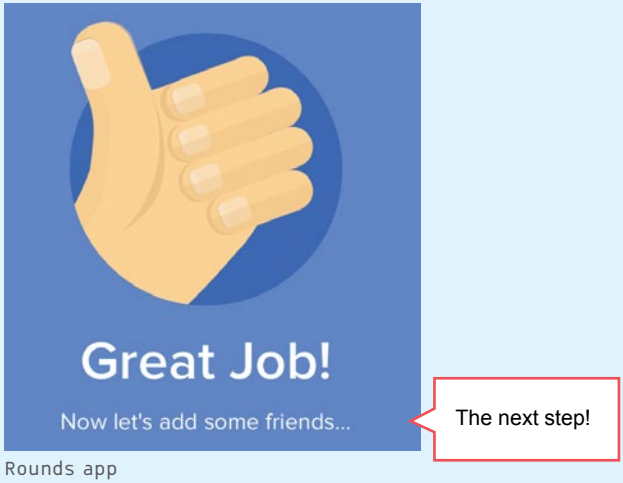
www.epipheo.com



After giving feedback on one of **Wix**'s new features, they say what it actually means: You just improved the feature. The illustration shows their gratitude and completes the copy. Very satisfying.

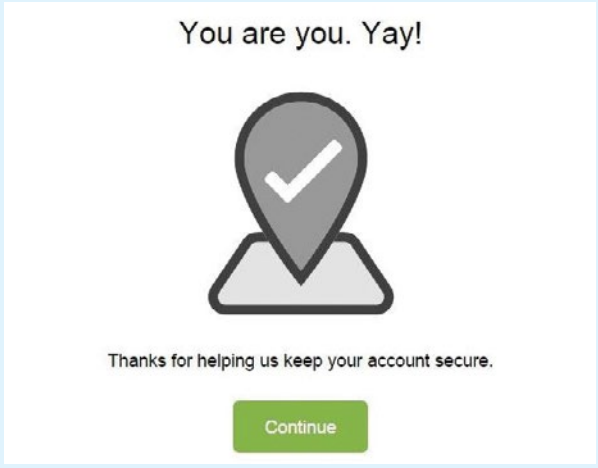
www.wix.com

Rounds. This is the success message after installing their app. Some people claim that a pat on the back can be seen as condescending, but Clifford Nass discovered with his research that even though users realize that the compliments are entirely random and not personal, they still feel good about themselves, and appreciate the interface. Yes, we humans are weird, so go ahead and compliment your users, no biggie.



Rounds app

Envato's success message upon completion of the security check is very short, but also surprising, funny, conveys a true sense of cooperation, and tells the users how **they** benefited: by having a secured account.



www.envato.com

CHAPTER 9

EMPTY STATES

IN THIS CHAPTER

- How to turn a dead end into an open door
- Empty states for features before first use
- Empty states for an empty cart and previous orders
- Empty states for search results

Nothing to see here, move along?

Words don't only empower and sharpen an experience, they can also create it, even when it seems that there is nothing to experience. Microcopy for empty states is the best example of this.

But first, let's go back to the definition. Empty states are those states where there is nothing to show users. They can appear when the user first encounters a digital product or a feature in it, and they can also appear as a result of use, such as running a search that returns no results.

When you leave the empty state empty, you are basically telling your users what there **isn't**. You are missing out on the opportunity to tell them what **there is**. For example, what could have been here, what they could gain from it, and what they can do to get things moving. A feature that hasn't yet been used is an opportunity to present its benefits and encourage them to use it. An empty cart is an opportunity to encourage a sale. A search that ended without results provides the opportunity to show you care, by offering other options and preventing the users from leaving empty handed. This isn't only a chance to offer good service, but also to direct the users towards the next step and get them back in business.

1. Empty states of features before first use

77% of all app downloads are discarded within three days of being downloaded, so wrote Dina Chaiffetz in "Why empty states deserve more design time" (InVision Blog). Obviously we can't put all the blame on empty states, but they do play a very important role in creating the user's first impression of your website, app or service.

Imagine users browsing through your site after registering (or app after downloading), and all they see is:

- There are no items in your basket (or cart, or even bag)
- Your wish list is empty
- No previous actions were found
- You haven't saved any favorites
- No messages
- You don't have any friends in your network, and so on.

Often these empty state messages appear on a totally blank page – inches and inches of emptiness.



What a waste! After a short tour of such a static and ineffective product, users will feel that you don't have much to offer and that this site won't exactly change their lives.

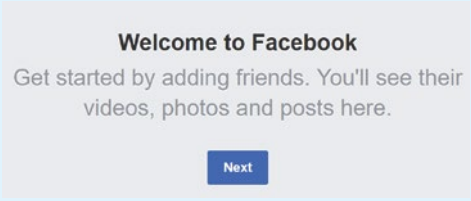
When users open a page or feature that they haven't used before, you have an opportunity to show them the feature's potential and motivate them to start using it.

Instead of saying that there is nothing here, write about what is supposed to be here or what they can do here, what this feature does and how it can help them.

If relevant, add instructions. Tell users exactly how to start using the feature (if possible, its best to add a visual), or provide a link.

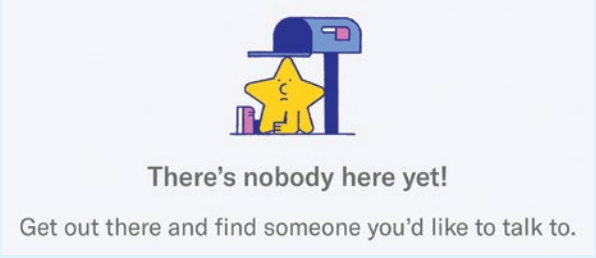
Examples of empty states of features before first use

Do you remember how your **Facebook** feed looked like when you just opened your profile? This is the empty state before doing anything. It welcomes users and guides them towards taking the first action, the one that the platform is based on – adding friends. The button that says *Next* takes them to some friend suggestions. I would expect it to say something like *Add friends*, or *See suggestions*, or *Look who else is here*, but maybe *Next* is noncommittal, thus more appealing. I wonder if they tested it.



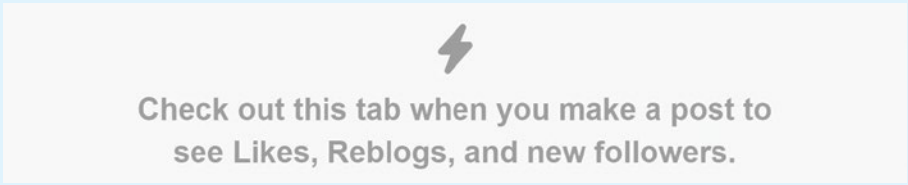
www.facebook.com

OkCupid's inbox is one of the dating site's most important pages. If it's still empty, they encourage users to go ahead and explore the site. Cute illustrations that reflect the specific situation are a great way to improve the experience, and I would add a shortcut button to browse matches.



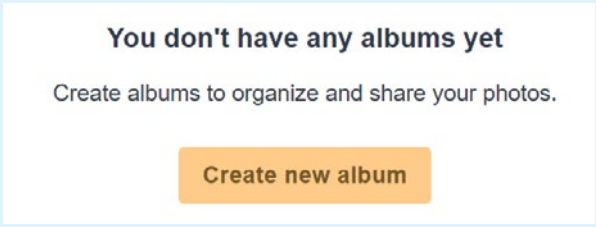
www.okcupid.com

tumblr doesn't say that *you have no notifications*, instead it tells you when to come back and check. Not what isn't there, but what will be there.

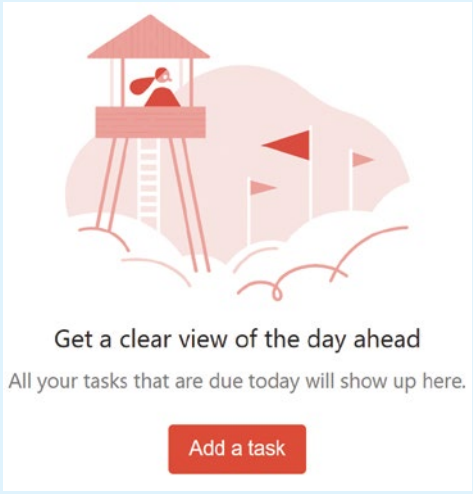


www.tumblr.com

On **Amazon photos**, if you haven't created any albums yet, they don't just say *No Albums*, but rather tell you how albums can help you (organize and share your photos) and provide a shortcut button with a call to action, so you can go ahead and create your first one.



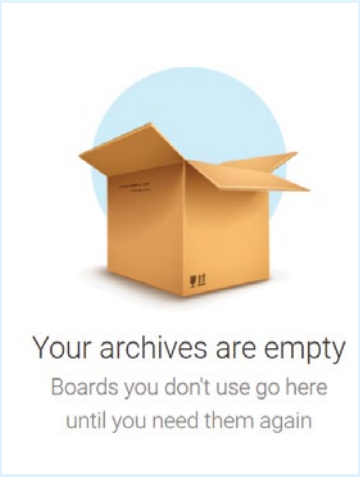
www.amazon.com

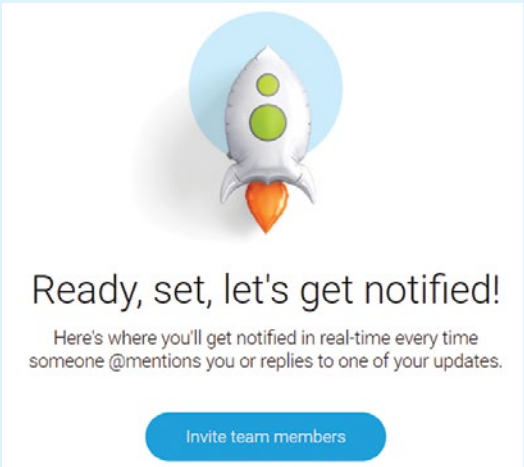


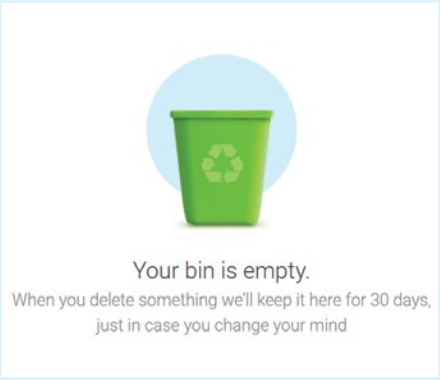
www.todoist.com

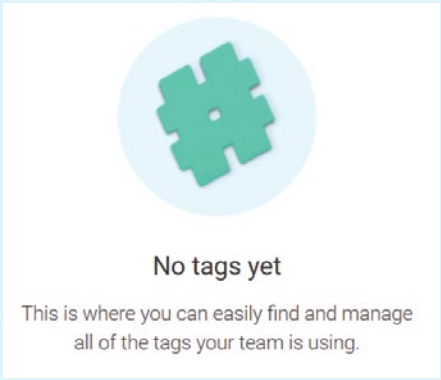
Todoist is a task management tool. If you still haven't posted a task for today, they not only tell you that once you do you'll see it here, but also why it's worthwhile to list your tasks – it gives you a clear view of the day ahead. The image strengthens this value, and the button is practical and down to business.

Monday makes great use of empty states to show new users how the system works, and how they can make the best out of it: Here you can easily find and manage tags (instead of just *No tags yet*); things you delete will be kept for 30 days (instead of *No deleted items*); you can temporarily archive folders (instead of *No archived items*); and how you receive and send personal notifications using @ (instead of *No notifications yet*). The images make things nicer too. Great job.









www.monday.com

On the space where your future designs will appear, **Canva** puts their faith in you to create amazing things. They also refer users to the search bar to begin.

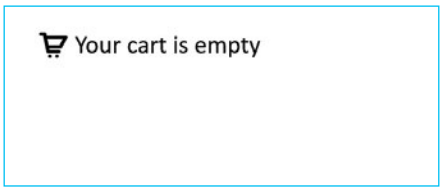


www.canva.com

2. Empty states of an empty cart and previous orders

Users have a variety of reasons to open their empty cart (or basket or bag). For example, if they thought they added an item to the cart by mistake and went to check if there's anything there, or if they didn't remember if they added an item or not and wanted to check, or if there was something in the cart but they removed it, leaving it empty.

An empty cart is a terrible waste of real estate. I've seen quite a few like this one:

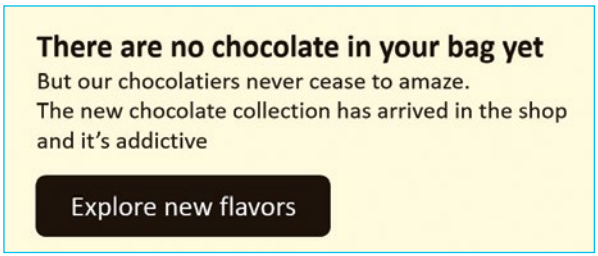


So how can you use this empty area? To motivate users to shop of course:

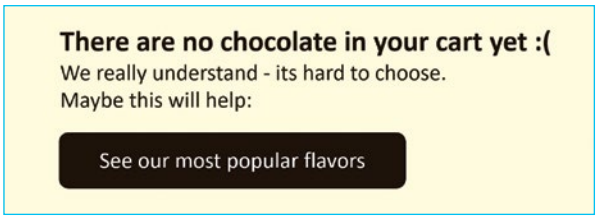
1. **Make it clear that the cart is empty**, that it doesn't have any items in it.
2. **Start an interesting and persuasive sales dialog**. Try to be funny or exciting or make them curious, and best of all be all of them. As we saw in the first part of the book, when users are happy or excited they want to act. A combination of text and graphic works very well here.
3. **Direct your users to interesting parts of the shop**, such as special offers, popular or new items, and so on.

4. **You can also provide social proof** or interesting statistics about other buyers or items, and only then direct the users to specific items in the shop.

For example, on the site of a very famous chocolate shop, they write "*Your shopping bag is empty*", and the rest of the page remains blank. Instead of this vacant lot, they could have started a sales pitch, and from there direct the curious users to the shop, while they have the urge to buy. For example:



Or:



In another online shop, selling health and beauty products, they didn't even write that the bag was empty. The only thing users saw when they opened the bag for the first time was a space so empty that its cleanliness dazzled them. What could they have written? For example:



Of course, make sure that the offers don't look like products the users add to their basket. We're trying to motivate them, not to confuse them.

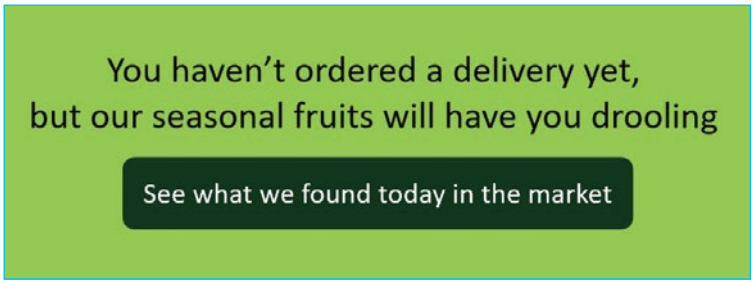
You can combine this with social proof and write:

Items that have been purchased the most this week

Or: **Items that someone else is looking at right this moment**

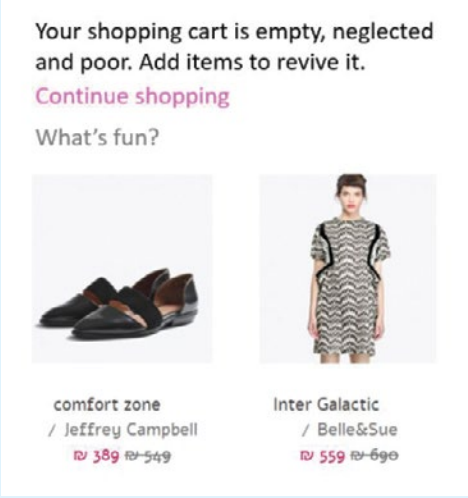
And under each title add photos of the products and a link to buy them.

Many sites have a **Previous Orders** page, where you can browse the list of your past purchases, and sometimes even reorder one of them. Before purchasing the first item, users will of course see an empty state, but if you only write "*There are no previous orders*" you miss out on a sales opportunity, just as with the empty cart. Both the users' experience and their willingness to buy something will be dramatically enhanced if you write something substantial like:



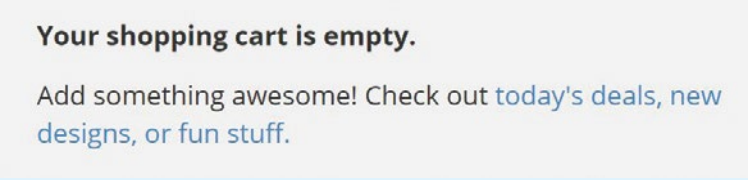
Examples of empty carts

Belle and Sue is an Israeli fashion store. They first make it clear that your bag is empty, but they do it with a smile. They then motivate users to buy something and provide links, the first to the shop and others to specific items, with a title that thouches the shopping nerve.



www.belleandsue.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

Busted Tees makes it clear that the shopping cart is empty, and refers users to the three most interesting pages in the shop.



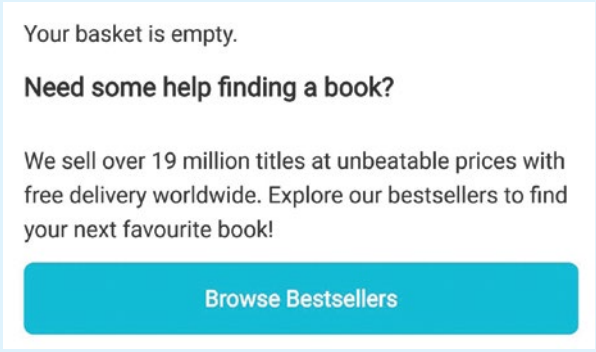
www.bustedtees.com

American Eagle believes the new collections will peak users' curiosity.



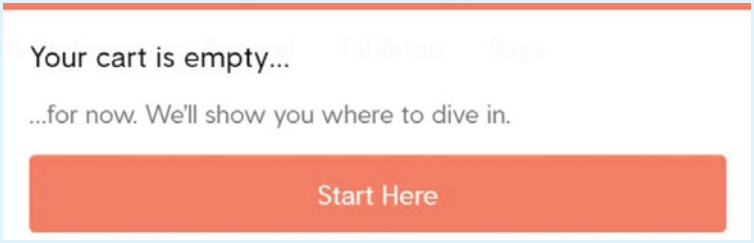
www.ae.com

Variety, promise of low prices, free delivery, social proof of best sellers and a helping hand – **Book Depository** successfully turned their basket into one that makes you want to set sail on your next reading adventure.

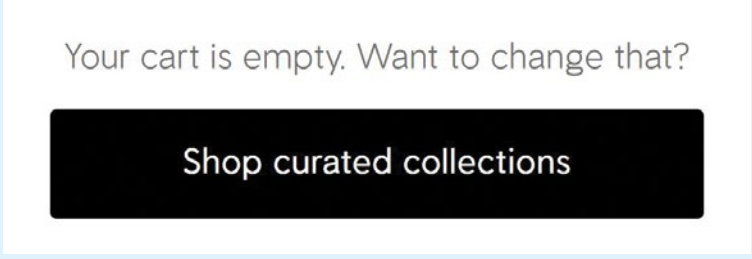


www.bookdepository.com

Society6, the art shop, has a different phrase for each empty state. This is the tooltip shown when the user hovers over the empty cart icon:



And this appears on the empty cart page:



www.society6.com

3. Empty states of search results

When users are searching for something, but the system can't find it, it returns an empty state. As developers put it: "*The query produced no results*", or "*No results were found for the values entered*". But you must never write anything about the system to your users, nor about queries or values. Never mention any of these terms outside the confines of your office. Also, don't ask them to perform another search, they simply won't find it again. And of course, don't leave it at "*No results*" or "*No results were found*". Here also, instead of leaving your users at a dead end, you can direct them to the next step and keep them moving on your product.

1. **Explain the situation**. Tell your users clearly that you didn't find what they were looking for. You might want to use empathy or even humor in the message.

2. **Suggest one of the following**:

   a. Other ways to search for the same thing. Select the method that is most relevant to your type of content:

   - Search by category
   - Search for a more general term
   - Search for a more specific term
   - Check your spelling
   - Try to use synonyms

   b. Things that are similar to what they searched for. Suggest items or links that are as close as possible:

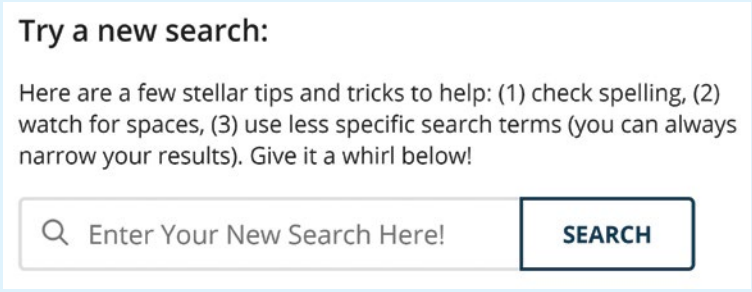
   - Other items by the same designer, writer, manufacturer, and so on (for example, other Toyota cars)
   - Other items with similar specifications but from other manufacturers (for example, other cars from 2009)
   - Other items of the same type or style or feature (for example, other family cars)

   c. Did you mean... If your search engine can find similar terms, like Google does, it's worthwhile offering these results to your users and maybe save them the need to run another search.

With each of these three options you need to really understand what the users are trying to accomplish by making their search, and then offer them something that gets them closer to that.

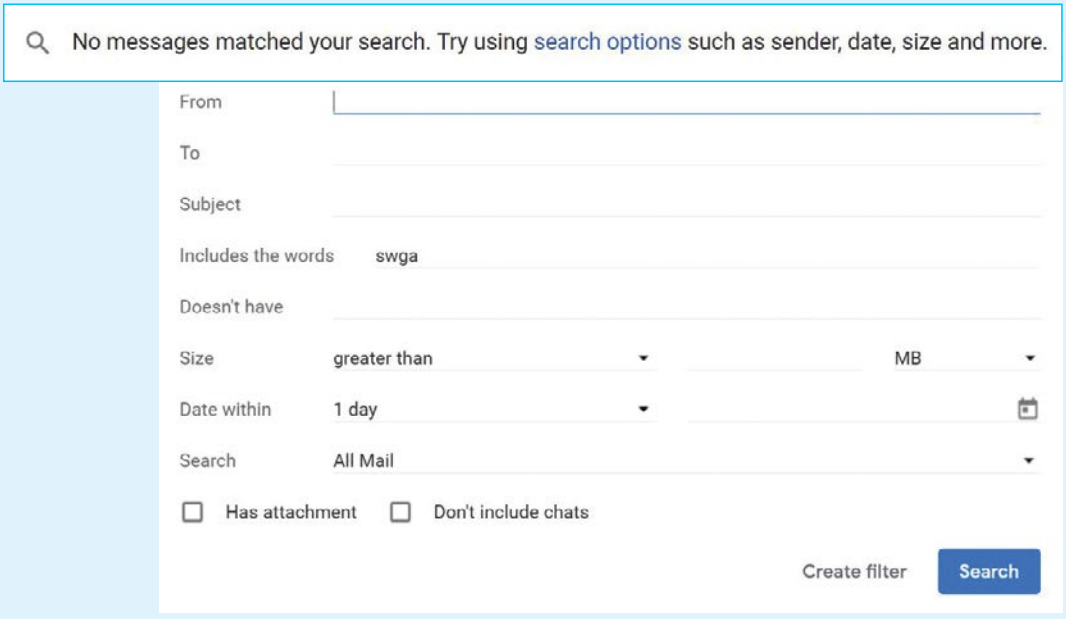
Examples of empty states of search results

Zappos provides three search tips and a new search box below them. Very efficient.



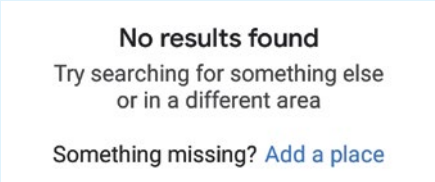
www.zappos.com

Gmail offers a link to more search options. Clicking it opens an advanced search box.



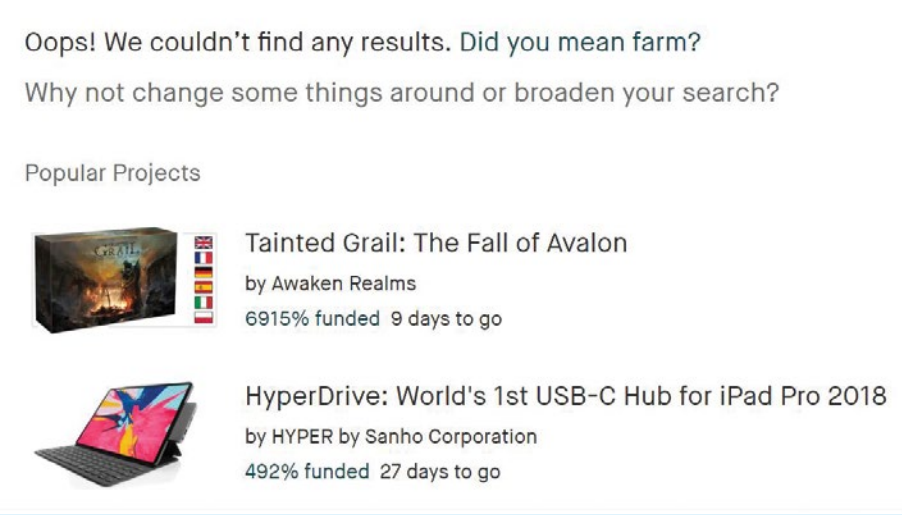
www.gmail.com

Google Maps suggests you'll try a different area or add a missing place. With a link of course.



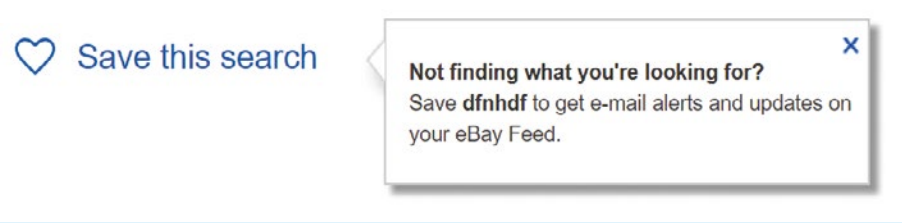
Google Maps app

Kickstarter suggests a correction (*did you mean something else?*) with a link, gives a search tip (*broaden your search*), and presents some popular projects in case you're only browsing. Imagine that all of this helpful information was just – *Sorry, no results...*



www.kickstarter.com

When **Ebay** doesn't find something, they offer users to save the search so they can get alerts about it in the future. What a great idea.



www.ebay.com

CHAPTER 10

PLACEHOLDERS

IN THIS CHAPTER

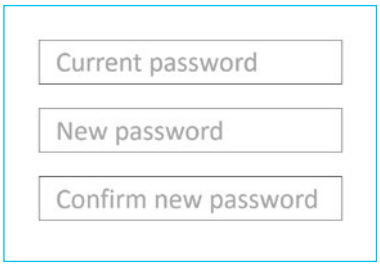
When you shouldn't use placeholders, and when you shouldn't

6 types of placeholders and how to use them

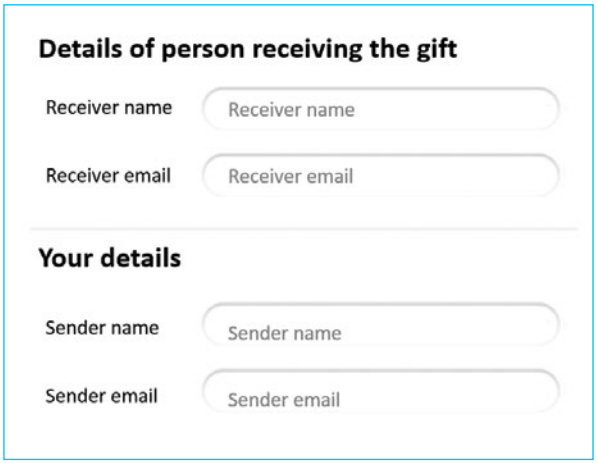
When a placeholder is needed, and more important, when it isn't

Placeholders are the text you write inside a field, usually in a light shade, until the user starts to type. If everything works properly, the placeholder should either disappear or move as soon as the user places the cursor in the field.

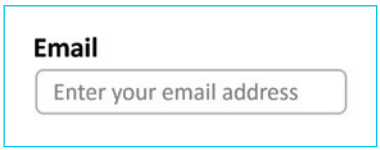
Since smartphones took over our lives and introduced the need to use space sparingly, the practice of writing the field labels inside the fields as placeholders became popular. For example:



This practice made its way to the desktop, even when there is no real space restriction. In fact, it has become so pervasive that sometimes designers are incapable of leaving the fields empty, and feel the need to fill them, even if it creates a weird redundancy:



And even if it means overcoming the redundancy in creative ways...

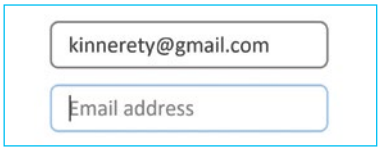


So first thing, here are two important principles:

1. Separate the labels and the placeholders

The label is the title or question that tells the users what information they are supposed to enter in the field. That is its only function, nothing else.

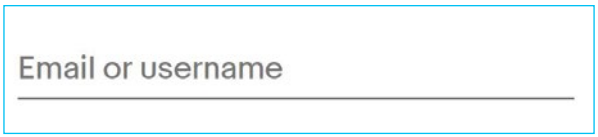
If you put the label inside the field, you present users with a challenge to their short term memory. The label disappears when users start typing, and there is no way for them to go back and remember what they were supposed to provide here. The most important piece of information just isn't there anymore. Granted that when talking about email and password fields the problem is less severe, because users know what is expected of them, but it hasn't completely disappeared. For example, two fields were displayed in a login form. Force of habit made me type my email address in the first box, but then...



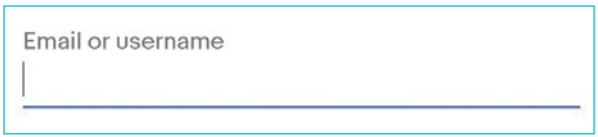
Wait a minute, what was I supposed to provide in the first field? I had no idea and needed to delete the email address so that I could find out.

One way of solving this problem is that as soon as the user places the cursor in the field, the placeholder doesn't disappear but moves above or outside the field.

Look what happens at **eBay** before placing the cursor in the field:



And after:



www.ebay.com

Another option, which is always best (unless you have an extreme shortage of space), is to leave the labels as labels, **outside the field, permanently displayed and in a contrasting color** (also good for accessibility! See Chapter 18). The rule is simple: making it obvious, eye catching, easy to understand and unchallenging will make it easier for all users. And if you have a problem of space, you can always place the labels above the fields not next to them.

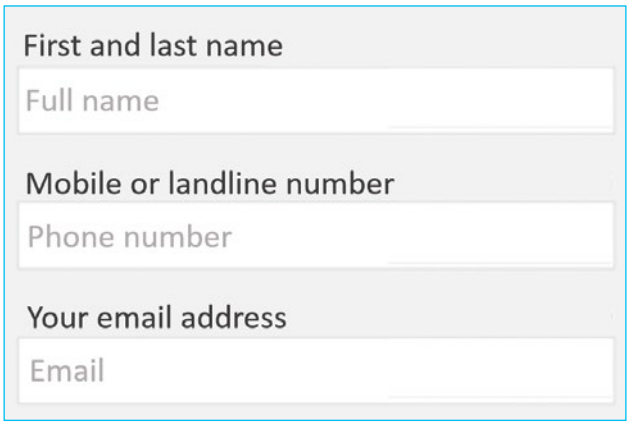
2. Don't add placeholders if there isn't a good reason

When users first see a form, it needs to look as simple as possible and provide the feeling that there's not much work, or that it's easy to fill out.

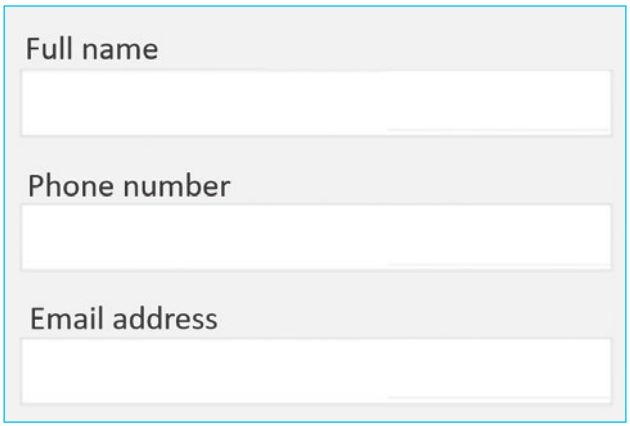
Blocks of text immediately negate this feeling, because users need to read all those words, work in itself; and also a lot of text hints at a lot of work. Therefore in forms and other areas where users need to complete tasks, the rule is always, **as few words as possible**.

Please go ahead and read the article "Placeholders in form fields are harmful" by Katie Sherwin (Nielsen Norman Group).

When you add both labels and placeholders to every field, you are actually **doubling the amount of text on the form**, and it looks busy, crowded and difficult to fill. For example, the following form is simple enough, but the placeholders make it look crowded, especially as they don't add anything to what the labels provide, and thus don't serve any purpose.



This is totally unnecessary. Without placeholders, and with the right labels, the form seems as simple as it actually is:



Note that the empty fields really catch the eye and make you want to type something in them. If you want users to express themselves, give them the space to do it.

In the article by Katie Sherwin I mentioned earlier, she writes: "*Eyetracking studies show that users' eyes are drawn to empty fields. At the minimum, users will spend more time locating a non-empty field. At the worst, they will overlook the field completely – a potential business-killing disaster*".

In conclusion, don't add placeholders just to fill up the space. Only add them when there is a good reason and they help you accomplish a specific goal. When you know what that goal is, you will be able to choose the placeholder that best suites it. In the following pages, I provide examples of the various types of placeholders and how to use them.

TIP

18

Wait a minute, how many characters did you say?

It's unadvisable to put hints or instructions as placeholders, because your users might need to refer to them while typing, and they'll need to delete what they've already entered to see the advice.

If you have instructions about a specific field, such as the rules for a password, restrictions on specific values, or a limitation on the number of characters, write these beneath the label, or in a tooltip, or in any other way you see fit (see Chapter 14 for various possible ways) – as long as users can come back and see the instructions at any time, even while typing.

When you should use placeholders

If you shouldn't put labels as placeholders, and you shouldn't use placeholders as guidelines that the users need to remember, when should you use placeholders?

1. **Fields that you especially want your users to complete**. For example, if you have a search box on your homepage that encourages users to explore the site. You usually find this at the top of the homepage, in its place of honor, with motivational text next to it, and a search button after it (you'll see examples soon). Another very important field is the one that serves the main goal of the product. For example, the status field in Facebook or the profile fields on a dating site (without statuses or full profiles there isn't anything users can do on these sites). In these important fields, putting a placeholder motivates users to action and moves things along.

2. **Fields that users might not understand, avoid or shy away from**. For example, questions that can be answered in a number of ways, open questions that require consideration and time, questions where it is difficult to pin down the answer, questions requiring sensitive information, or questions where users might have other aversions to answering them (examples coming right up). In such fields it pays off to use placeholders that help users overcome the obstacles, and pave the way to filling in the fields with peace of mind.

Another reason to add placeholders is simply to make your users laugh, and I'll go into that in the last section of this chapter.

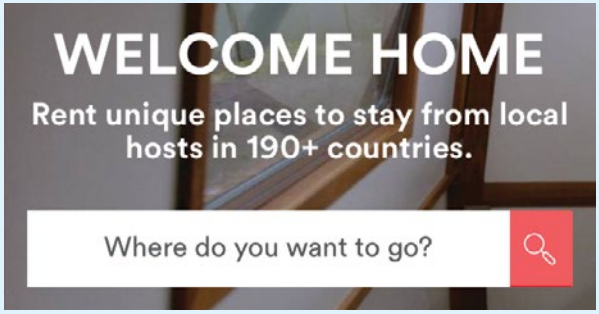
Six types of placeholders and how to use them

Type #1: Questions

An interesting personal question in an especially important field, will awaken in your users the need to answer, drive up the traffic and increase user actions on your product. Ask a direct question (preferably in the second-person: you) that interests them, that they want to answer, and that has a simple and short answer.

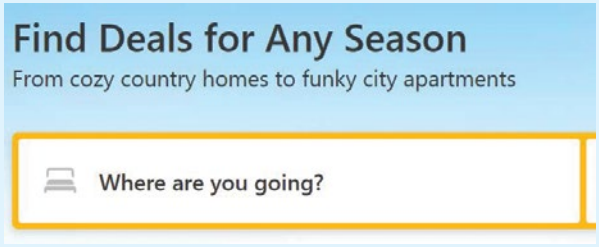
Examples

Airbnb used to ask where you want to travel to. Show me the person who doesn't have the answer to this question... Moreover, the question makes me want to take a quick peek and check what is available at my dream destination. I expect that this is exactly what Airbnb wanted to happen.



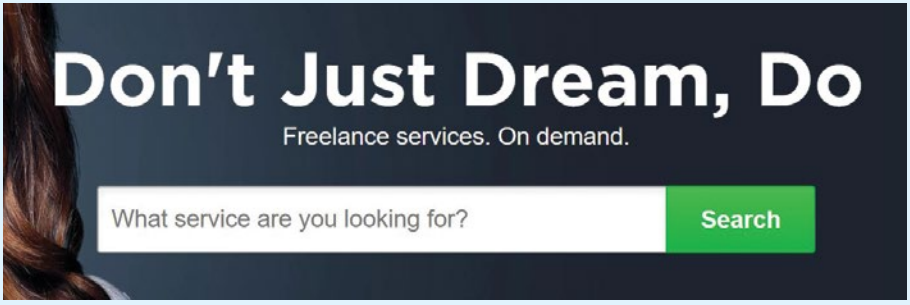
www.airbnb.com (a previous version)

Similarly, **Booking.com** asks:



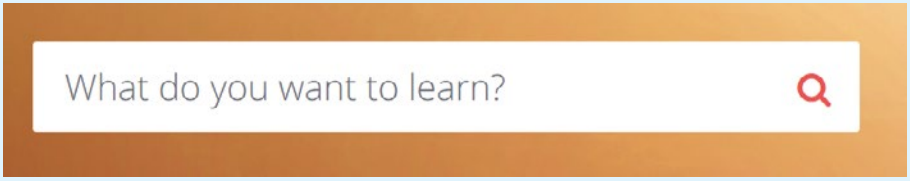
www.booking.com

Fiverr asks in the field "*What service are you looking for?*" The text that precedes the field, together with the placeholder, make for a very practical call to action, a kind of a promise that everything can be done right here, just say what you need. The question also informs users what type of search terms will get the best results on this platform – services. By the way, they could also achieve that by using examples (I'll discuss that later in the chapter).



www.fiverr.com

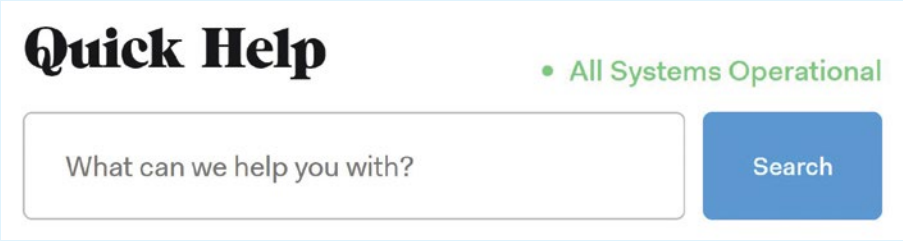
Udemy, the online courses platform, asks on their homepage:



www.udemy.com

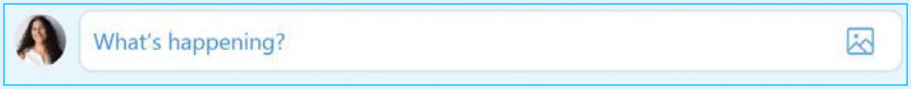
In all previous examples, the placeholder on the site's homepage not only motivates users to find their personal answer and dive into the site, it also enables them to go directly to what interests them, instead of searching through a hierarchical set of menus.

WeTransfer does the same thing with a question as a placeholder in its support area.



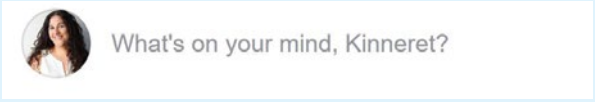
www.wetransfer.com

Twitter asks "*What's happening?*". The question that you decide to put as a placeholder on your site, dictates the style of the answer you'll receive. So it's no wonder that Twitter became the preferred social media users check to get up-to-date reports from the field.



www.twitter.com

Facebook asks me what I'm thinking about. They don't steer my thoughts towards something that's happening outside, but towards something that is happening in my own head. And endless passing thoughts are exactly what you'll find there.



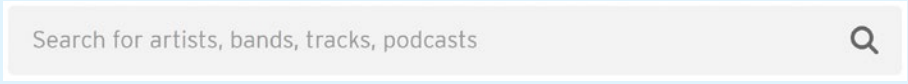
www.facebook.com

Type #2: Categories

Defining categories helps reduce the choice range, enabling users to focus on the possibilities, and guiding them on the best way to use the field. As with question placeholders, categories also encourage users to enter something that personally interests them.

Examples

SoundCloud, the audio platform, details what you can find here in four categories.



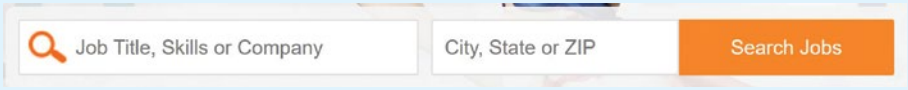
www.soundcloud.com

Hipmunk, the vacation planner, explains what you can search for in order to find a hotel.



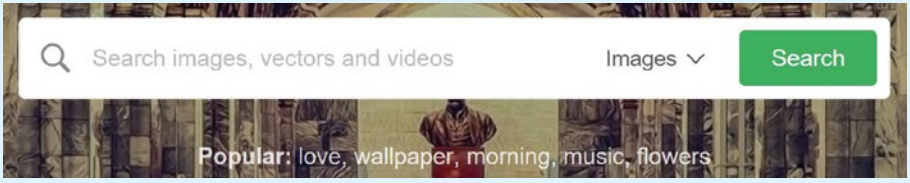
www.hipmunk.com

SimplyHired, the job board, offers three categories for finding a job, and three for choosing its location.



www.simplyhired.com

Pixabay is a platform for sharing free stock photos. The placeholder suggests the best search categories, and below the field there are a few examples to make things even clearer. We'll talk about using examples on the next page.



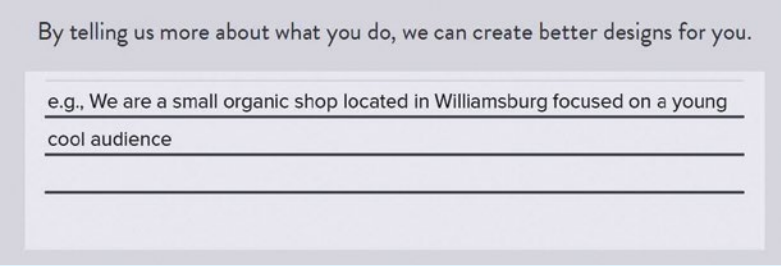
www.pixabay.com

Type #3: Examples

Sometimes an example (or even two or three, but no more) will show your users the best way of using the field.

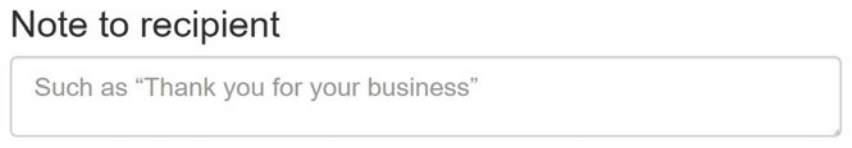
Examples

Tailor Brands is a logo generator. The users are invited to describe their business, and the example, given as a placeholder, provides the type of required information: size, industry, location and target audience.



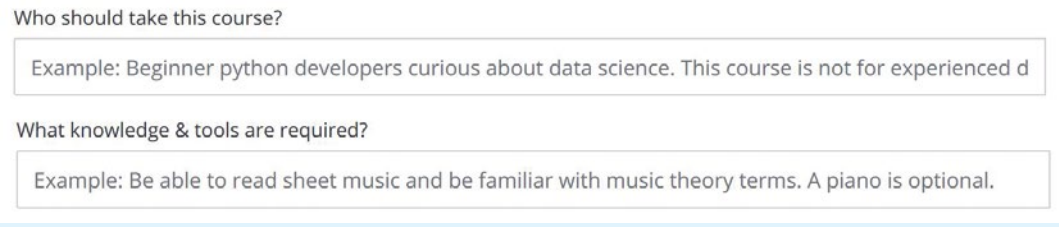
www.tailorbrands.com

On the payment request form, **PayPal**'s example reminds you that a business note can also be personal.



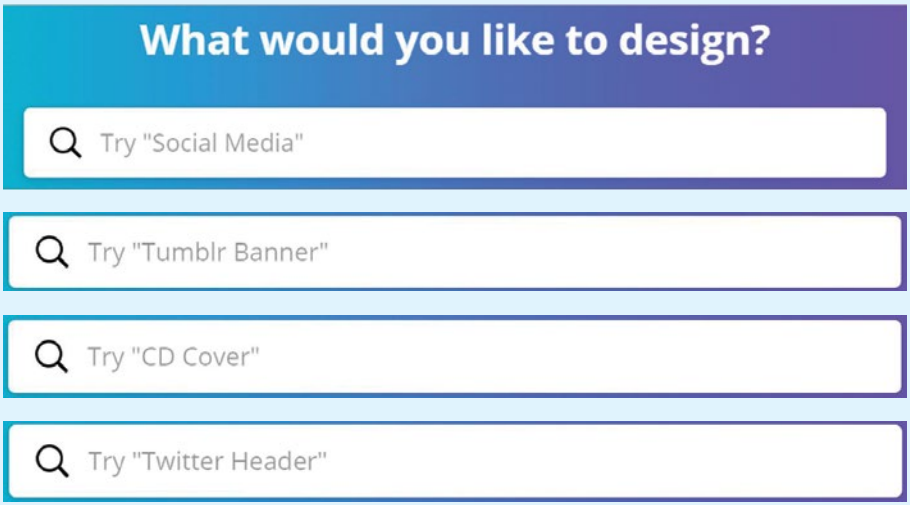
www.paypal.com

Udemy, the online learning platform, uses examples to help instructors describe their course in a very practical way.



www.udemy.com

Canva, the design platform, gives examples of design templates, which change every time you enter the site:



www.canva.com

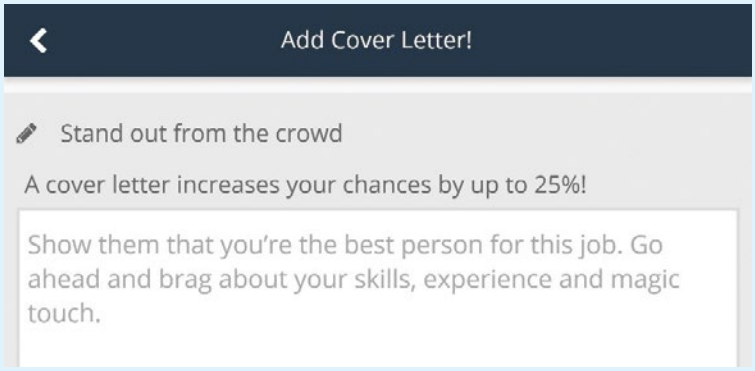
Type #4: Guiding sentence

Open questions require users to think. But if there is something users don't like doing, it is needing to think in the middle of a task. All they want to do is fill out the form and carry on.

So, when you use open questions, the purpose of the placeholder is to give the users a lead and focus them on what's important, thus making it easier for them and encouraging them to answer.

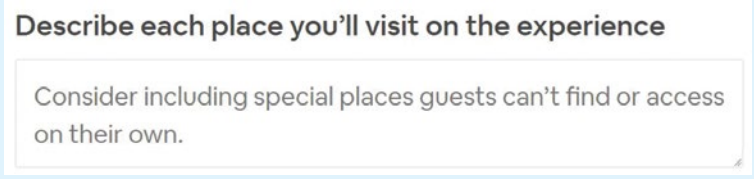
Examples

On the **RealMatch** job boards, applicants can attach a cover letter to the resume. Writing a cover letter demands a lot of thought, and many candidates decide to skip this step, even though it can significantly increase their chance of receiving an answer from prospective employers. To help them start, the placeholder makes clear the purpose of the cover letter and provides the main topics the users can write about.



RealMatch Job Boards

When posting an experience to **Airbnb**, they introduce guiding placeholders to help you make it sound more attractive to guests.



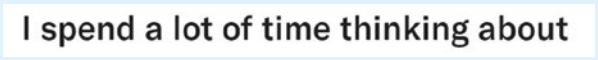
www.airbnb.com

Type #5: Remove obstacles

If you know that users have an issue that prevents them from answering your question, the placeholder can appeal directly to this obstacle and try to remove it.

Example

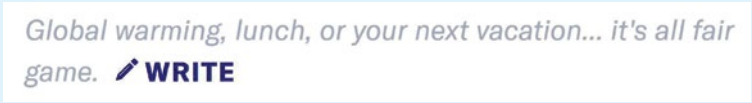
When filling out the profile on the **OkCupid** dating site, there are a number of open questions that are challenging to answer. Each question appears above the field, one of which asks:



www.okcupid.com

Users need to enter here an area of interest that they think about a lot. But they might worry that most things they think about are not very interesting to potential partners (too trivial, too heavy, a bit strange, not important enough or too important...). This apprehension might cause them not to answer honestly, or even not to answer at all.

So, the placeholder puts it this way:



The placeholder removes the obstacle by combining examples that are very important (global warming), not important (lunch) or very common (next vacation). And at the end they also add a calming phrase – exactly what the users need to hear so that they can let go and give an honest answer.

And if we are already talking about **OkCupid**, I warmly recommend – even to the happily married among you – to visit the site and check out profile questions and placeholders. The microcopy around fields greatly reduces the confusion and concern and makes filling out the form simple and even fun.

Type #6: It's also possible just to have some fun

Sometimes placeholders are simply designed to amuse users. That's excellent, but remember that with forms the purpose is to let users complete them as fast as possible. So usually, that won't be the place to joke with them, unless it's an integral part of your voice and tone, and fits the atmosphere of the product. Or it might just be a fun form where no one is in a hurry.

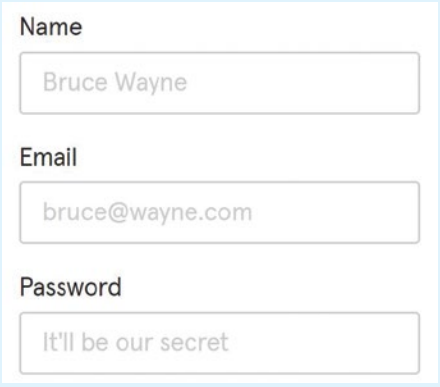
Examples

On the **Trello** sign up form the placeholders are meant to make users smile. Each time, a different fictional character from a TV series, film, book or video game, appears in the field.



www.trello.com

And this is from **Typeform**.



www.typeform.com

CHAPTER 11

BUTTONS

IN THIS CHAPTER

Basic principles of writing converting buttons

What click triggers are and how to use them

Push the right buttons

The importance of buttons cannot be overrated. So that users can get what they came for, and so that their browsing turns into your desired outcome, i.e. a conversion, users must click a button. The button is therefore the point when a decision becomes an action, so give it the time and thought it deserves (and also time to test it if possible). Don't settle for generic terms that won't move your users, that's like slowing down just before the finish line.

Before we dive into best practices of writing text that accompanies buttons, an important remark:

Test, test, test – Microcopy for buttons is full of surprises, and changing just one word on the button can increase or drop conversion rates significantly (there are many examples of this on the Internet, just google "buttons copy"). If you want to maximize your conversion rate, invest in A/B testing. It's an investment that will pay off. Why do you still need best practices? So that you can select one of two excellent choices, instead of from two mediocre ones.

"What do I get" rather than "How do I get it"

Generic words like **Download**, **Search**, **Send**, or **Register** don't help users make a decision. When users get to one of these generic buttons, they need to balance up the pros and cons on their own, remember what they have read and understood so far, and decide for themselves if it's worth it or not to click the button.

Another problem with these generic words is that they usually emphasize what users have to do, the hard work.

So what do you write instead? Michael Aagaard tested buttons for four years and came up with the following formula:

Value + Relevance = Conversions

In the article "How to Write a Call-to-Action that Converts", Aagaard writes that instead of writing on the button what the user **does** (the action), we need to explicitly write what the user **gets** (the value). For example, when he changed the copy on a button from **Order information** to **Get information**, conversions went up by nearly 40%!

The reason for this is that the "order" button emphasizes what users have to **do**, not what they're going to **get**. It doesn't give them enough value to want to click the button.

When the button focuses on the action and not the value, we are leaving it up to the users to draw conclusions, and there's no way of knowing where their train of thought might take them. However, if you write the value on the button, you are offering the exact bottom line they're looking for, and that's a much bigger motivator.

The second variable in Aagaard's equation is **relevance**. Value by itself could still be too general, and Aagaard's tests showed that buttons with specific microcopy relevant to a certain context, convert better. In other words, not only **Download for free**, but **Download the guide for free**, or even better: **Get your free guide**. Here also, the right fine-tuning can increase conversion by dozens of percents. And if the length of the button copy seems daunting, you can relax. Buttons offering the relevant value raise conversions even if they are long. But don't just take my word for it, check it out for yourself.

Heads up: not every button on your product needs to provide significant value. When I talk about value I mean **only those buttons that generate conversions or an action that's important for you**, such as signing up, generating leads or downloading. And if the most important action on your product is, for example, search, comment, or watching a sales video – then those are the buttons you should invest in.

However, most of the button microcopy on your product will probably be functional guidelines, that can remain – and it's even best that they remain – standard, obvious and well known to users: **Continue**, **Add to basket**, **Chat with us**, **Pay securely**, **Edit**, **Share**, **Compose**, **Upload**, **Save**, and so on.

Example

Three different digital invoicing systems offer a 30-day free trial. Their buttons are slightly different from one another:

	Button on the homepage leading to the sign up form for the free trial	Button at the end of the sign up form for the free trial
1	Sign up now	Create account
2	Sign up now 30-day free trial	Start free trial
3	Sign up now 30-day free trial no commitment	Send and start using the system

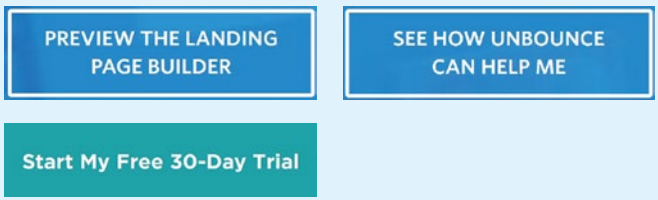
In the **first system** (row 1), both buttons refer to the action that users need to take, and neither of them provides the value that makes it worthwhile to click the button (unless one of your hobbies is creating accounts all over the Internet). There's also no relevancy, both buttons are completely generic, and you could put them exactly as they appear here on any other digital product – and they'll fit in just fine.

In **systems 2 and 3** (rows 2 and 3), the buttons on the homepage (left column) do indeed talk about the action users need to take, but immediately remind them of the value: a 30-day free trial. However, as these buttons appear on the homepage, maybe it would have been better to write **only** the value: Get a 30-day free trial, and not even mention the sign up process, which might sound complicated and deter users from clicking the button.

If we wrote on the homepage button the benefit of a 30-day free trial, what should the button at the end of the form say (right column)? The final value, creating invoices. In **system 3** (row 3, right column), they indeed provided a similar value, **Start using the system**, but the relevancy is only partial here, as this button could actually fit into any system, and it still hints at the hard work users have to do and not what they get as a result of that work. A more relevant phrasing is: **Start creating digital invoices**.

More examples

unbounce specializes in building landing pages optimized for conversion.They have buttons with loads of values. They seem long and as a writer you might feel that you want to get rid of quite a lot of words, but to the users they deliver important information, and no one said that buttons need to be short.



www.unbounce.com



With purchase buttons, the more mundane - the better

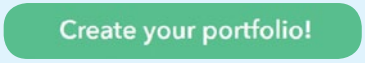
Add to cart means add the item to the cart, and that's it. Users expect that adding an item to their cart will only save it for future consideration or purchase. They don't intend to commit to it just yet and begin the payment process. **Anything else you write will only increase users' level of uncertainty.** For example, *I want this*, *I pick this*, or any similar expression will immediately raise unnecessary doubts about what does this button actually do and where will it take me.

The checkout button should also be clear (at most it can be **Secured checkout** or **Checkout securely**, as we'll see on Chapter 16), so that only users who really want to proceed to payment will click on it. This is also true for that final button: **Confirm payment**, **Place order**, or **Submit purchase**.

Further more, UniqUI's research (in Hebrew) found that **deviations from the standard process of purchasing lower conversion rates.** So it's really not the time and place to reinvent the wheel.

And a few more in conclusion

Sign up →



www.carbonmade.com

Sign up →



www.goodui.com

Sign up →



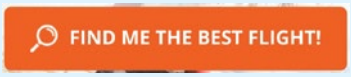
www.themiddlefingerproject.com

Search →



www.indeed.com

Search →



Loco app

Start →



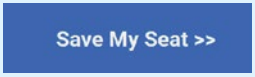
www.myperfectresume.com

Start →



www.ziprecruiter.com

Register →



www.leadpages.net

Register →



www.themiddlefingerproject.com

TIP 19

Remind me why I wanted to sign up

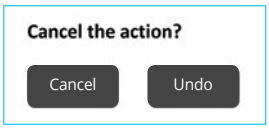
The Sign up button at the end of the sign up form can be much more interesting and motivating if you ask yourself how users benefit from signing up, or what they can start doing afterwards. Thus instead of writing only **Sign up**, you can write **Sign up and – start saving recipes, start learning French, create a professional logo, see jobs that suit you**, and so on.

Besides, if those who sign up receive a discount or gift, you can write it on the button. **Get free credit**, or **Get 25% off!** Buttons like these transfer the weight from the registration to the reason for registering, and can be very effective.

TIP 20

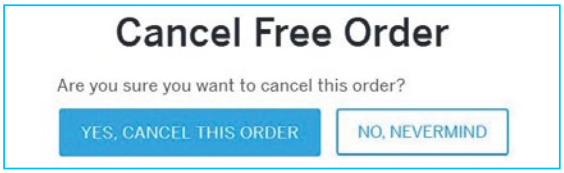
What on earth am I cancelling?

Other buttons that need special attention are the cancel action buttons. These buttons can be really confusing. For example:



What is cancelled by the **Cancel** button, the action or the cancellation request?

In such cases, instead of **Undo** and **Cancel**, it's better to use the words **Yes** and **No**, and add a word or two to make it conclusive. For example:



www.eventbrite.com

Click Triggers - the last minute message that tips the scale

Joanna Wiebe shows in **Buttons and Click-Boosting Calls to Action** how short messages written **next** to the button can significantly increase conversions just like the main microcopy **on** the button. She calls these short sentences **click triggers**.

The goal of click triggers is to tell users exactly those words required to tip the scale at the split second it takes for the decision to be taken. They are supposed to get users to respond immediately and turn intention into action.

Next to (or beneath or above) every button important for you, it's worthwhile writing at least one click trigger, whether it's signing up for a newsletter, signing up for the product, watching a demo video or purchasing something.

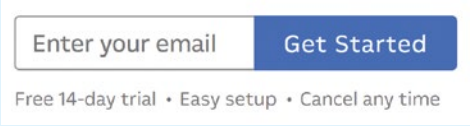
Just like the microcopy on the button, click triggers can also remind users about the value they'll get if they click. But they can also work in another very interesting way: remove concerns that accompany clicking and pave the way to make it happen.

You should carefully choose the click trigger based on the objectives of your users on the product and according to the things that deter them most. Even if you have already addressed these issues in other places on the product, a short reminder next to the button can create the desired response (learn more about alleviating concerns on Chapter 16).

If necessary you can even write 2-3 click triggers, but don't overdo it: carefully select those that are the most influential, and as usual, run A/B testing.

Examples

Intercom's click triggers are great. The three of them together form an image of an easy to use product that you can only benefit from trying. Didn't like it? You can cancel without losing time or money.



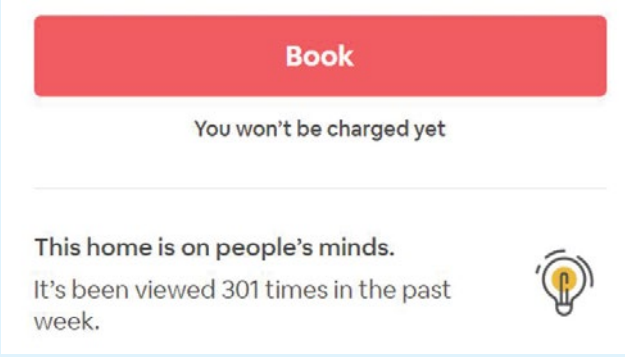
www.intercom.com

Booking.com excels in writing effective click triggers. They use loads of social proofs to show the value of the room, and especially to induce a sense of urgency. When users are deliberating on whether to click the button or not, the social proof that the hotel is well liked by others can be a trigger, and it also provides the feeling that if they don't book now they'll lose the room.



www.booking.com

Similarly, when pondering whether to book a home on **Airbnb**, there are two click triggers beneath the button: the first alleviates a concern, and the second does the opposite.



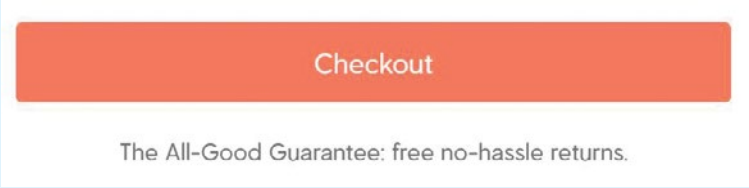
www.airbnb.com

Showpo does the same with fashion items – you snooze, you lose:



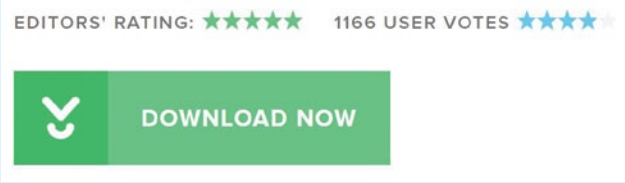
www.showpo.com

Society6 alleviates a major concern of shoppers – if I don't like the product I bought, can I return it? Will you give me a hard time returning it? The answer is no, and when users know that, it's much easier for them to continue to checkout. In the worst-case scenario, they'll easily return the product, no big deal.



www.society6.com

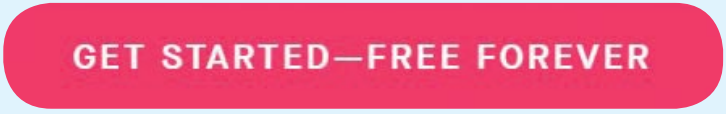
High ratings are a common social proof, and you can use them as click triggers too. This is how it's done on **Download**.



www.download.com

Here is an example of a click trigger appearing on the button itself:

InVision – free forever!



www.invisionapp.com

CHAPTER 12

404 ERROR: PAGE NOT FOUND

IN THIS CHAPTER

4 things every 404 page needs to include

Ideas for perfectly branded 404 pages

Black holes on the Internet

Renny Gleeson summarized his very short TED lecture on 404 pages ("404, the story of a page not found") thus:

> ***A simple mistake can tell me what you're not,***
> ***or it can remind me of why I should love you.***

Users encounter a 404 page when searching for one that no longer exists on your site (or that was never there in the first place). This might happen if you leave a link somewhere on your site or the Internet to a page that no longer exists, or its address has changed; and it can also occur because users typed a wrong URL.

Ideally, your users are not supposed to see 404s, or at least only see them rarely. However, it is still an important page. If the users got here from the Google search results page or from another site that referred to you, and found only this:

404 error: Page Not Found

they will immediately hit "back", and you lost them. The chances they'll explore other pages on your site are zero. They have no idea how to continue from here, and they have no good reason to try. Moreover, as Gleeson said, the 404 page tells users a lot about your brand. For example, how you deal with your own mistakes, how you deal with user errors, and how you treat users when they encounter a problem or are disappointed.

The standard message as above shows that the writers of the page did not understand either the users or the problem (if someone even gave it some attention). Technically, such a message does not help users understand what went wrong, nor help them get to where they want to go. It's a dead end. Even emotionally, it doesn't show any empathy for the disappointment felt by users because they couldn't find what they were looking for.

It's important to understand that the design of a 404 page is significant, but it's not enough. **An image without microcopy might raise a smile, but won't help users get to where they want to go.**

How to write microcopy for a 404 page

1. **Explain to the users what happened and how they ended up here.**

   Remember that they don't know what a 404 is. In fact, you don't even need to mention the number 404 or the word error, just explain in simple words, without technical jargon, that the page wasn't found or is no longer here (if your users are digital savvy, it's worth mentioning the term 404, because they probably understand it, but it still shouldn't be the main message).

2. **Show empathy.**

   Because users are disappointed that they didn't find what they were looking for, and sometimes it's our fault, it's worthwhile to show empathy, that is add a word or sentence that demonstrates to the users that you can relate to the way they are feeling right now. You can apologize and you can reflect their feelings (many examples coming up soon).

3. **Point to the way out. It's worthwhile to put one or more of the following:**
   - Links to central areas of the site, to categories that lots of people search for, or pages that you want to direct users to.
   - A search field
   - A link to the homepage
   - If the main menu appears on the 404 page, turn the users' attention to it either with words or a visual sign, and don't count on them seeing and understanding that it's their way out.

4. **A 404 page can, but doesn't have to, include one of the following:**
   - A great design
   - Humor that will turn the negative experience into a positive one (but be careful not to laugh **at** users when they are confused).
   - Provide a way they can report the broken link, something along the lines of: "*If you got here from another site, we'd appreciate it if you told us from where so that we can fix it and save others from ending up here*". Then add a link to the Contact page or a special support form dedicated to this purpose.
   - List the contact details of customer service and support.

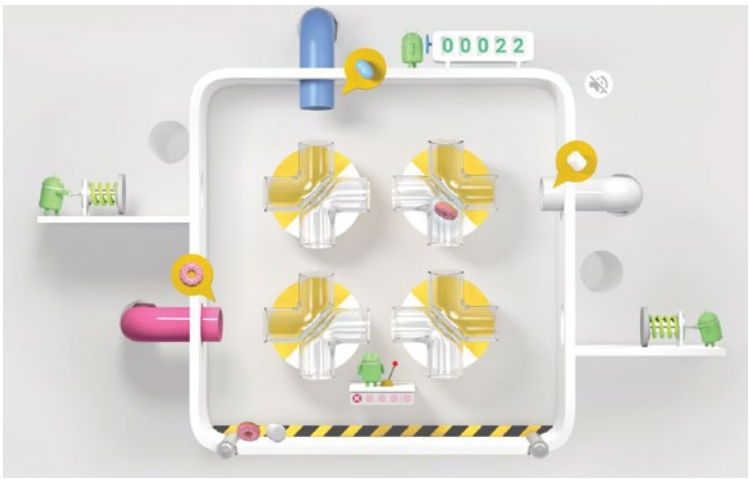
Put things into perspective

There are sites that invest a lot on their 404 page. **Google** developed a game for Android's 404 page (see the screenshot below), and on **Romain Brasier**'s site (www.romainbrasier.fr), there's a game where you need to save 404 lemmings. In the world of microcopy and design, it seems as if more has been written about 404s than any other page, and there are dozens of articles of the type "The 30 best 404 pages ever".

But let's be honest, we are the people who enjoy it most, our users only rarely get to see the page, and then they don't stay around but move forward towards whatever they were looking for in the first place.

It's important that the page creates engagement and a desire to continue from there to the rest of the site. But it's even more important that the page provides full details and the required service. There's no need to go overborad: a simple design or funny picture, clear text with a touch of humor, and three links to central areas on the site, will do a great job.

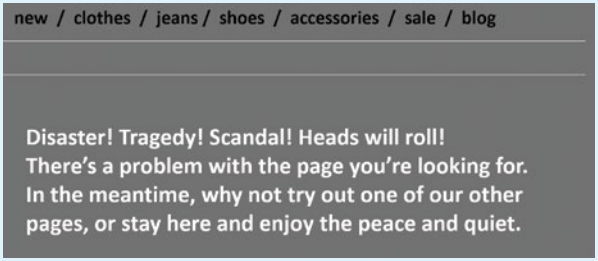
Mind you – Successful 404 pages have provided their owners with a great marketing service, because users shared them. Romain Brasier is one example, as is the **Nosh** video that went viral (look for "Nosh 404" on YouTube). So if the purpose of your 404 is sales, go for it and invest!



www.android.com

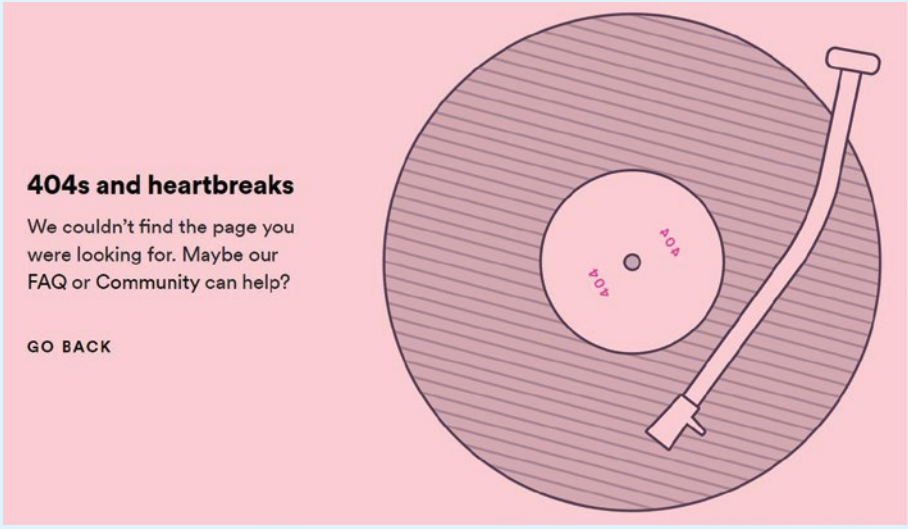
Examples

The 404 of the **Belle and Sue** Israeli fashion shop does not include any design, but it's very funny. It reflects the frustration of users, but also puts things into perspective, using lots of humor. It simply states that there's a problem (users are not interested in the technical details of the problem), and at the end of the message, ways to exit to other pages on the site are offered. Simply lovely.



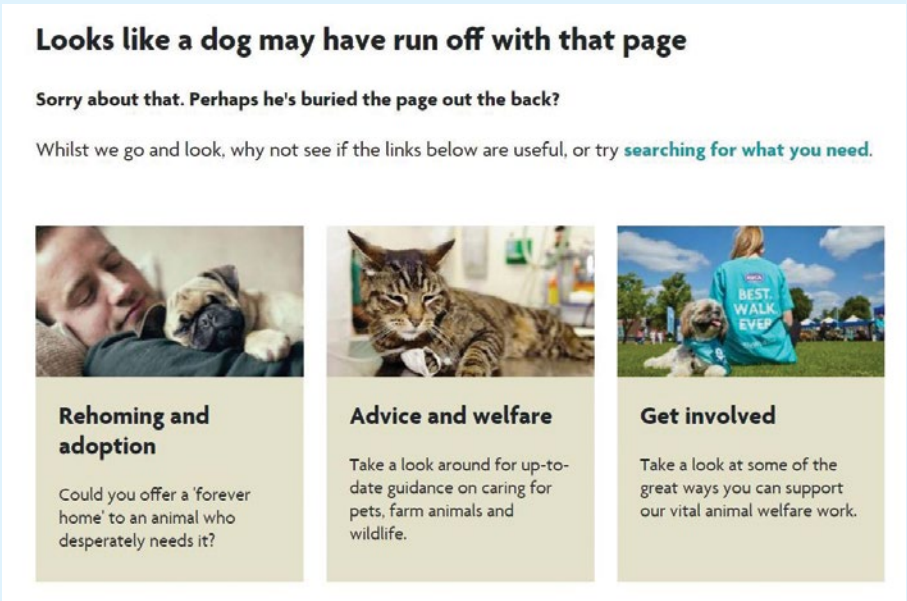
www.belleandsue.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

On this simple but beautiful 404 page by **Spotify**, they name a record (that's actually spinning on the right) with a title that reflects disappointment. They also explain what happened in everyday words, and offer links to FAQ, community and back. The link GO BACK takes users to the homepage, so it would have been better to say exactly that, since they might have arrived here from somewhere else.



www.spotify.com

RSPCA, the royal society for the prevention of cruelty to animals, have a funny copy describing what happened to the page (a dog ran away with it and buried it in the yard, of course), and they give some useful and important links, plus an extra one for further searching in the help center. Super cute and useful, and delivers the society's spirit.

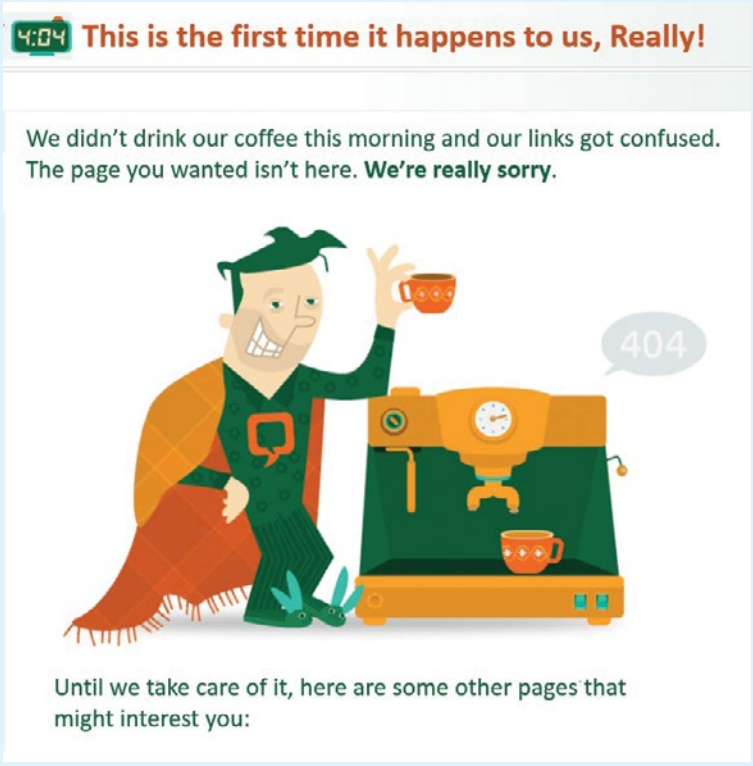


www.rspca.org.uk

Ideas: What else can you put in a 404 apart from microcopy

- Funny pictures
- Graphics that express the frustration the user feels
- Animation
- An explanation, in the voice and tone of your brand, that explains to the user why the page is missing
- Excerpts from songs or films
- YouTube videos

The Israeli UX studio, **Uniq UI**, explains the problem beautifully, using simple words (the term 404 is hinted at for those that understand it), takes full responsibility for the problem, and at the end offers a few links as the way out.



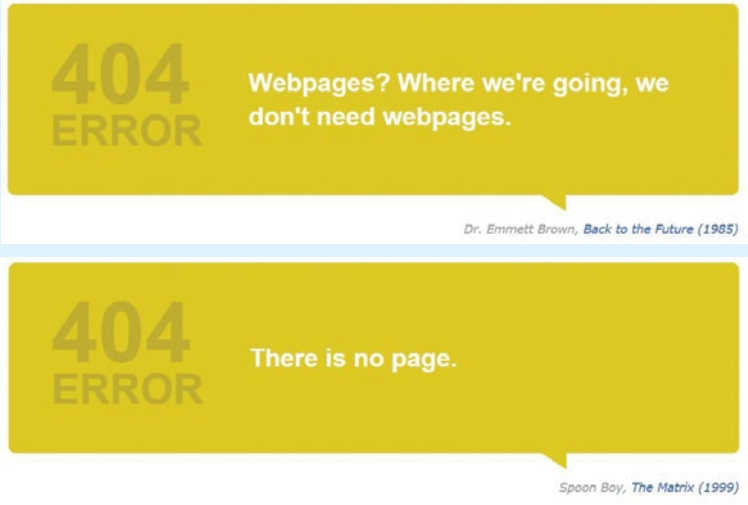
www.uniqui.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

Brand content in 404 pages

In the quote that opened this chapter, Gleeson says that the 404 is also an opportunity to remind users why they love the brand, why they are here. In other words, the page is not only there to help users recover from the error, but is also an opportunity to engage them. To do this, I recommend including on your 404 page ideas taken from the content of your brand. For example, to explain the missing page, use reasons connected to what the brand does, using terminology from relevant content.

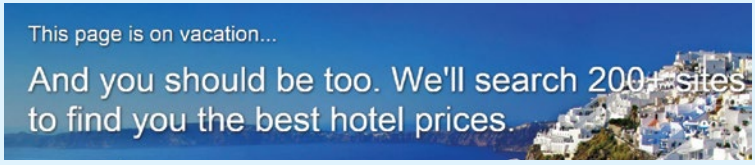
Examples

Every time we see a 404 on the **IMDB** database of cinema and television, it provides a different movie "quote" – there are about 15 of these.



www.imdb.com

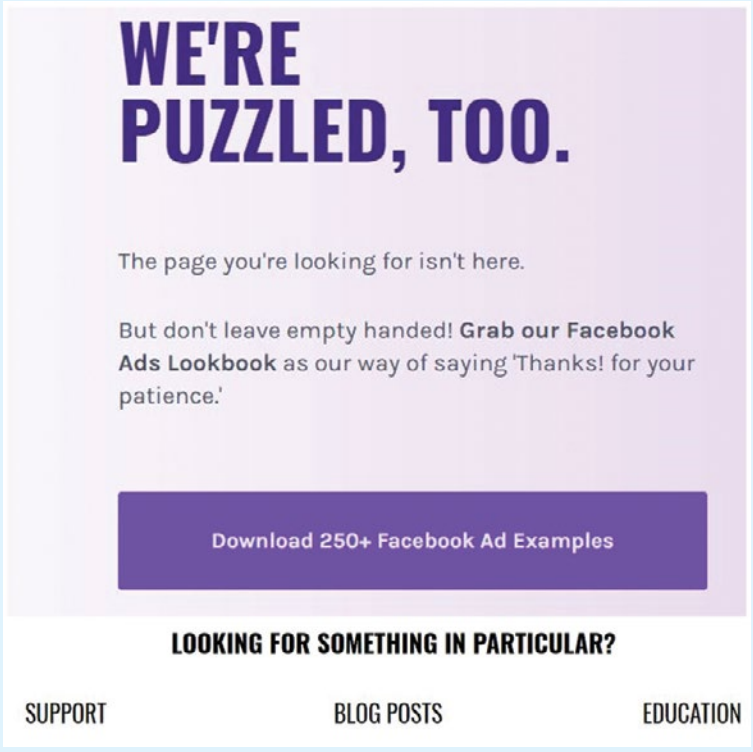
TripAdvisor tells us that the page we are looking for has gone on vacation, and so should we.



www.tripadvisor.com

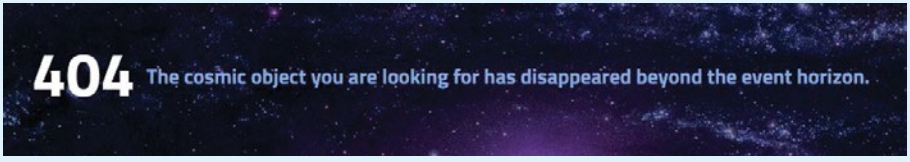
Leadpages specializes in generating leads for their customers through landing pages they build and campaigns they run. On their 404 page they show empathy for the users' disappointment and thank them for their patience, but even more interesting – they offer free relevant content if you provide your email, therefore generating leads. On their 404 page!

I find that creative and efficient, and it shows users that these are pros they're dealing with, and how this service can benefit them too. Below, **Leadpages** present links to three main areas on their website.



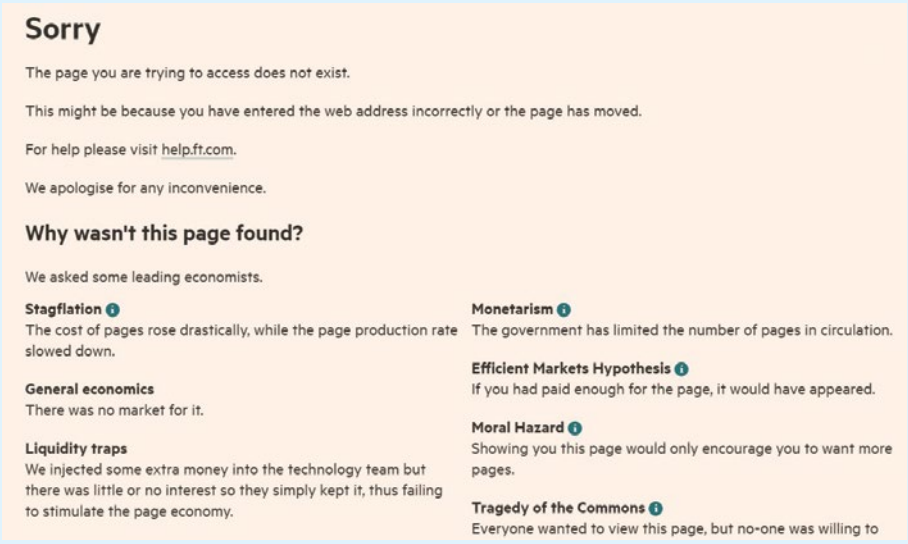
www.leadpages.net

NASA thinks astrophysics and sends users beyond the event horizon.



www.nasa.gov

It appears that the **Financial Times** spent many hours on its 404 in order to explain why the missing page is not there – there are 22 (!) possible economic theories. You really should read the page (type ft.com/404).



Sorry

The page you are trying to access does not exist.

This might be because you have entered the web address incorrectly or the page has moved.

For help please visit help.ft.com.

We apologise for any inconvenience.

Why wasn't this page found?

We asked some leading economists.

Stagflation
The cost of pages rose drastically, while the page production rate slowed down.

General economics
There was no market for it.

Liquidity traps
We injected some extra money into the technology team but there was little or no interest so they simply kept it, thus failing to stimulate the page economy.

Monetarism
The government has limited the number of pages in circulation.

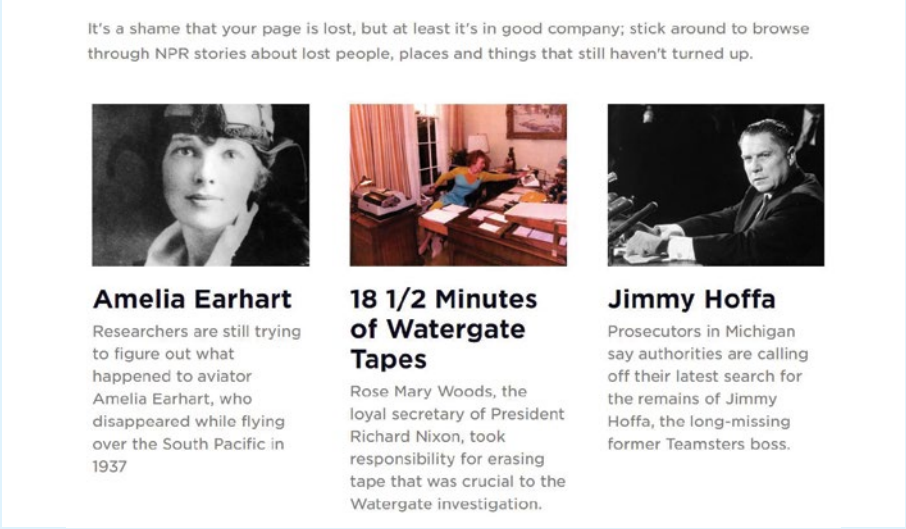
Efficient Markets Hypothesis
If you had paid enough for the page, it would have appeared.

Moral Hazard
Showing you this page would only encourage you to want more pages.

Tragedy of the Commons
Everyone wanted to view this page, but no-one was willing to

www.ft.com

NPR, the news and radio network that stands for brave and responsible journalism, presents on its 404 page news stories about people and items that were lost and never found, exactly like the page you were looking for. Go visit the site and look at the gripping list.



It's a shame that your page is lost, but at least it's in good company; stick around to browse through NPR stories about lost people, places and things that still haven't turned up.

Amelia Earhart

Researchers are still trying to figure out what happened to aviator Amelia Earhart, who disappeared while flying over the South Pacific in 1937

18 1/2 Minutes of Watergate Tapes

Rose Mary Woods, the loyal secretary of President Richard Nixon, took responsibility for erasing tape that was crucial to the Watergate investigation.

Jimmy Hoffa

Prosecutors in Michigan say authorities are calling off their latest search for the remains of Jimmy Hoffa, the long-missing former Teamsters boss.

www.npr.org

CHAPTER 13

WAITING TIME

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why it's important to invest in the waiting time experience

Some ideas on how to pass the time with your users

Quality time with your users

The waiting time is the period it takes a system to load, process data, search, download a file, and so on. And if you are asking yourself why you need to deal with such menial pursuits, then a great article (only in Hebrew for now) by Tal Mishaly, the UX professional consultant for this book, throws some light on this. One fascinating insight from his research on user experience versus usability, is that animation, changing text, or a progress bar all shorten the **perceived** time that passes for the user. In other words, if there is something that keeps users busy while waiting, something to read, look at or follow, time passes quicker, and they perceive the waiting period as being shorter than it really is.

Another reason is that you have a few moments where the user is simply staring at the screen and waiting. Why not use this time to impart something wise, heartwarming or branded? With minimum investment you can prepare another surprise for your users that shows you thought about them and that they are important to you. These small things make all the difference!

It's important to make clear that you can use only graphics, without a single word, during this waiting time. So if you are able to invest in a fun animation – that's great. But words need much less design and development, thus providing a quicker and cheaper solution that works just as well.

So what text can you display during waiting times to make it appear to go a bit faster, and change it from a waste of time into time to engage with your users? Choose one or more of the following.

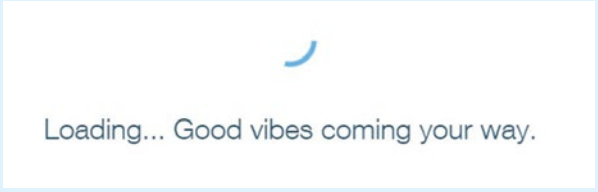
Get your users in the mood

InVision promises an experience for user experience designers.



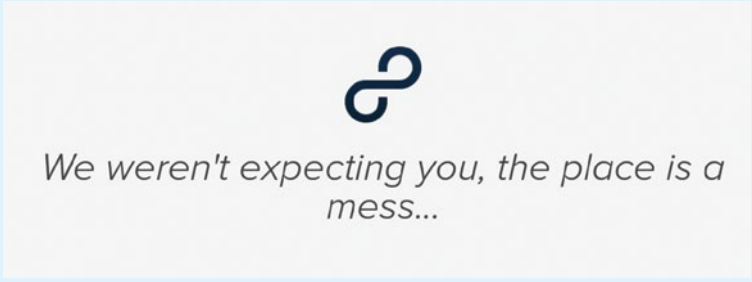
www.invisionapp.com

WIX, the websites building platform, wants its users to be in a good mood while they work.



www.wix.com

8tracks, an app for making and discovering playlists, is fun and funny.

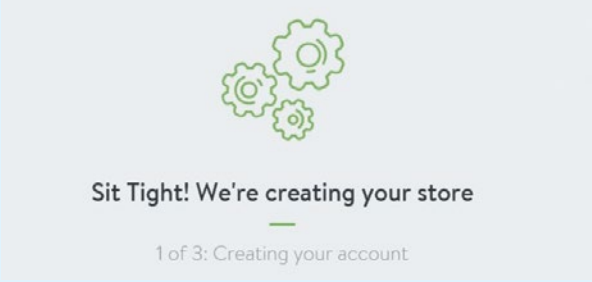


8tracks app

Get the users involved with what the system is doing for them

Users follow the progress of whatever is happening, and that helps pass the time, makes them feel they are taking part in the process, and also builds expectation about what the result will be when the process completes. As we'll soon see, this works even if the stages aren't real...

While waiting for an online store to be generated, **Shopify** updates the users on the stages.



www.shopify.com

Tailor Brands give their users a real sense that a lot of thought was invested in their logo and products design. I assume they want to emphasize that even though the process is automatic, it is well thought, so that the result looks like it was designed by a real designer.

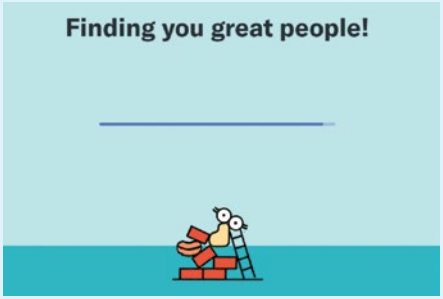






www.tailorbrands.com

At the end of the registration process, **OkCupid** updates users that it's finding great people for them. And this is exactly what the users are here for.



www.okcupid.com

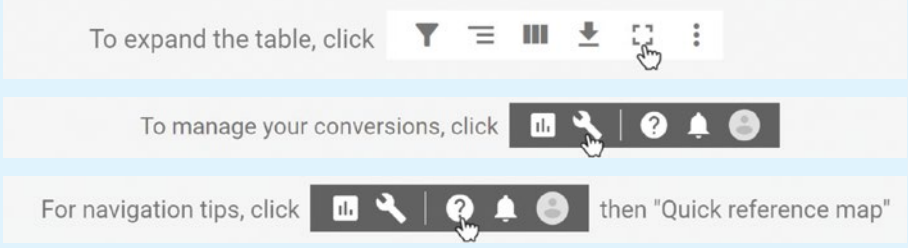
Videostream, the app for Chromecast, offers a humorous take on what's happening.



Videostream app

Tips about how to make the best out of the product (great for complex systems)

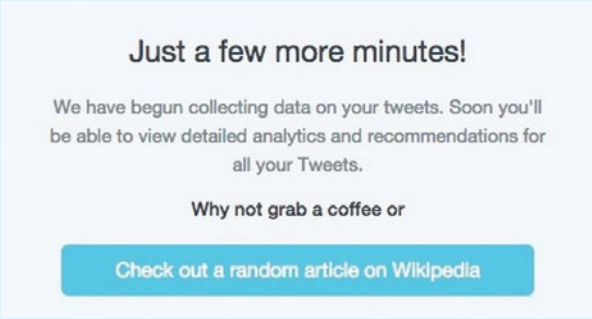
When uploading **Google Ads**, you get a quick tip, which changes every time you enter the system. This is not only a way to pass time, but also a great way to expose the system's features to your users.



www.ads.google.com

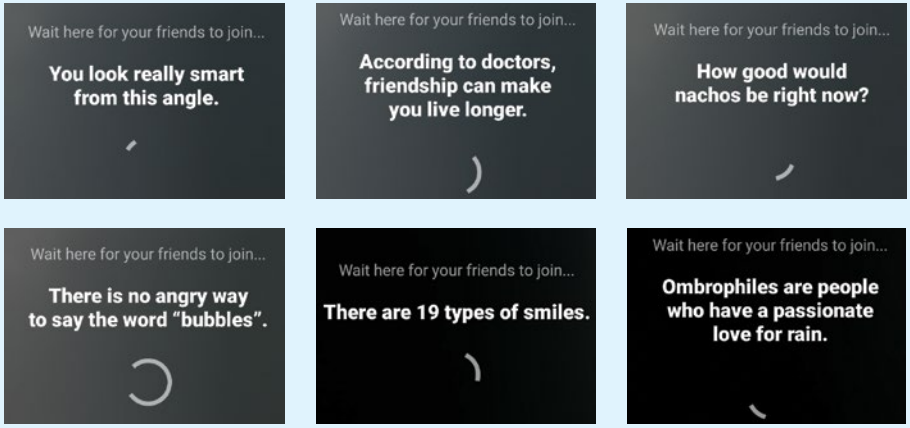
If the wait is expected to take a long time, you can suggest that users do something else in the meantime

Twitter Counter, the site that monitors a user's follower count on Twitter, promises that at the end of the waiting time, we can look forward to valuable information. It suggests that while the system collects data and analyzes the results, the user can make a cup of coffee or read a random article on Wikipedia, and it includes a direct link (not to the coffee :( ).



www.twittercounter.com

On the app **HouseParty**, waiting for your friends to join the video chat is a part of the experience and may take a while. In the meantime, the app provides you with dozens of remarks, things to think about and fun facts. When your friends join you, you're sure to have something to talk about.



HouseParty app

PART 3: USABILITY

How to prevent and smooth out frictions

Our users need very little reason to abandon the process. It's enough that they hit a single field that is not entirely clear on how to fill it, a task that looks too much like hard work, the smallest concern regarding their privacy, or a question for which they found no answer. There are users that give up at the first bump in the road or the first sign of any friction.

Good microcopy appears anywhere friction might occur, and provides an immediate solution. Sometimes it can even prevent the friction from the start.

In the previous part of the book, we spoke mainly about the microcopy that is shown before or after a user's action. In part 3 we'll talk about the microcopy that **accompanies** their actions so as to guide them and make the task simpler and quicker. The goal is to enable users to successfully and quickly complete the task – both for them and for us.

Chapters in Part 3:

14. Microcopy and usability: basic principles

15. Questions answered and knowledge gaps bridged

16. Alleviating concerns and suspicions

17. Preventing errors and other setbacks

18. Microcopy and accessibility

19. Microcopy for complex systems

CHAPTER 14

MICROCOPY AND USABILITY: BASIC PRINCIPLES

IN THIS CHAPTER

Be succinct

4 ways of introducing microcopy in forms

How to know where microcopy is needed

The fewer words the better, but...

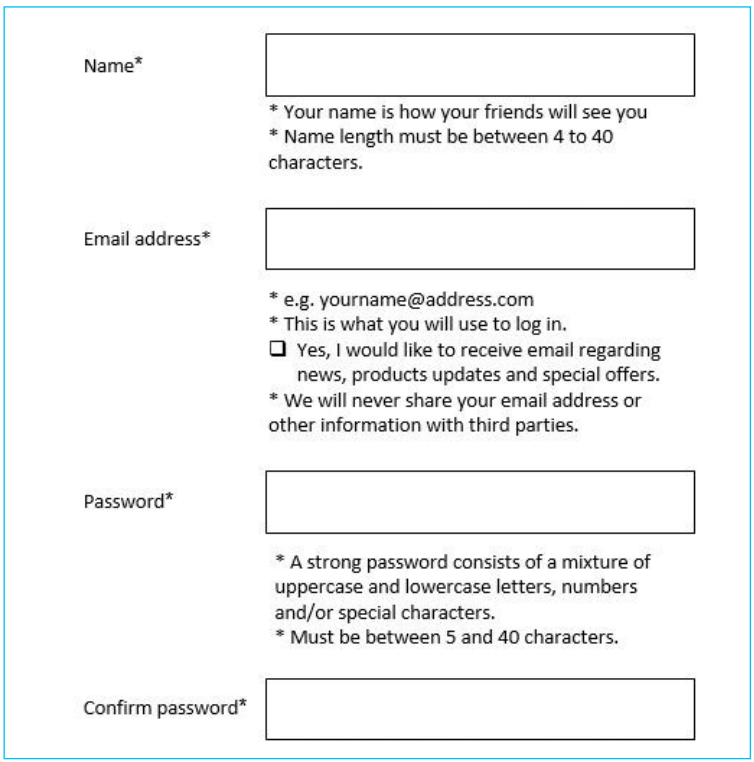
With messages and calls to action, discussed in previous chapters, the purpose of the microcopy was mainly to create or enrich the emotional experience and engagement of the users. Now, once you have got them to act, and they have started the process on the website, app or complex system (such as signing up, ordering something or starting a new project), the purpose of microcopy changes. **Now it needs to increase usability and help users avoid friction, so that they finish the process quickly and easily.**

Therefore, the focus moves from the emotional experience you created for your users, to enhancing clarity and practicality. Here good service is not measured by how pleasant it is (and it must, of course, stay pleasant), but by how much you helped your users complete the task with minimum effort (or thinking, as Steve Krug put it) on their part.

It doesn't mean that you go back to writing like a lawyer in an aloof and condescending manner, most certainly not. It does mean that you write microcopy only when it's needed and in as few words as possible. It also means that as long as your users are trying to complete the task, and as long as you want them to progress from control to control until they hit the *Submit* button, don't be too clever or complicate things.

Say only what is required, precisely, concisely and using simple language.

In the following real-life example, it looks like the writers went out of their way to provide a good service, but took the wrong turn and made the most simple and standard form into something complicated, even daunting.



Most of the explanations are totally unnecessary, and those that are required should be much shorter. It's true that you need to write in a personable way, but in such practical forms, it's important to provide the information in the most intelligible and clear way, avoiding long sentences.

For example, instead of: Must be between 5 and 40 characters

Write simply: 5–40 characters

So before stacking your interface with words, ask yourself:

1. Are they really necessary?
2. How can you phrase it in as few words as possible?

Check your UX

If you find yourself explaining a lot of things using many words, or can't find the right words, you might have a UX problem. A good interface should have its UX designed so that it motivates and is self-explanatory. The microcopy is only supposed to support the process and clear up any remaining issues. If you feel that the UI is overloaded with words, I highly recommend that you ask the UX team to find a creative solution.

On the other hand, don't hesitate to give a helping hand where needed

Being succinct is essential, but the question isn't **how much** microcopy to add to a form, but: **do users need help?** If the answer is yes – go ahead and add written guidance.

In a great talk by Sara Walsh she shows how they **doubled** the number of words in a form on **Capital One**'s website, giving up white spaces and adding assistive copy around the fields, which resulted in **tripling** the form completion rate from 26% to 92% (watch "Don't forget your online forms" on YouTube).

If you identify a place on your form where users might go astray, make a mistake or feel unsecure – don't hesitate to write down the answer to the question nagging them, or the reassuring words they need at this point. **Never skip on giving important explanations, in order not to overburden the users.** On the contrary, **they'll be happy to get your support at those friction points** and be able to easily find what they are looking for, without contacting support or giving up on doing what they came for.

As we saw earlier, the instructions should of course be as short and concise as possible, the kind that offers maximum information with the fewest words. You can also keep the instructions hidden until the exact moment they are needed, or present them in various ways according to context.

4 ways of introducing microcopy in forms

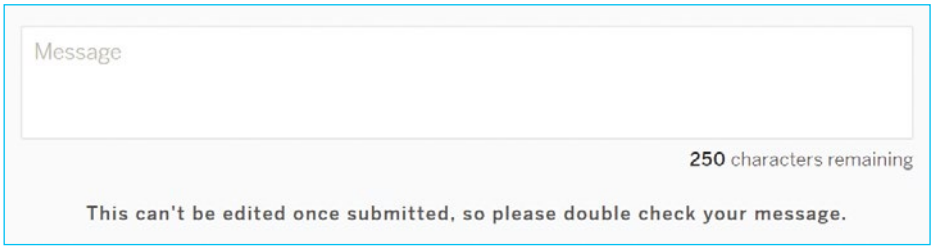
1. Static

The assistive microcopy is permanently shown on screen, without appearing, moving or vanishing. It's just always present, accessible and out there all along, in front or beside the control.

Main advantage: users can't miss it.
Main disadvantage: might overload the form's visibility.

Best for: When the instruction is critical for the users to understand how to take action, and you would like to make sure they don't miss it.

Munchery uses static microcopy to notify users about an irreversible action:



www.munchery.com

Notice that these instructions should be placed **in front** of the field to meet microcopy accessibility requirements (see chapter 18).

2. Shows up on demand

Microcopy that appears (usually as a tooltip) when the user clicks an icon (?,!,i) or hover on top of it or click a link.

Main advantage: always easily accessible for everyone, but doesn't burden those who are already familiar with the form.
Main disadvantage: users might not click on it, and miss important

information. Therefore, I recommend that important explanations are displayed next to the control and not hidden in a tooltip (unless it automatically appears, as we shall soon see).

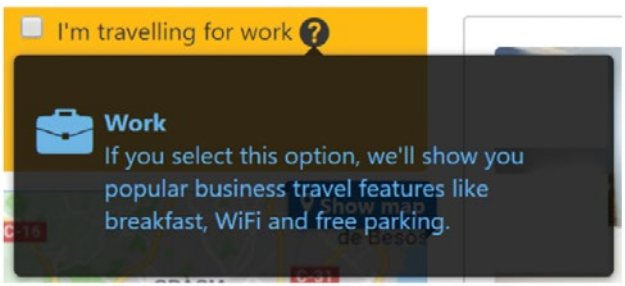
Best for:

a. When there's a lot of information or instructions to present that might create a visual overload.

b. Giving the user background information about the action that might direct them or show the value of taking the action.

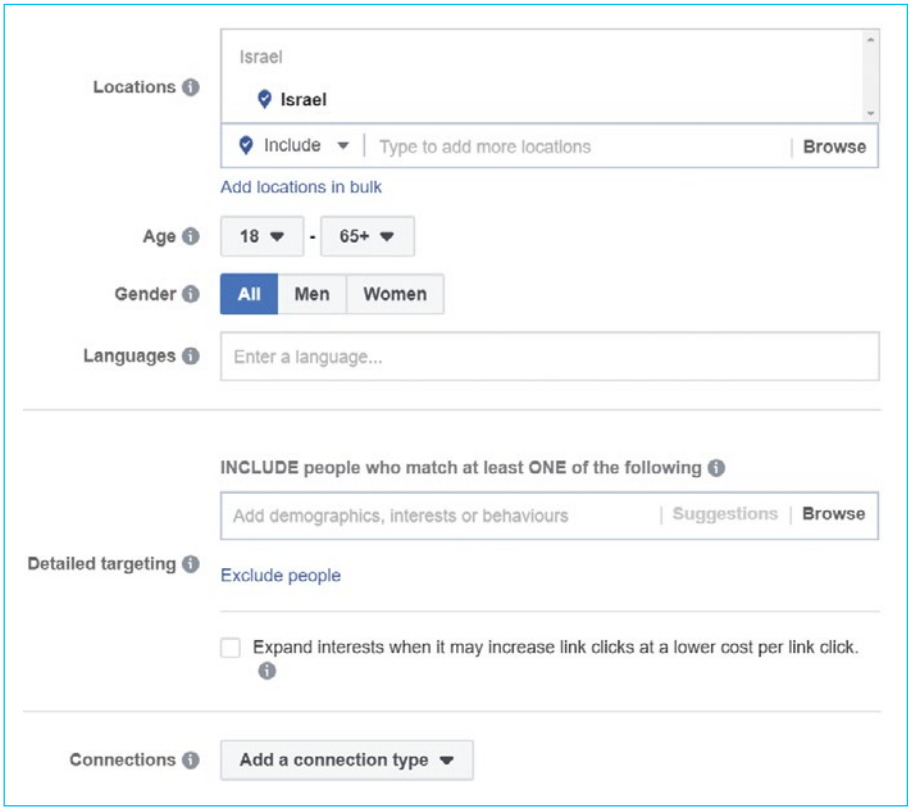
c. Frequently taken actions, so that on the second or third time users can complete it without referring to the information icon. Thus, new users get the highly accessible information they need, while veterans can move swiftly along without stopping, but can still refer to it should the need re-arise.

This tooltip appears when hovering over the '?' icon in **Booking.com**, a website that is very rich with information and instructions. The tooltip's aim is to explain why they ask for such private information (see also Chapter 16).



www.booking.com

This is **Facebook**'s UI for creating ads. They placed an 'i' icon next to each control, which is a lot, but the icons don't get in the way. On the contrary, they deliver accurate, accessible and helpful guidance for every term, helping users make the right decisions.



www.facebook.com

We'll see many more examples of explanatory and assistive tooltips in the following chapters.

3. Appears automatically

The microcopy automatically appears exactly when the users need it (i.e. when the cursor is in the field, and the field is in focus), and stays visible as long as they need it. Once users move on in the form – it disappears, and a new guidance will replace it according to where the focus is.

Main advantages: always accessible when needed, doesn't burden the form, almost no chance of instructions being overlooked.
Main disadvantage: will appear again and again, even for returning users who don't need it anymore.

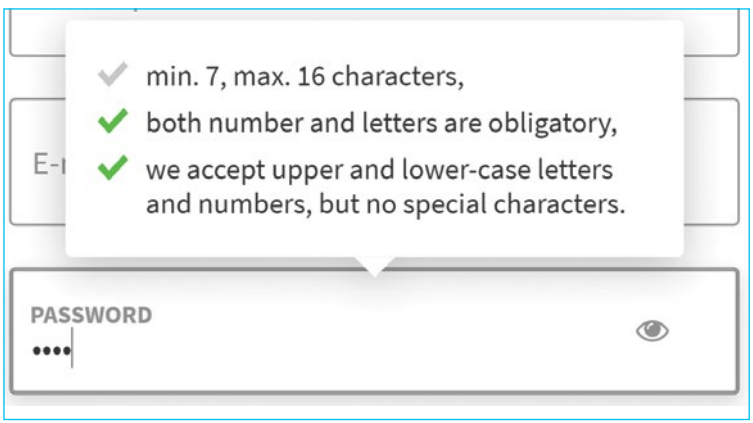
Best for:
a. When there is a lot of information or instructions that might create a visual overload and thus should better be hidden.

b. One-time actions, like setting up an online store, creating an account, starting a crowdfunding campaign, or booking a guided tour to Papua New Guinea.

c. When you want to give users the feeling they are closely accompanied throughout the process, for instance when making financial actions, enrolling in an academic institution or making an expensive purchase.

d. Important and infrequent actions, like buying airline tickets.

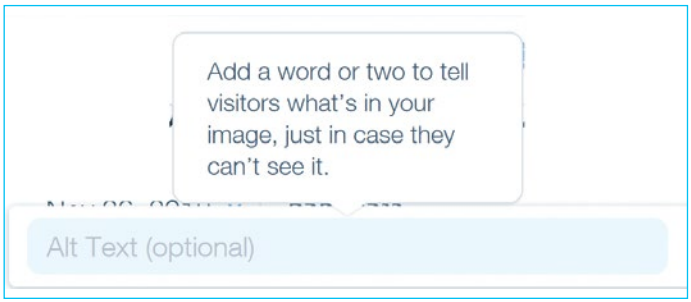
This tooltip, from **Wizzair**'s website, appears automatically when the password field is in focus, and stays with you until a valid password is created:



www.wizzair.com

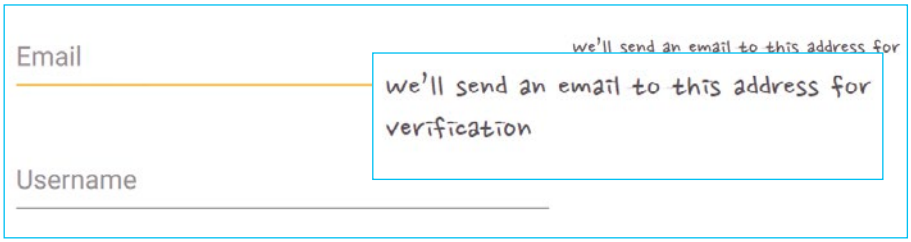
They could have written it much shorter though:
* 7–16 characters
* Must contain numbers and letters
* No special characters

This excellent tooltip appears automatically when placing the cursor in the Alt field on **Wix**'s blog platform, to explain what Alt is for and encourage adding one:

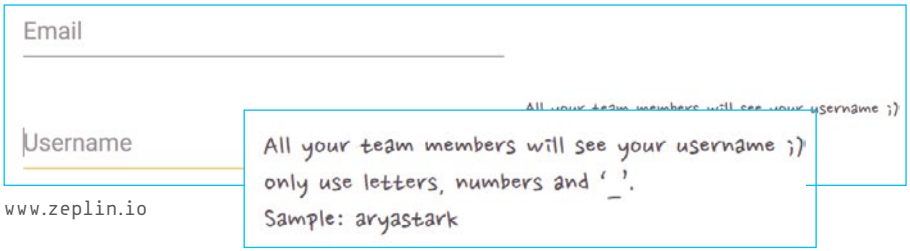


www.wix.com

By the way, it doesn't have to be a tooltip. These screenshots are from **Zeplin**'s sign up. The copy on the right automatically appears when the email field is in focus:



And when you move on to the username field:



www.zeplin.io

4. Placeholder

As we saw in Chapter 10, placeholders are usually written in a lighter shade in the field, and disappear when the field comes into focus.

Main advantage: it will not be missed.
Main disadvantage: it disappears and the user cannot see the information on demand.

Best for:

a. Short instructions.

b. When there's no risk the users might want to see the information again once the placeholder disappears.

c. Giving the users a thread or a short leading phrase to start with.

d. Giving the users a short example on how to correctly fill in the field.

See many examples and more ways to use placeholders on Chapter 10.

Of course, don't use all 4 ways in one form; consistency is, as you know, a virtue. Use each method appropriately to meet your users' needs, to make simple relaxing forms that are easy to use.

TIP

21

(?) or (!) or (i) or maybe a link?

When should you use an exclamation mark or a question mark icon? Maybe it's better to create a short link? It's not clear cut, but the answer lies within the minds of your users.

If you think (or discovered in usability tests) that they'll ask a relatively common question – such as **what do you mean, what does that do, why do you want this piece of information** – put a question mark icon, that will resonate their question and provide a hint that it is answered here.

If a specific question might arise – such as **how was that amount calculated,** or **where do I find the data you are asking me to provide** – it is certainly possible to provide a text link next to the relevant field, in the way your users would phrase it. For example, "*How did we calculate that*" or "*Where should I check*". The question must be short and simple (there are many examples in the following chapters).

You can put the exclamation mark or i icon when you want to provide information that doesn't necessarily answer a user's question, but rather adds background or other important details.

But, as I said, it's not clear cut. If you are debating which is more appropriate, it's probably borderline and whichever you choose won't affect things much. Most important is that the microcopy is efficient, simple and really smooths out friction.

How to know where microcopy is needed

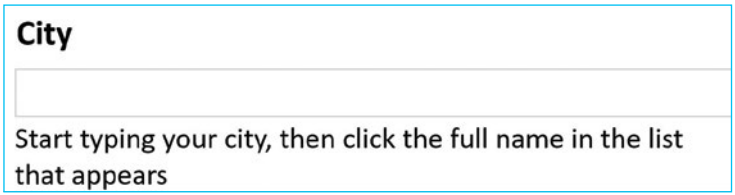
In those places where friction may occur between users and the interface, that's where you need microcopy. Friction could be caused by a delay, misunderstanding, concern or error. The question is of course how to know where potential friction might occur and to solve or prevent it in advance.

In the book **Web Form Design** by Luke Wroblewski (Rosenfeld Media, 2008), he provides a variety of ways to find weak spots in forms. Following are the three most relevant to microcopy.

Usability tests

Watch the recordings (paying attention to the words users use) and write down where users were delayed, hesitated or became stuck, and what was it that they didn't understand in each place. Sometimes, all it takes to solve a delay is a few words of explanation.

For example, if you have a control that offers auto-complete and the user has to select one of the values from the list, but you see in the tests that users prefer to finish typing the full name and not to select from the list, it's a good idea to add a short instruction under the field and make it clearer.



Of course it's preferable to allow users to type in the full name if that's what they want, but when there's no other choice, microcopy can help.

Customer support reps

Ask your online customer support team what are the most frequent questions customers have, and why they feel they need to turn to support. You'll discover where in the process customers have problems and need help, and what exactly is difficult for them. These weak spots either need a UX repair or the help of microcopy.

For example, if a lot of users turn to support during the payment process, and request to complete the purchase on the phone, it might be that they are afraid that the online payment is not secured enough. In such cases, it's worthwhile emphasizing in a variety of places and ways that the payment is secured, and maybe even point out what kind of payment security you offer and how good it really is (see examples in Chapter 16).

Monitoring and analysis tools

Web analytics tools, such as heatmaps, can show you where users abandoned the task, what the last thing was that they tried to do, where many error messages were displayed, and other important data that will highlight those squeaky hinges that you can grease with microcopy.

For example, if you discover that users skip the date of birth field, or get errors because they didn't fill it, it's probable that they don't understand why you want this private information. It's recommended that you mark that field as mandatory and add a short explanation offering a convincing reason (i.e. required by law, see examples in Chapter 16).

In the next few chapters I will list a few weak points you can find in almost any form. For each item I'll write about microcopy that can fortify this weak point, enhance usability and increase completion and conversion rates.

CHAPTER 15

QUESTIONS ANSWERED AND KNOWLEDGE GAPS BRIDGED

IN THIS CHAPTER

4 common questions that microcopy needs to answer

Remove the curse of knowledge

Practically all digital processes arouse some sense of uncertainty within users. Someone else designed this process for them, and they are completing it in the belief that it will benefit them, or at least won't cause any trouble. We, who designed the process, see the full picture, but users only see a few steps ahead. So when they don't understand a term and can't find an explanation for it, or they don't understand how to use the interface, this fundamental uncertainty increases, and they lose their confidence in the process, and in us.

Microcopy can offer users an immediate and accessible answer to any question they might have, and thus create a feeling of certainty. The copy doesn't only answer the question, it also shows users that we take them into consideration and that their question is legitimate, and thus they can trust us.

The difficulty for microcopy writers stems from what is known as the **Curse of Knowledge**. This is the inability of a person who already has some knowledge to see things from the point of view of someone who lacks that knowledge. When you write microcopy you know everything about the digital product that you are writing for, the subject matter, the specific task, and also about interfaces in general. Things that seem to you well known and obvious, might be new and incomprehensible to your users. To identify those places where users might ask **What's that?** or **What does that do?** or **How do I use that?** you need to take a fresh look at the process, and it is also well advised to use the resources discussed in the previous chapter (usability tests, customer support reps and analytical tools).

This chapter shows some common questions that users might ask. Even before the usability tests, try to look at the process through the eyes of completely new users, identify those places where questions may arise, and write microcopy that answers them.

Question #1: What's that?

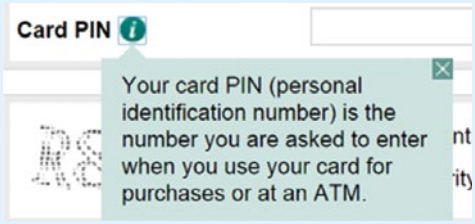
a. Go over the process and look for **internal technical** terms and for terms that might be **unusual** or **new** in the eyes of the users, making them ask **What's that?**

b. For every such term, check **if you can replace it with simpler words**.

c. If you can't simplify the term, **add microcopy with an explanation**.

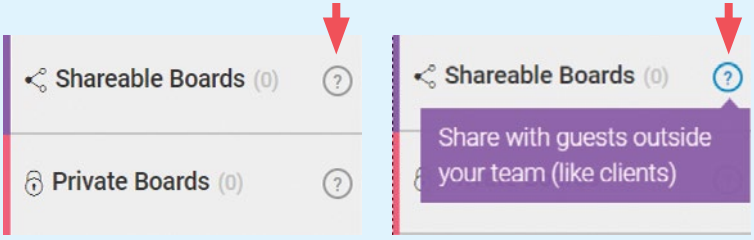
Examples

Commonwealth Bank's customers are not used to being asked to provide their credit card pin code. This might lead to them not understanding the banking term "Card PIN". For that reason, a clear explanation is provided right by the field. It would have been better to put a question mark icon, because the explanation answers the question **What's that**? (**see tip 21**).



www.commbank.com.au

When you name different features in your product, you actually create a new in-product convention that users might not understand. They might also fail to see what value it can give them. If you want users to use it – explain what it means, and what is it good for. **Monday**, the team-project management tool, does it with colorful tooltips.

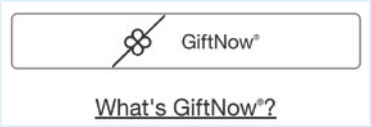


www.monday.com

Golan Telecom is an Israeli mobile operator. When a user orders a new line, they can order "Numbers Sequence". But **what's numbers sequence?** Hovering above the question mark icon displays the explanation – to buy a few sim cards that have sequential numbers. It's worth mentioning that if Golan Telecom really wants to sell sequential numbers, and I guess they do, they should phrase the explanation as a call to action. For example, "Order more than one sim card and get sequential numbers".



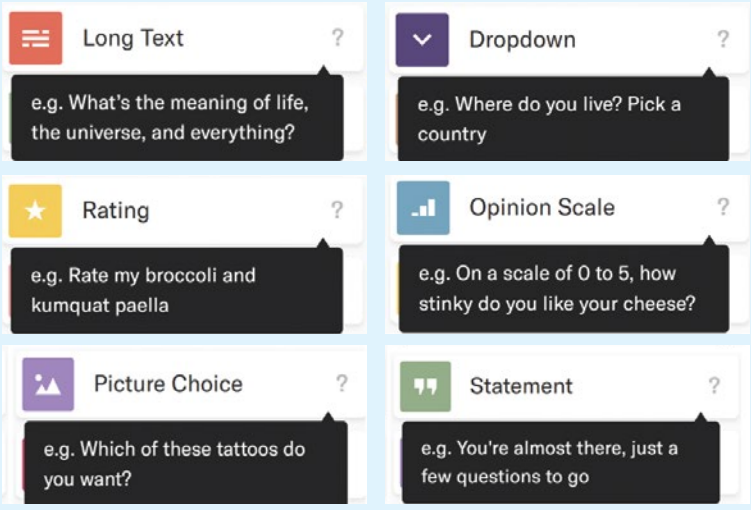
www.golantelecom.co.il



Target shows a permanent link that leads to an explanation about the GiftNow feature.

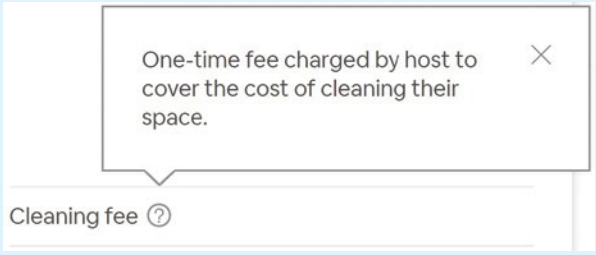
www.target.com

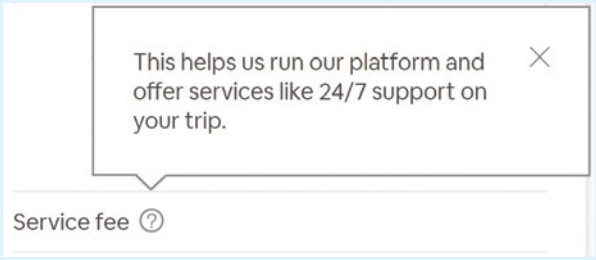
Like with placeholders, sometimes an example is the best way to explain a complex idea. On **Typeform**, the questionnaire creator, they explain every kind of question available using an example in a tooltip. It clarifies the terms and makes it very easy for users to choose the one they need.



www.typeform.com

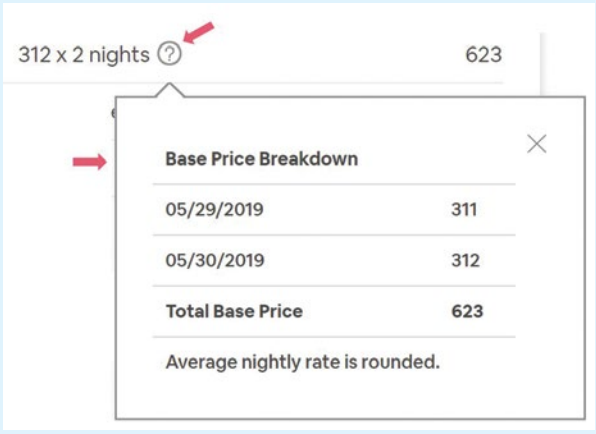
Airbnb answer common questions in advance and explain the different elements of the payment in a simple, relatable way. I find the term *one-time*, together with the specification of what they're going to do with the fees, and most importantly – what's in it for the users – reassuring and alleviates objections.





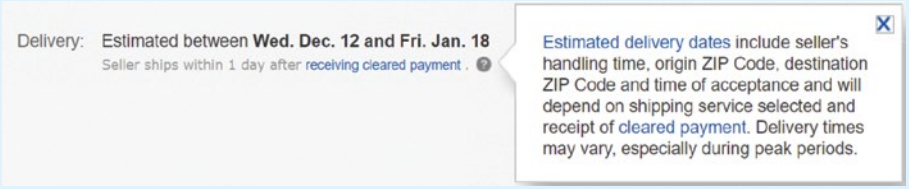
www.airbnb.com

When you show users a number that's an outcome of a calculation you made, consider sharing how you arrived at this outcome. **Airbnb** offers a tooltip with a breakdown of the base price. Transparency is one of the most reassuring practices.



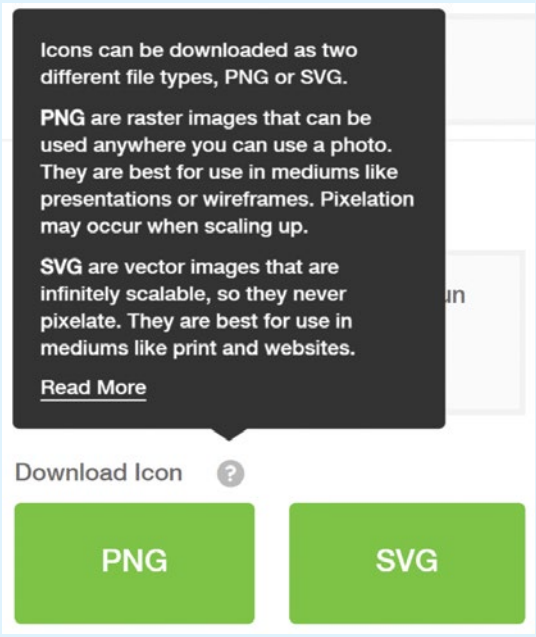
www.airbnb.com

eBay tells users how they estimate the delivery date:



www.ebay.com

A clarification of professional terms can help users choose between various options. In the following example, the icon shop **The Noun Project** gives a super-useful explanation for each file format, detailing what they're good for and what are their pros and cons, thus helping users decide which format to download.



www.thenounproject.com

Anyway, the question mark icon doesn't imply that there's useful information inside, and instead I would write a permanent link such as **What's the difference**, or **How do I choose**, or **What are PNG and SVG**. I also think that the first two lines in the tooltip are redundant, since the UI is self-explanatory.

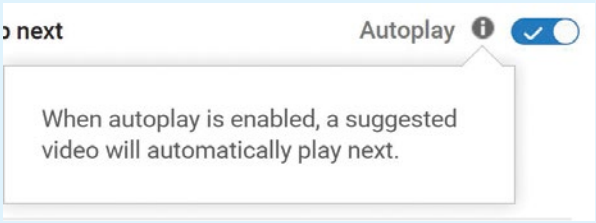
Question #2: What does that do?

When you have an on/off switch (toggle) or check box, and if the action is not entirely obvious, write near the control what happens, or doesn't happen, when you turn it on or off. If necessary, explain to the users the advantages and disadvantages of turning it on or off.

Also, if you have a special interest in making users use the feature, phrase your explanation as a call to action in an attractive, interesting way rather than using a neutral-technical tone.

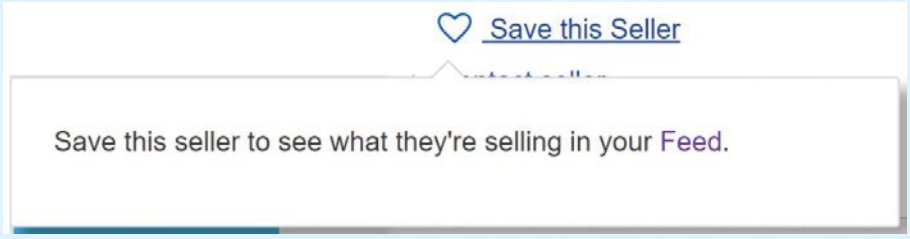
Examples

When **YouTube** launched the Autoplay feature, they used to have an i icon right next to the switch, that when hovered over answered the question **What does that do?** Because YouTube has a clear interest in us using this feature to increase the number of views, it would have been better if they worded the explanation more actively. For example, *Turn this on to automatically play the next suggested video.*



www.youtube.com (a previous version)

What will happen if you click *Save this seller*? How will that help you? **eBay** presents the answers in a tooltip. But will users know they can hover to find more info, or would it be better to add a tiny help icon?



www.ebay.com

Toshl, the budgeting app, has monsters with great humor, but not all users like their finances served with a dose of laughter (see Chapter 1 about how to use humor in your microcopy). For them, there's a switch that turns the monsters into the most politically correct creatures.



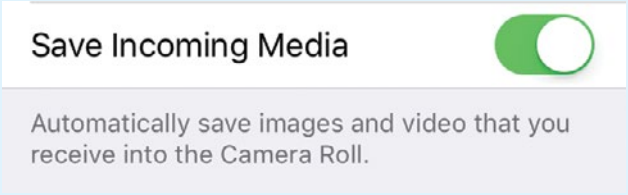
Toshle app

Notica, an app that processes and stores photos as visual notes, explains to the user all the consequences of turning on or off the high resolution feature. The explanation is a bit long, but the information is important for users that invest time and effort in organizing their photos, and enables them to make a decision most suitable to their individual needs.



Notica app

In **WhatsApp**, even though the feature has a simple and clear label, it still needs the sentence underneath. This explains precisely what is included in "incoming media" and where and when is it saved.



WhatsApp app

Question #3: Where can I find this?

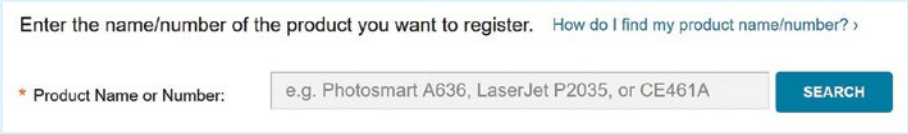
On forms where users are requested to supply specific information (such as finding what class driving license you have, your account number on your utility bill, and so on), it is a good idea to explain in a clear manner next to the field how to find this information, and even accompany it with a picture highlighting the exact location.

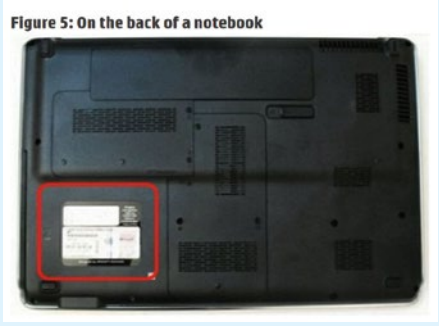
If the value includes dashes or slashes, or a combination of letters and numbers, mention if they need to be typed in or not, in what order and more (or even arrange the input field as a number of boxes that skips the symbols).

Example

When registering an **HP** laptop, you need to provide the product name or number. The form provides a link saying: "*How do I find my product name/number?*" It opens in a new window, there they have a video and many other ways the user can find the number.

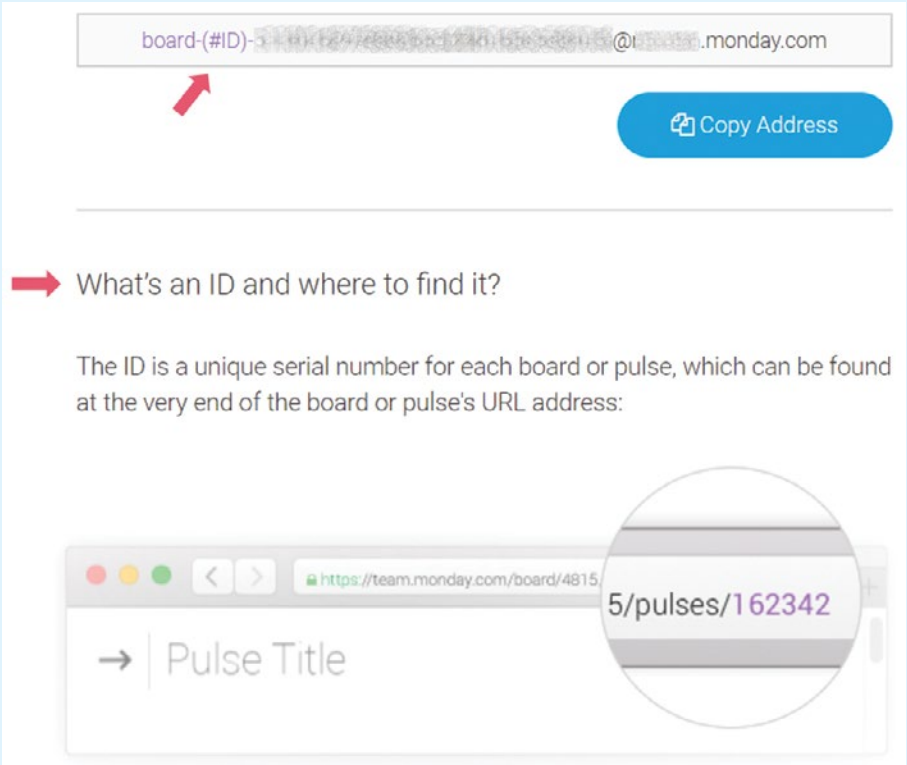
Note that they could use fewer words: the instruction "Enter the..." isn't necessary because the field label and the placeholder are doing a great job, and the link could be shorter too: "Where do I find it?"





register.hp.com

Similarly, when **Monday** asks for the board ID, they provide an explanation both for what's an ID and where to find it.



www.monday.com

TIP

22

You can select more than one option

As you know, radio buttons are used when only one option is possible, whereas check boxes are used for multiple selection. But the general public doesn't necessarily know that. It might be that most users don't even notice that there are two type of selection controls. Therefore, when it's possible to select more than one option, it's worthwhile pointing that out explicitly.

Question #4: How do I use that?

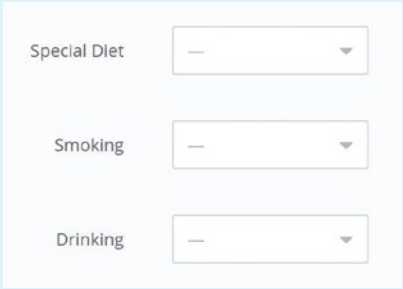
In theory, the user experience should be self-explanatory, and text used only as a last resort. But will users really understand all by themselves what they need to do? This is where the Curse of Knowledge is at its most confusing. You understand interfaces, you understand the latest Internet fashions, you are technologically inclined, and can intuitively survive nearly all digital products that you come across. But what about your users? What can be considered a basic skill for anyone living in the 21st century, and what still needs explaining? When do you need to write **drag**, **type**, **click** and **select**, and when is it obvious?

And what is right for all other aspects of UX is absolutely correct here: **the best way to find out if you need or don't need written help is by performing usability tests.**

When an explanation is not required

Fields, buttons, drop-downs, exclamation or question mark icons, links, asterisks, radio buttons, and check boxes, all these don't need instructions. You can simply write the label next to it, for example "*Email*", and not "*enter your email address*", because users already know what to do in these fields. In most cases also next to radio buttons and check boxes you only need the label and don't need to add **select**, and you don't need to add **click** on a button.

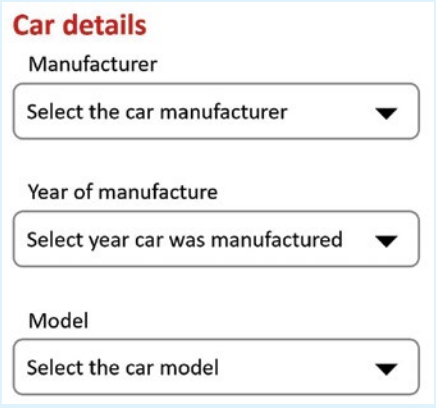
Examples



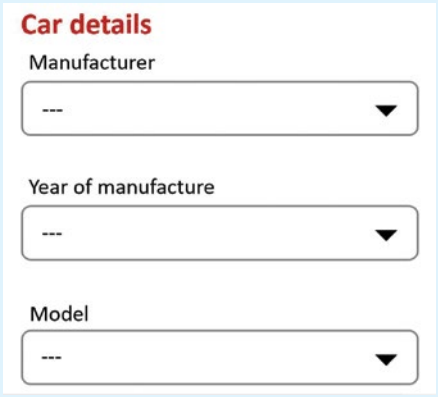
www.okcupid.com

OkCupid provides drop-downs, without telling the user what to do, simply because the drop-down is so well known, and thus the interface remains free of words and very simple.

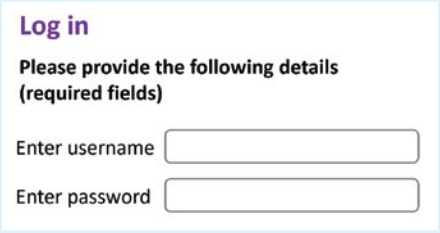
Instead of all this:



you could have only this:



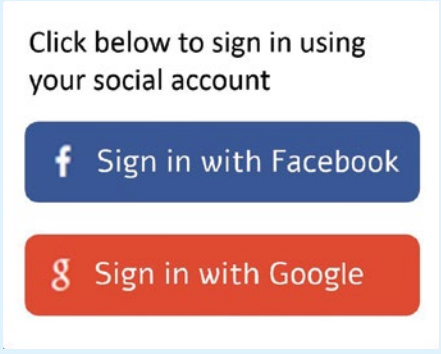
And on this form they only needed to keep four words:





(Though, as I said earlier, it's best to make the title more welcoming on a site's gateway).

And the following instruction is not required above these buttons, as they already convey all the information needed:



When an explanation is necessary

If you have developed a unique interface to meet your needs, or the interface is still considered innovative, it is worthwhile telling users how to use it. Write short, simple and precise instructions in exactly the right place.

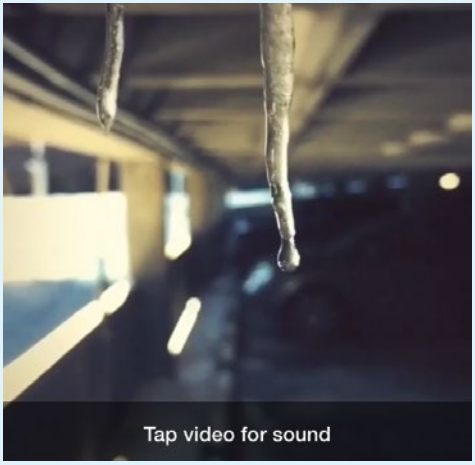
Examples

A good example of a precise instruction, appearing exactly when it is needed, is from **Instagram**:

"*Tap video for sound*"

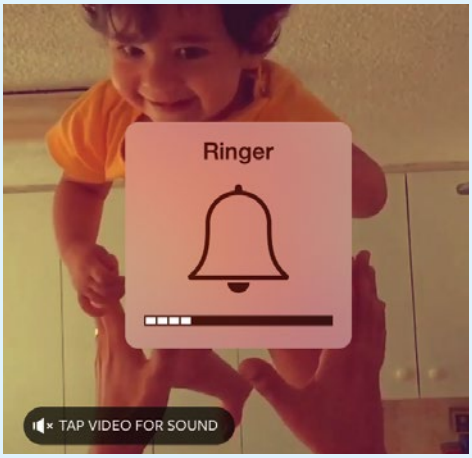
Tapping the video to start or stop the sound is (still) not an intuitive action, though it will be soon because Instagram has adopted it. But at the time of writing these lines, it is actually the opposite of what our intuition tells us, because we are used to YouTube, where clicking the video stops it.

When they first introduced the feature, Instagram wrote the instruction at the bottom of a video when it played:



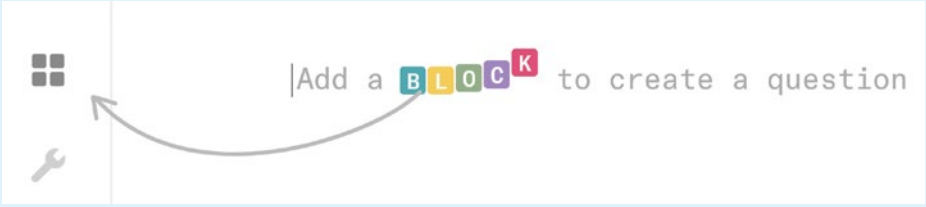
Instagram app (photo: Elazar Yifrah)

But with the passage of time, when the instruction became better known to users, it started to appear only in those instances where Instagram had grounds to believe that the users weren't acquainted with the interface. For example, if they tried to turn up the volume while the video was playing, when in fact the sound was turned off.



Instagram app (photo: Elazar Yifrah)

Typeform designed a unique UI for creating questionnaires. The connection between blocks and questions is not commonly known or obvious, so they add visual and textual help to make things clearer and help users get started.



www.typeform.com

TIP

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Save users from themselves

If incorrect use of the interface can cause a problem for the users or to the process, for example to exit a process, to open a new window, to delete everything entered so far and so on, you should provide instructions clearly and prominently, even in those places that seem obvious to you. The more repercussions an action might have, the more reason to explain it.

TIP

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Be nice – even when writing instructions

Instructions need to be simple and clear, but in a nice service-oriented way, not as an order to do something. If it fits your voice and tone, you can even inject some humor (but never at the expense of clarity).

The first time I transferred a file using **WeTransfer**, I laughed out loud.

Drag the file here and then –



www.wetransfer.com

CHAPTER 16

ALLEVIATING CONCERNS AND SUSPICIONS

IN THIS CHAPTER

7 common concerns and suspicions that you need to address

If you ignore it, it won't go away

Users have many good reasons not to trust us. Everyone is trying to sell them something, be it directly or indirectly, and what's free now will require payment later. Each time users provide their email address, they are swamped by spam, and sometimes they hear about yet another giant company whose database has been hacked, and credit cards or other private details were exposed. When they download a small widget, three other things they didn't request are also downloaded, and in general, to survive the Internet they need to be constantly on their guard and with their eyes open.

There is no reason why users, not yet acquainted with your company, should place their trust in you. This trust needs to be earned. First and foremost, you need to earn it by genuinely and practically and **really** being on the side of the users in all your service interfaces. But you also need to show them that you are worthy of their trust. Instead of ignoring their legitimate concerns and suspicions, you need to explicitly tell your users that you are aware of their concerns and respect them, and that they are in good hands.

In this chapter I'll demonstrate a few weak points that could arouse the concern or suspicion of users, and how to overcome them.

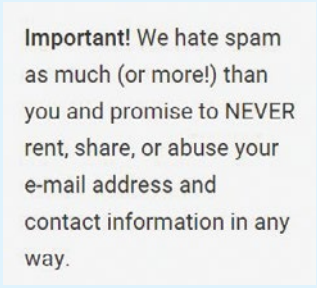
Concern #1: Providing an email address

In the chapter on signing up for a newsletter, we said that users have two main concerns when they provide their email address:

a. That you'll drown them in emails. That's why you need to reassure them about the low frequency of the newsletter. It's also worthwhile to remind them they can unsubscribe with a single click any time they want to.
b. That you'll pass their email address to others who'll drown them in spam. That's why you need to promise them that their email address stays with you and that the privacy of users is important to you.

Examples

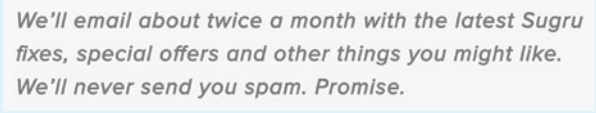
See also the short and simple phrases on the sign up forms in chapter 5.



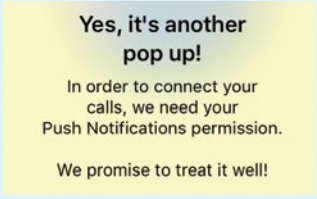
www.metromsp.com

metroMSP, an IT support company in North Jersey, tells users that it hates spam even more than they do.

On the checkout form of **Sugru**, the magical glue, there's a checkbox offering users to subscribe to their newsletter. Right next to it, they specify the frequency and promise not to spam.



www.sugru.com



Rounds app

Push notifications may be seen as spam, and when asking for permission it is advised to address this concern. **Rounds** app asks for your permission and promises to treat it well.

Concern #2: Providing special personal information

Users are vigilant nowadays about privacy and are reluctant to provide any information that is not absolutely necessary, mainly date of birth, telephone number, gender, home address, and so on. If asked to provide such information, they become suspicious and ask **what do you need it for?**

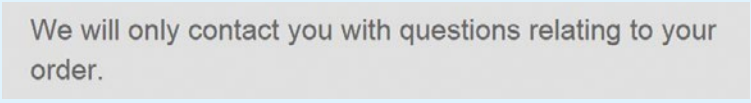
We need to supply a good answer:

a. If it's a required field, explain why you need these details and guarantee their privacy.

b. If it's an optional field, explain why it is **worthwhile** that users give you these details, and how it will benefit **them**.

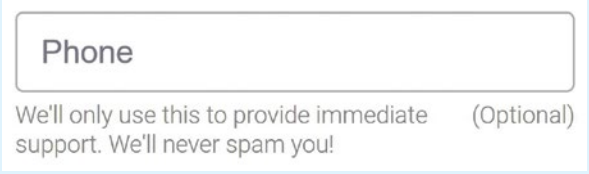
Examples

During payment, when the cursor is placed in the telephone number field, **Tesco** displays a tooltip explaining why they ask for the number. They also calm users and promise that it is the only use they will make of this information. Simple and perfect.



www.tesco.com

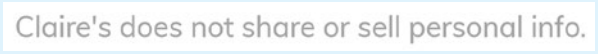
Monday specifies that giving the phone number is optional, but tells users how it'll help them in the future (immediate support when needed), and reassures them that it will never be used for spamming.



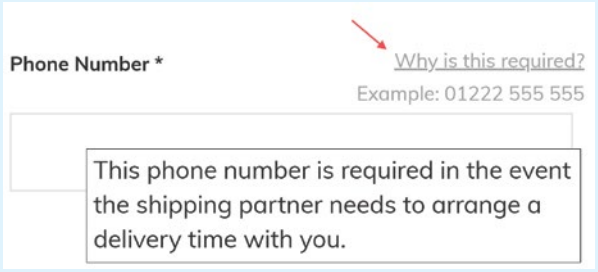
www.monday.com

At **Claire's**, the fashion accessory shop, they're very aware of privacy concerns, and make sure to be as transparent as possible about why they collect personal details and what they're going to do with it.

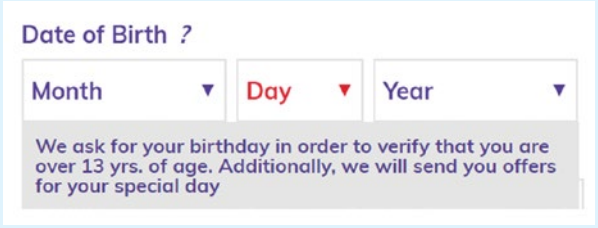
When signing up they reassure:



When asking for a phone number they answer the common question – Why is this required? They could have phrased it in a much shorter, nicer way though, such as: *Only for necessary delivery purposes, nothing else.*

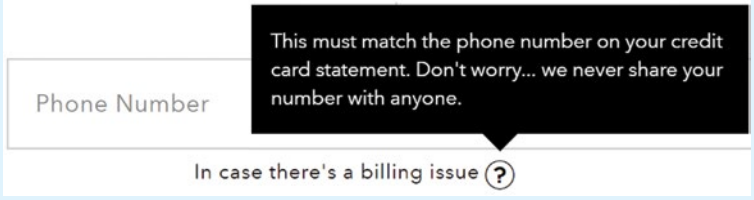


When asking for date of birth, **Claire's** uses both tactics: they explain why they must ask for this information, and tell users how they'll benefit from giving it.



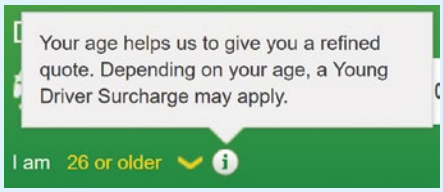
www.claires.com

American Eagle explains what they need the phone number for, and promises not to share it. They also prevent possible error by stating up front that the number should match the one affiliated with the credit card.

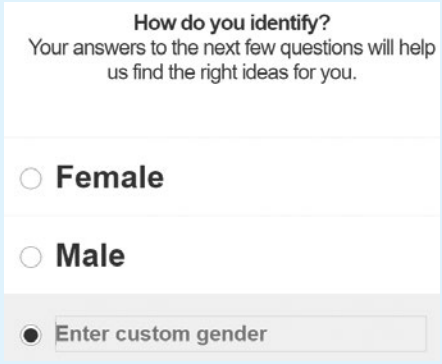


www.ae.com

It's pretty obvious why a car rental company will ask for users' age, but **Europcar** gives a full explanation in case the user is new to the matter.



www.europcar.com



Pinterest explains why they ask users about their gender. It also suggests a costumized gender field.

www.pinterest.com

Vimeo doesn't ask for users' gender but rather pronouns, and immediately explain why they're asking.



www.vimeo.com

These are from the fashion shop **boohoo**. Both fields are optional, so they tell users what's in it for them.



www.boohoo.com

Concern #3: Signing up using a social media account

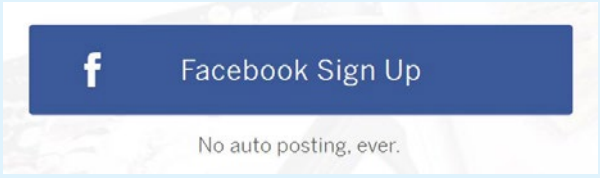
As mentioned in the chapter on sign up processes (chapter 4), registration using social media is widespread but still arouses concern. So it's important to promise users that:

a. You won't post anything in their name.
b. You won't share their information with other parties.

Examples

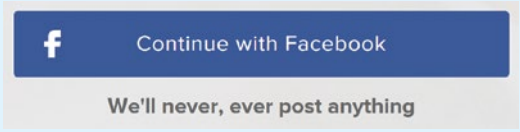
See a few more examples in chapter 4. Note that in most cases there is only a reference to the first concern, and that might prove to be a mistake, because the second is also very important.

Munchery, the fresh meal delivery service, promises there will be no surprises.



www.munchery.com

On discreet websites this promise becomes doubly important. This is from **eHarmony**, the dating platform.



www.eharmony.com

Switch is a job seeking app using LinkedIn accounts for uploading resumes.



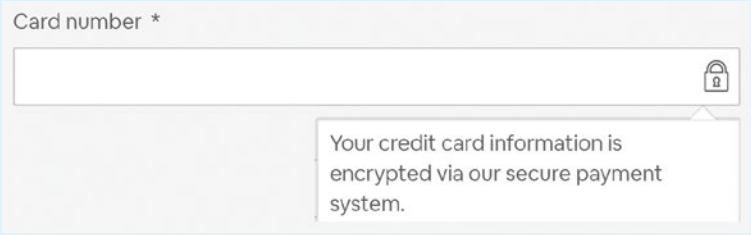
Switch app

Concern #4: Secured payment

Buying online appears to be one of the most worrying processes. The main concern of course is that credit card information is kept secure. It is worth your while to address this concern and relieve it right up front where users click to go from their cart to checkout, and of course, on the payment form itself.

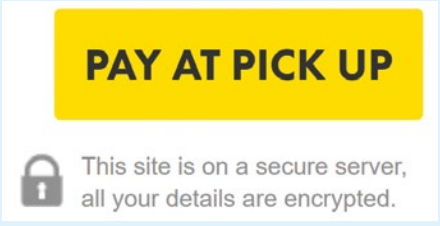
Examples

Airbnb places the reassuring tooltip about security exactly where it's needed: right in the credit card number field.



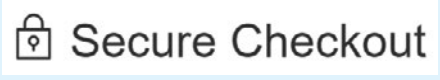
www.airbnb.com

Europcar assumes that customers may prefer to pay when picking up the car for security reasons, so they explicitly say:



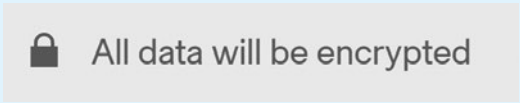
www.europcar.com

On the top of the payment form, **Macy's** says:



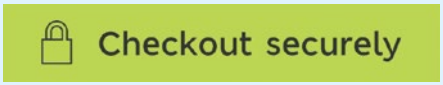
www.macys.com

H&M writes in their checkout form:



www.hm.com

This is **Marks and Spencer's** button in the cart. Exactly at the point when users are debating whether to proceed and purchase the item, and if they should click the button or not, they receive a response to their main concern: Yes, the checkout is secured!



www.marksandspencer.com

And this is the fashion shop **Roxy**'s button in the shopping cart:



www.roxy.com

TIP

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Who pays for the shipment?

Another common concern when buying online is related to shipment. Who pays for it? How much does it cost? If the product doesn't meet expectations, how is it returned and who pays for the return shipment? Answer all these questions clearly right at the beginning of the process, and save your users doubts and hesitations.

Concern #5: Free trial

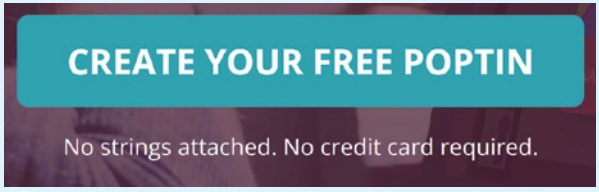
The main concern for users when signing up for a free trial period is that they'll be charged as soon as that period is over. The solution, as usual, is simply to clearly refute this concern.

At the beginning of the sign up process, promise users that there is no need for their credit card details (meaning they can't be charged).

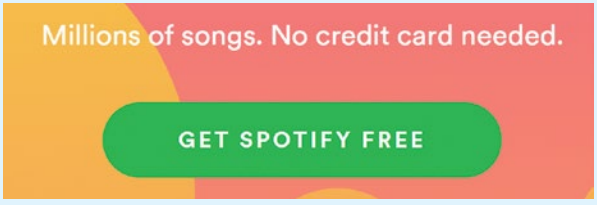
If you do need credit card details, promise that on no account will you charge it without the explicit permission of the user.

Examples

Poptin is a platform for creating popups. **Spotify** is... well, you know Spotify.

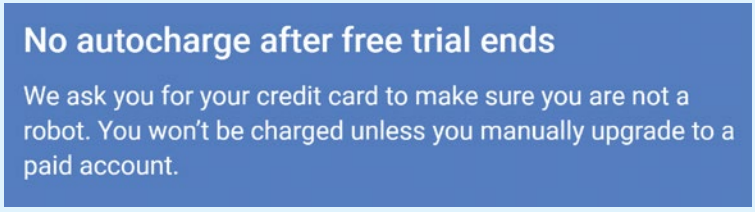


www.poptin.com



www.spotify.com

Google Cloud Platform does ask for credit card details but promises:



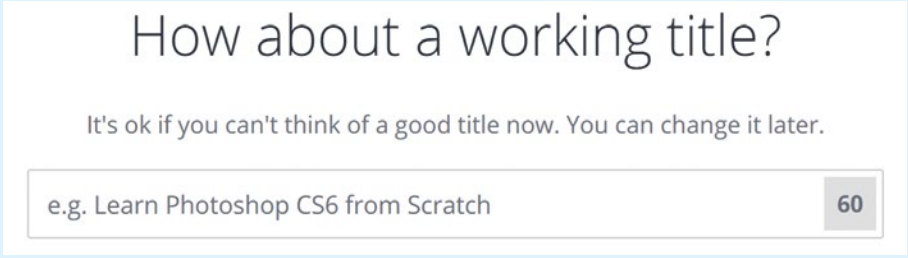
cloud.google.com

Concern #6: Settings and configuration

When users start a process, they usually expect to finish it quickly. If the process requires some serious thinking from users, they might decide to leave it to a later date, when they have more time. To avoid that, explain clearly to them that these settings can be changed later, whenever they want to. In this way, the users won't feel like they are making a lifelong commitment, and will be able to quickly define settings without worrying about future consequences.

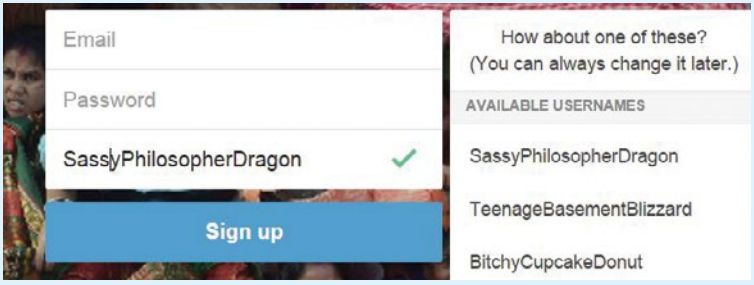
Examples

When creating a new online course, the dilemma about which title to use can continue until the last minute, and **Udemy** are aware of that. But they don't want users to delay the process, so they let them enter a temporary title, and clearly state it to concerned users.



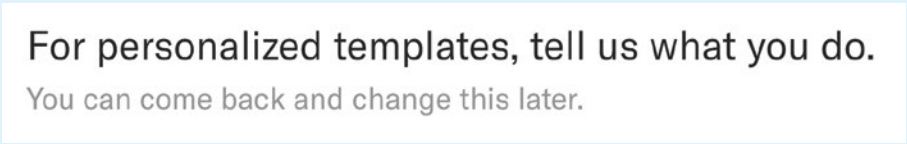
www.udemy.com

tumblr really doesn't want users to delay sign up just because it's hard for them to select a username. Their solution is to offer loads of funny names, and promise that they can easily change it whenever they want.



www.tumblr.com

Typeform, the questioner creator, offers personalized templates, but they know the need will probably change over time, so they say:



www.typeform.com

TIP

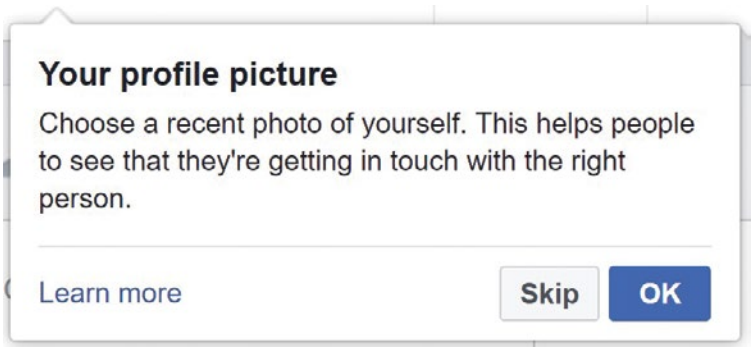
26

It's worth the effort!

If your process includes steps that demand some extra effort on the part of your users, and regardless of whether it is optional or mandatory (such as uploading a photo, installing an add-on, or writing a few words about themselves), their inclination will be to skip that step so that they can move on.

So, write them a few words about why it's good for them to do it, and how they'll benefit. Remind them why they came to your site in the first place, and how this will get them closer to their goal.

For example, when **Facebook** motivates users to upload a photo to the profile they just created, it talks about friends easily connecting with you, and that's exactly why people come here.



www.facebook.com

Concern #7: Download or installation

The big concern for users about downloading and installing is that in addition to the desired product they'll get a few other very undesirable products: viruses, spywares, toolbars and the rest of the parasites. So, if your process includes downloading a product, assure the users it is free of viruses and that the installation will not include anything else.

Examples

This is how they say it on **Download.com**:



www.download.com

Before downloading the add-on for Chrome, **Rounds** says simply:



www.rounds.com

CHAPTER 17

PREVENTING ERRORS AND OTHER SETBACKS

IN THIS CHAPTER

5 setbacks that can be easily avoided with the help of microcopy

A stitch in time saves nine

In Chapter 7 we discussed how to phrase error messages so that users can quickly continue with the process and make an irritating experience slightly better. But it is even better to prevent the errors in the first place. In this chapter I'll point out some weak points where users might receive errors or otherwise be disappointed. As you, the process designers, see the full picture, and know which values the system can accept and which values will produce errors, and as only you know what's going to happen on the next page or stage of the process, you are the one responsible for letting users know what they need, and prevent them from falling into these traps.

All you have to do is go over your forms and processes, identify the weak points (that we'll look at right now), and add a few words next to the suspect places.

Stitch #1: Required fields

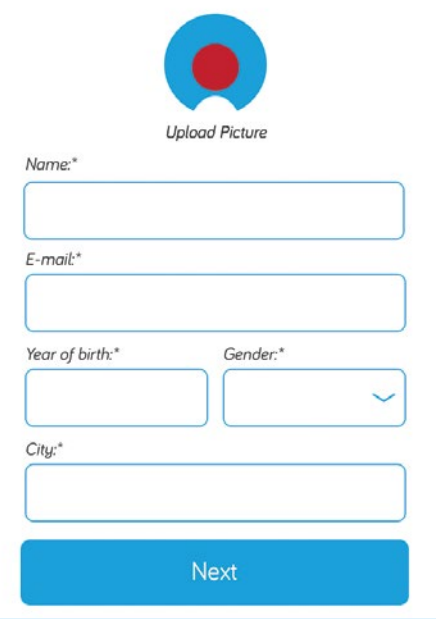
Users should never have to see the most unnecessary of error messages - "This field is required". The fact that a field is required should be clear, explicit and unequivocal, though unintimidating.

You can achieve this by using asterisks. Yes, even if all the fields are required, as seen in the screenshot below.

If you find out that your users are put off by asterisks, as some studies show, you can clearly state at the top of the form that all the fields are required, and note "optional" only next to those which are not (and then ask yourself if you really need all those you left as optional. The less information you request, the greater the chance that users will complete the form).

Whatever you do, make sure to remove all ambiguities, and save users the need to draw conclusions for themselves about your rules. Just be very clear about it.

Examples



Musketeer app

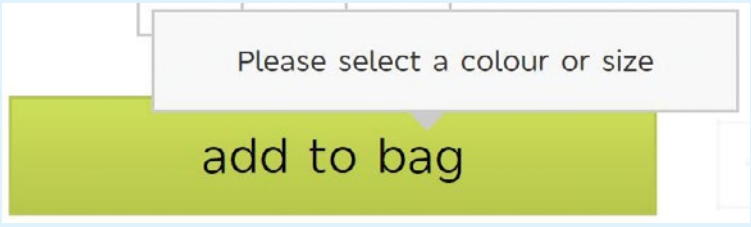
Look how simple and clear it is on the sign up form for the **Musketeer** app, that enables citizens to help each other in case of an emergency. You don't even need a sentence explaining that the asterisk indicates a mandatory field, it's perfectly obvious.

Walmart makes things super clear with a combination of asterisks and "optional".



www.walmart.com

This is from **Marks and Spencer**. It shows another way to deal with required fields: when hovering over the button (even before clicking), the instruction appears in a tooltip and says what required details are missing, thus preventing the error message.



www.marksandspencer.com

Stitch #2: Symbols or special formatting

When users are requested to type in a value that includes special symbols (such as dash, slash, a combination of letters and numbers, and so on), or there are several possible formats for this value (such as the date or phone number), they ask themselves if they should actually type the symbols, or which format is acceptable. There are of course users, and maybe even most of them, who are not even aware of the problem and don't ask themselves any questions. They just type whatever seems right to them.

The ideal should be that the system is indifferent to formats and can accept whatever the users type. If you succeeded in creating such a system, you don't need to write anything.

But if the system only accepts a value written in a certain specific way, you must point that out to the users before they start typing, to avoid the error.

Examples

The next example uses an interface solution to make life easier for the user.

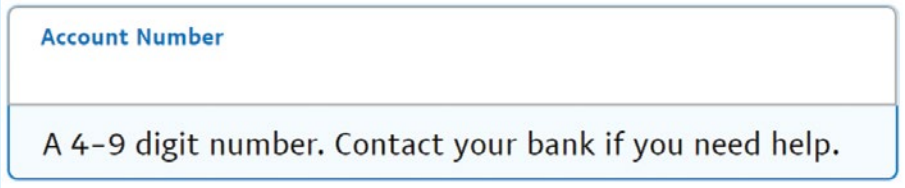
The Idle Man broke down the date into its component fields, so the user doesn't need to think about a period or slash. Then they wrote the exact format under each field: day and month in two digits, year in four.



www.theidleman.com

When linking a bank account to a **PayPal** account, formatting instructions automatically appear beneath the field when it comes into focus, to make sure users type in the correct details.





www.paypal.com

When linking a credit card, the formatting instruction appears as a placeholder.

This is the field beforehand:



And this is the field after the user clicks inside it:



www.paypal.com

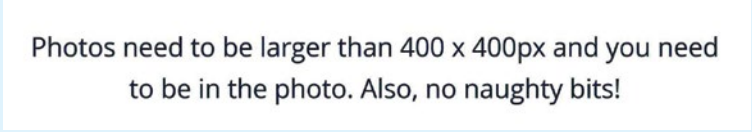
Stitch #3: Size, range or length restrictions

If there are fields that only accept limited values, for example a certain range of numbers or time, a limited number of characters, format or size limitation of a file that can be uploaded, and so on, check if there is a UX way to prevent entering unacceptable values: shading dates on a calendar, turning off the option of typing when the maximum number of allowed characters is reached, etc.

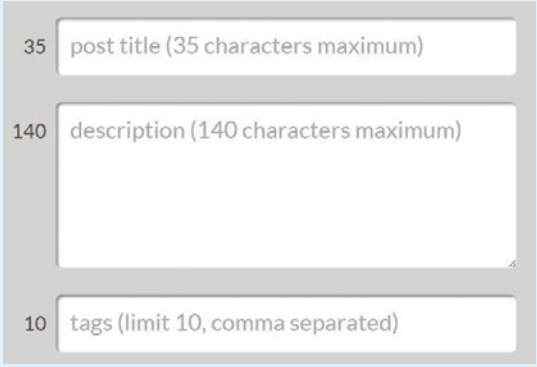
Anyway, explicitly write the limitations so that users won't encounter avoidable errors and understand why these options are unavailable. If this is a field, don't write the limitations as a placeholder within it. The placeholder will disappear once the users start typing, preventing them from rechecking it if needed (see Chapter 10).

Examples

OkCupid provides the minimum size of a file, and some other important instructions...



www.okcupid.com



www.foodgawker.com

Foodgawker, a photographed recipe site, did put the limitations as placeholders, but outside each field there's also a countdown number indicating how many characters users have left, helping them to always know where they stand.

Stitch #4: Passwords

Here too, it's best if you don't limit users (unless you have specific security requirements), so that they can use one of their regular passwords or one that's easy for them to remember. If this is the case, you obviously don't need to provide instructions. If you only have a very wide restriction, such as: the password should be between 4-60 characters - most passwords will answer this criterion anyway, so you don't need to write anything.

But if you do have restrictions on how the password must be constructed, write them next to the field (or above it, next to the label, for screen reader users), or in an exclamation mark icon next to the label, or in a tooltip displayed when the user puts the field into focus.

It's best to provide users with an indication that their password is acceptable immediately after they finish typing it in (in-line), or even better - display a tick for each restriction they met. In any case, it's recommended not to write the restrictions in the field so they don't disappear as soon as the user starts typing, and challenge their short term memory.

When writing passwords microcopy, address the following points, based on what is relevant to your situation:

- How many characters (minimum, range or exact number)
- The type of characters the password must include (such as at least one capital letter)
- Characters that the password cannot contain (such as symbols like: *? - ").* You can also write it in a positive way: "*letters and numbers only*".
- Case sensitivity

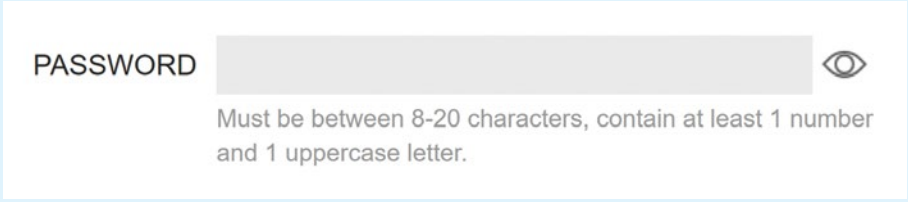
Examples

American Eagle has only two, very clear restrictions. As you can see, there's no need to write a full sentence, such as: *The password must include...* but rather be short and to the point, in a way that users can scan and understand the restrictions in a split second.



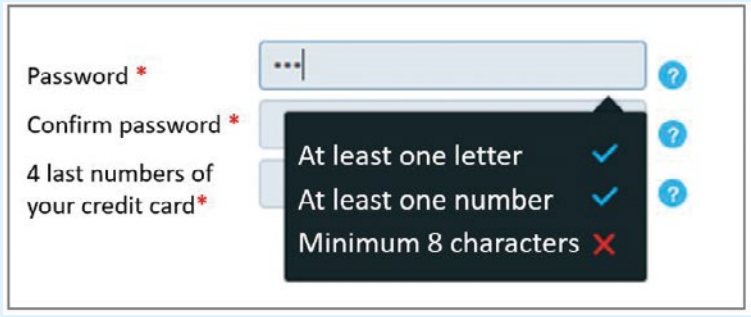
www.ae.com

Uniqlo also writes their limitations clearly under the field (it would be easier to scan if it appeared as a bullet list, wouldn't it?).



www.uniqlo.com

The Israeli TV provider **Yes** shows the rules as a tooltip when the user places the cursor in the password field, which is kept on display throughout. As soon as one of the rules has been met, a tick appears. Excellent!



www.yes.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

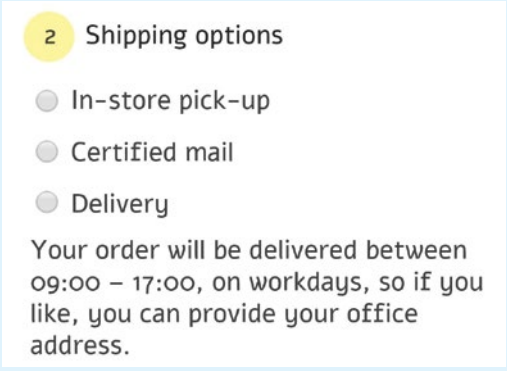
Stitch #5: Real-life problems

The user experience doesn't end when users leave the digital product, but continues wherever the customer is in contact with the brand. If the online process is connected to concrete processes that take place afterwards in real life, such as issuing a certificate, printing a document or receiving a shipment – think about each stage in the process and check if any problems could occur that you should point out right now and prevent.

Even if the potential problem is supposedly outside your jurisdiction, pointing it out to users will spare them the disappointment with the provided service, and give them the feeling that you thought about everything on their behalf. They might even thank you (or at least feel grateful).

Examples

The deliveries of **Belle and Sue** fashion store only go out during regular working hours. But there's no going around the fact that during working hours most of their customers are at work... Belle and Sue took that into account and propose a creative solution that is offered as soon as the customer starts making the order.



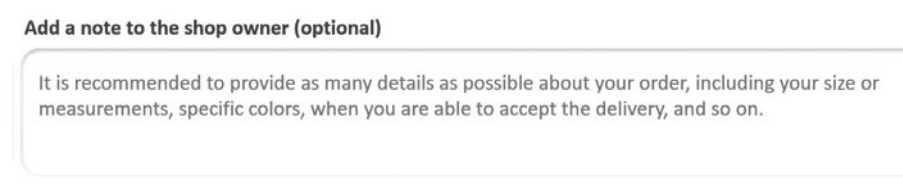
www.belleandsue.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

The QR Code Generator lets users decide if they want a margin to their QR code or not. But the site creators thought one step ahead: if users decide to remove the margin, they receive an extra piece of information – that to scan a marginless code requires printing it on a light background. This printing suggestion is a result of the company thinking about the process of how QR codes are used after their customers leave the site.



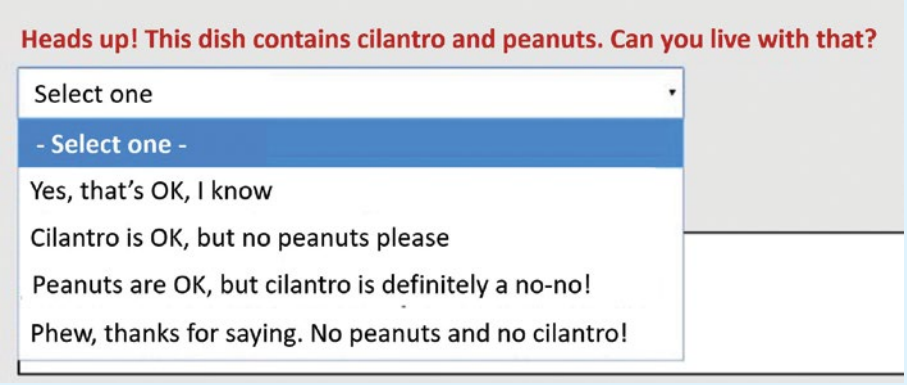
www.the-qrcode-generator.com (Powered by Visualead)

Marmalade Market, the Israeli equivalent of Etsy, offers a wide range of products, many of them are one of a kind or handmade, that have a myriad of potential confusing features. Marmalade wants to prevent frustration and misunderstandings that might arise between the customer and salesperson, and so it suggests that the customer leaves a detailed message for the shop owner. The placeholder provides examples of the type of details that are worth pointing out.



market.marmelada.co.il (Design: Say Digital | Translated from Hebrew)

Pekin Zahala restaurant in Tel Aviv knows that lots of people hate cilantro and that many are allergic to peanuts; so these are two ingredients that can cause problems once the customer receives the delivered meal. We can assume that in the past customers provided the restaurant with angry feedback on discovering that their delivery contained one of these ingredients (even though this is clearly mentioned in the menu). So nowadays, when you order a delivery online, and it contains cilantro or peanuts, a special alert appears in red.



www.pekin.co.il (Translated from Hebrew)

This is an excellent example of holistic thinking about the process, that prevents disappointment and the feeling of receiving bad service. Not to mention the excellent phrasing that makes the issue funny and provides a good experience for all the customers.

CHAPTER 18

MICROCOPY AND ACCESSIBILITY

This chapter was written with **Rotem Binheim, UX designer and AUX expert.*

THIS CHAPTER INCLUDES

7 guidelines for writing accessible microcopy

Microcopy for all

There's a fine line between providing a good, effective experience and causing frustration – and the difference can be just one word, or a quick hint, exactly where it's needed. **This is doubly true in the case of accessible microcopy and people who have difficulty or are unable to see the screen.**

The good news is there are 7 simple guidelines we need to follow to make sure we're serving these folks. Of course, these guidelines are for microcopy writers, but since most of us aren't in charge of actually implementing what we write, it's important that **product managers, UX designers, visual designers and developers** are also familiar with these principles.

How does your microcopy sound on a screen reader?

People who are visually impaired often use a **screen reader** to browse websites and use apps. Navigating with a screen reader isn't done with a mouse (as the user is unable to see the on-screen cursor), but rather by using the keyboard. Each press of the Tab or arrow keys advances the screen reader one element further – **from the top down and from left to right**, or according to a hierarchy set during development. The screen reader audibly reads each element in focus and identifies it as a link, button, or image when necessary.

As a result, people using screen readers don't perceive a full picture of the screen, or even a partial one in case of adjacent screen elements – instead, they're notified of each element separately.

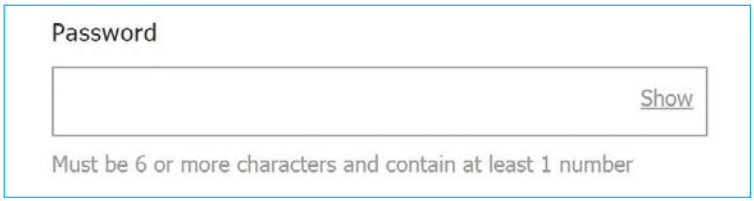
How can we make our microcopy compatible with screen readers? Let's dive in.

1. Think top-down and left to right

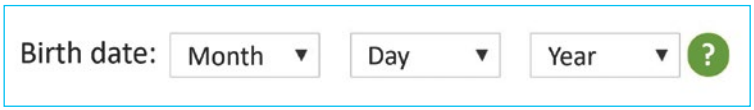
As mentioned, using a keyboard to navigate a website advances us from top to bottom and from left to right (and also back. In languages that are written right-to-left, the progress will be in that direction of course).

So when we embed a piece of microcopy to help users complete a task or prevent them from getting an error, placing the microcopy **in front of the action** is critical.

For example, on the form below, people will hear the field label ("Password"), and on the next Tab they'll enter their password. But when they create a password, they have no idea that there's a guideline written below the field (*Must be 6 or more characters and contain at least 1 number*) because the screen reader has not yet reached it. So users will choose a password and then find out there were further instructions, and then have to go back and choose a password that meets the requirements.



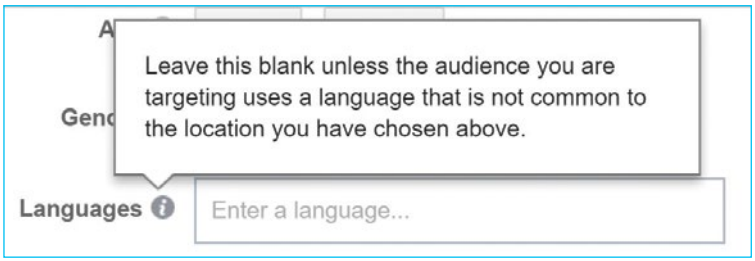
In the next example, screen-reader users will reach the drop-downs without knowing there's more information to the right. They, like everyone else, will be wondering why you're asking for their date of birth, but they wouldn't know there's an answer in a tooltip after the input fields. They might skip this question, or even abandon the task, because they don't see why they should give up this piece of personal information.



The solution here is to place the instruction right after the label, ahead of the input fields. **The accessible order of elements is therefore:**

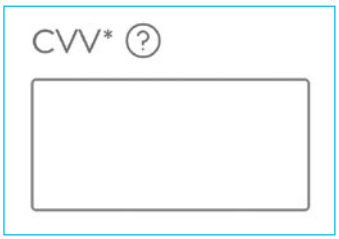
Label › Assistive text › Control

Here's how **Facebook** does it:



www.facebook.com

And here's how **Walmart** does it:

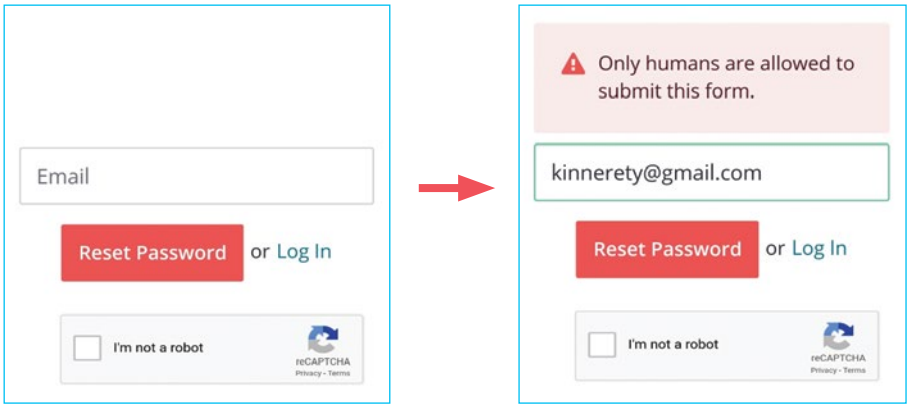


www.walmart.com

Note for developers: The elements can appear on screen in any order, as long as you set the keyboard focus shift in the correct accessible order. However, for seeing keyboard-only users, or people with cognitive impairments, having the focus indicator jump around the screen in an unexpected way could be a jarring experience. Ideally, content items will be aligned visually to match the document order, and vice versa (thanks to Scott Vinkle for the important note).

For the same reason, it's important not to place any microcopy under a confirmation button. A colleague with a vision impairment told us about her failure to complete an online purchase as she clicked the confirmation button (5 times) and nothing happened. She then found out that there was an "accept conditions" check box under the confirmation button, along with an error message pointing to the fact it was a required field. Of course, she couldn't see those, nor did the focus shift to them automatically, so after all the time and effort invested in placing the order, she wound up having to go to a brick-and-mortar store.

In the next form, how would screen-reader users know there's a captcha underneath when they hit the *Reset Password* button? And even worse, when they miss it, are the location and phrasing of the error message helpful? Will users that can only hear the error message, **and still don't know there's a captcha down there,** understand what the problem was and how to fix it?



To sum things up

All of the information needed to complete an action should be present ahead of it–above or just to the right of the control label. In cases that may result in errors, make sure during the development stage that the focus shifts correctly, so no one misses the piece of copy that can help them stay on the right track.

2. Be witty, but not at the expense of delivering a plain message

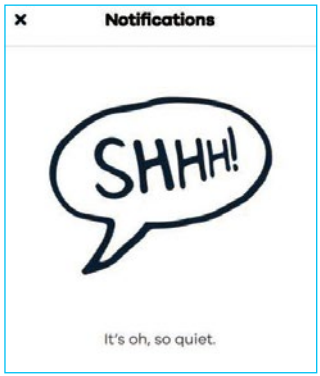
Will people understand where they are and what comes next, just from hearing the text read to them? In the next image you see the loading time meter for a swimming school website.



It includes some clever microcopy (*Diving in soon*), but for users who will only hear the words and not see the entire screen, it's not at all clear that they need to wait for the site to load.

A simple correction can solve this. Explicitly say something like: **The site is loading; we'll be diving in soon**

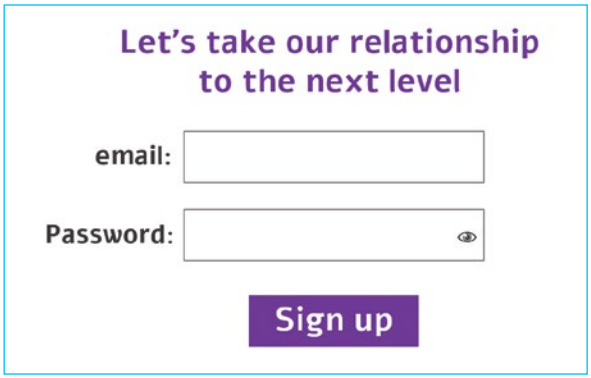
When users reach an empty state or 404 page, refrain from using just an image or clever words to explain where they are. And try not to use a combination of image and text that will be misunderstood if someone hears one but not the other.



What will users who can't see the screen understand from only hearing "Notifications, it's oh so quiet"?

For **errors or empty states**, write: *The page was not found*, or *There are no results*, or *There are no items in the cart* or *There are no new notifications* – and also explain how to proceed from there. All users will find this helpful (see Chapter 9).

On **sign up or login pages**, although it's always worthwhile to welcome users with an inviting headline (see Chapter 4), don't forget to say what the page is all about. In the next example of a sign-up page for a wedding planning website, the headline *Let's take our relationship to the next level* is appropriate for the desired voice and tone, but it doesn't say that this is the place to sign up for the site.



When screen-reader users arrive at the email field, they still don't know there's a password field and registration button below it, so they have no idea why their email is required. Maybe the next level is signing up for a newsletter? Granted, they'll discover the password field on their next click as the keyboard navigation proceeds, but you can save them from the hassle of wondering "What do I do here and why do they need my email?"

Oh, and it's best to mention that this is a sign-up page for seeing users as well, and add a few good reasons they should register. Two birds, one stone.

Writing the basic message is especially important on success and error messages. Close your eyes and repeat out loud the message you wrote. What do you understand from it? Is it unequivocal?

In a **success message**, do users who just hear the microcopy and can't see the green V, or smiling emoji, experience the reassuring confirmation and understand they've successfully completed the action as intended?

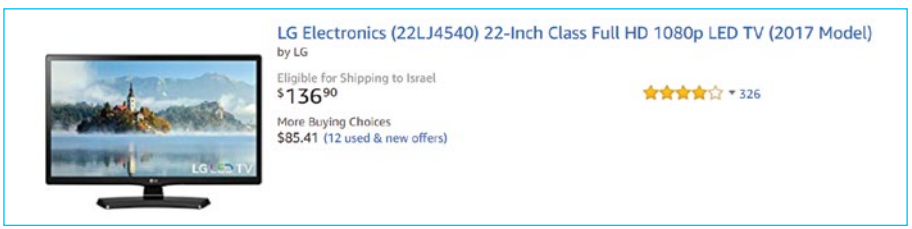
In an **error message**, do users who just hear the microcopy understand exactly what went wrong and how to proceed from here, even if they can't see that the field now has a red outline, or an added red exclamation mark?

3. A written alternative to every icon and every image

Every image or icon that bears visual information should have a short description – Alt – set during development. This text will not appear on screen, but will be read to users navigating using a keyboard and screen reader. If an image fails to load, due to connectivity problems for example, the Alt will be visible to seeing users as well – so it helps everybody.

Not every illustration needs a description. If it's a stock photo that doesn't enhance understanding or isn't important for setting the experience, it's actually better to spare this information from users navigating with the keyboard because they're inundated with information as it is.

In this example, there's no need to describe the scene appearing on the TV screen nor the TV itself, as there is a description of it to its right.



www.amazon.com

Icons are images too. If you have icons representing actions or features and they're unaccompanied by words (like a cogwheel or a house), add an Alt to them that says where they lead to, like: Homepage or Settings. If we don't add an Alt, the screen reader will just say *image* or *link* or *button* (depending on the setting developers decided on), and users who can't see them won't know about the extra actions or features present.

The icon **for more information**, indicated by an image of an 'i', '!' or '?', should also have an Alt describing what lies ahead. For example: *How to choose a password* or *More info*. If we fail to give these tiny-but-important icons an Alt, users who can't see them won't be aware of this crucial information.

Heads up #1 There's no point in being clever with Alt text. It should be clear and unequivocal.

Heads up #2 If the information is extremely salient, consider displaying it at all times rather than as a tooltip.

Emojis have preset Alts. Want to know what users hear when you use emojis in your microcopy? Watch "What do Emojis look like?!" by Molly Burke on YouTube.

4. Be more descriptive than "Read more" for links and buttons

Navigating with a keyboard allows you to jump between screen sections:

- Navigate between headlines only
- Navigate between links and buttons only

People who aren't able to see the screen in its entirety can thus quickly grasp what the important elements on the page are, then choose to navigate directly to what most interests them. So what does someone hear when jumping between buttons in the following screen?



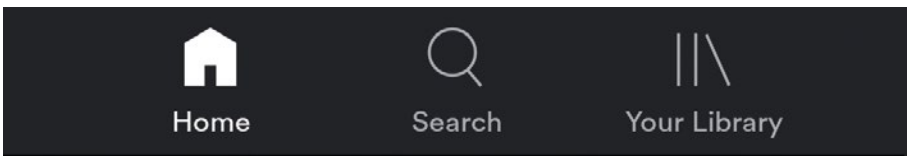
Since the headlines aren't links, this person will just hear "View post" repeated 3 times, with no indication whatsoever as to what these posts are about. It only takes a minor adjustment to solve this – no need to be overly clever. For example, you could replace each "View post" with: *My graduation outfit, How to stop chasing success, To the gift guide*.

When links or buttons give a little bit more information about the page they lead to, **everybody wins**: people with screen readers can decide if it's relevant, and *everyone* gets a good specific prompt to keep on reading.

5. All microcopy should appear as live text, not as an image

Screen readers only read live text. So if your button is actually an image; if the word beneath the icon is saved with it as one image; if you put a large image on your 404 page, with text in it explaining the situation – none of this text will be read to users who can't see.

In order for an icon set like this one (by **Spotify**) to be accessible, the microcopy should appear as live text, or be paired with an appropriate Alt text.



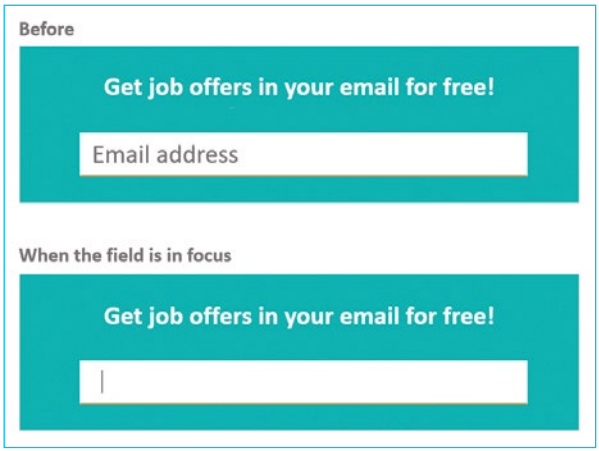
Spotify app

6. Readability: Permanent text in high contrast

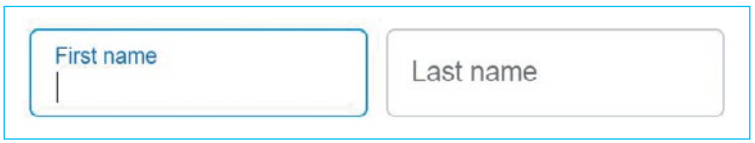
Keep it permanent

All the instructions, hints and notes regarding filling a form or taking any other action, should always be available – permanently visible or in a tooltip you can return to and read at any point in time.

Placeholders that disappear as soon as the field comes into focus are inaccessible, even to seeing users. Therefore, this form isn't accessible:



If set by developers as available for screen readers, **placeholders that change location** (like the ones in the next form) are passable for visually impaired users as far as accessibility, but their movement might confuse users with cognitive impairment. **So if you have abundant space**, place the labels outside the field – always visible and static. **If space is at a premium**, make sure whatever appeared in the field is also available when it's in focus.

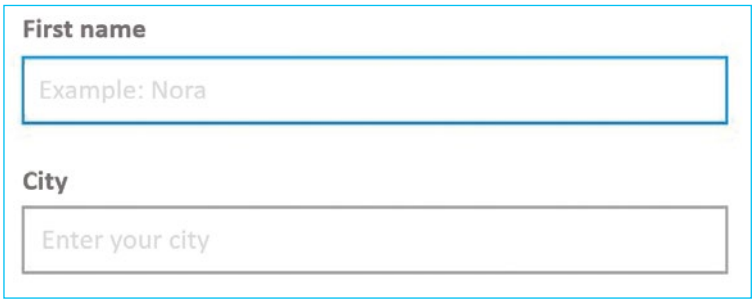


www.wix.com

Design in high contrast

All microcopy should appear in high contrast (to the background it appears on) so users with vision impairment or dyslexia can easily see and read it. This will also be much more convenient for others, making it easier for all users to read basic info.

If your placeholders contain information important for completing a task, they too should adhere to the high-contrast standards and not appear too bright. If they don't contain pertinent information, why are they there? Remove them, it'll benefit all users (see Chapter 10). In the next form, the placeholders are in low contrast and inaccessible, but are redundant too, so they shouldn't be enhanced but rather deleted.



This is the sign up form for the **Tesco** website. The labels are permanent and out of the field, and there is high contrast in the field. Way to go.

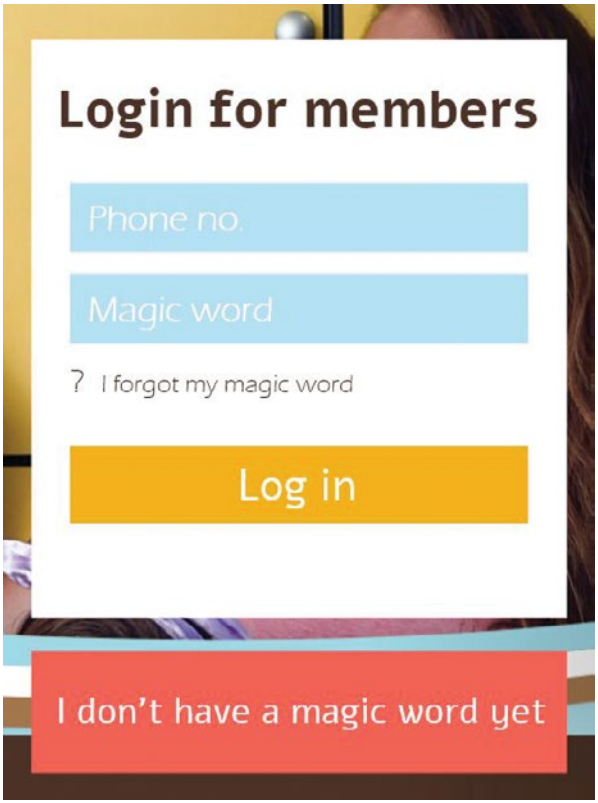


www.tesco.com

7. Simple is best

We tend to imagine writing for people who instantly comprehend what they read, but not everyone is actually able to do that. Many users won't necessarily understand – or have the patience to try to understand – abbreviations, acronyms, or the use of puns and word play.

This login form is very cool, but it's inaccessible. Even if everyone understands that "magic word" refers to password, will they all understand that "I don't have a magic word yet" means "I don't have an account"? This is cleverness upon cleverness that doesn't serve any of the users. Also note the low contrast in the light-blue fields and how difficult it is to read them.



A personal note

Ever since I've learned the principles of accessibility detailed here, I've overcome a big challenge in writing microcopy at large. I got a clear answer to my question of how clever I should be when writing microcopy. I imagine the screen reader reading the text, or a user with a cognitive impairment reading it, and I immediately arrive at where and how much cleverness I can use and where to draw the line. My writing has become simpler and clearer, with witty wording only in the right places.

So keep on writing rich, interesting, character-filled microcopy – but always remember to ask yourself **if everyone will understand what you've written**.

Increase your form completion rates

Just before you release a new form out into the world, or if you already have a form that too many users abandon without completing or call support to deal with, go over this checklist. **For further guidance on each item, explore the relevant chapters in this book.**

Before you dive in

1. Do users have enough good reasons to fill the form?

Do users understand why they need to fill it, and what's in it for them? Add on the top of the form, or on the page leading to it, a call to action that guaranties true value.

2. Is there too much microcopy in the form?

Does it look overloaded? It could happen if:

- You **over-explained**, even the parts that need no explanation.
- You've explained just what's needed, but **used too many words**.
- The UI/UX is **not intuitive enough**. Go back to the UX designers and reopen the issue.

3. Is there not enough microcopy in the form?

Did you skip on giving important explanations or reassuring words, in order not to overburden the users? Are critical instructions hiding in tooltips? Take them out.

Clarity

4. Conversational writing

Make sure you address the users directly, in everyday words and in a short, straightforward language.

5. Control labels

Check each label individually and make sure they can be easily understood by all users.

with this microcopy checklist

Make sure they **don't** include:

- Professional language that can be stated using simpler words.
- Terms you made up for internal use and were just left there.
- Abstract or vague terms that might be ambiguous.

If you find one of the above, either a. Substitute it with simpler terms, or b. Add an explanation.

6. When users have several options to choose from

In drop-downs, radio buttons or check boxes – make sure all the options are:

- Easily and quickly understood.
- Their meaning and implication are evident from their name (if not, consider adding a tooltip).
- Distinguishable from one another (none can be confused with another).

Where multiple choices can be made, say so.

7. Placeholders

- They shouldn't contain any information the user might need while typing.
- Make sure they add relevant information and don't just repeat the label.
- They should be in high contrast, to best serve accessibility guidelines.

8. Tooltips

- Make sure they don't contain critical information better left permanently visible.
- If this is a one-time or seldom filled form, consider using tooltips that automatically appear when the field comes into focus.

Cut out & keep

Proceeding smoothly with no interruptions

9. Preventing banal, irritating error messages

Check with the product manager or developers about each and every field: **What values and format does the system accept, and which values and formats will it reject with an error message?**

For those that will return errors, give the users an advanced warning around the field.

10. Marking required/optional fields

Use the asterisk or write "Optional". **If they are all required - mention this loud and clear or mark them all.**

11. Open questions

- Did you provide users with a lead to start their answer? **Something to help them focus and make your meaning clear?** Maybe a good tip on how to effectively frame an answer?
- If there's a limit to the number of characters in the answer – tell the users about it. Even add a counter.

12. Switches and check boxes

Whenever there's an option to turn something on or off (enable/disable) – using a switch or a check box – **make sure the users have all the necessary information to decide whether to switch it on or off**, including the implications of each choice.

13. Attaching files to the form

If there are any restrictions on file type or size, make it clearly known in advance.

14. Error messages

- Have you received all the potential error scenarios in this form from the development team?
- Have you written good microcopy for them, helping the users, following the best practices for writing error messages?

Address questions and concerns

15. Asking for personal information (email address, social security number, phone number, date of birth, etc.)

- If you need a piece of personal information – **explain why**.
- If the piece of personal information is optional – tell the users **how giving it will serve their needs.**

16. Asking for complex information

Do users know where to get this information from? If they don't – explain where it can be found.

17. Security

- With online payment – clearly indicate it's secured.
- If your business requires a higher level of discretion – clearly note that the information given will be secured and kept confidential.

18. Making changes later

- If users can later on change whatever they input into the form – tell them that. It will be easier for them to go ahead and fill it with no worries.
- If they cannot change it later – give them a heads up to avoid disappointment later.

It doesn't end with clicking Send

19. Waiting time

If there's a loading and processing time between clicking the Send button and the success message – prepare a nice message suitable for the experience, and show your users you gave some thought even to this small detail.

20. Success message

What do users see as soon as they complete the task and submit the form? Is the success message pleasantly rewarding and completes the experience you wish to create?

CHAPTER 19

MICROCOPY FOR COMPLEX SYSTEMS

This chapter was written thanks to the generous sharing of knowledge by professional UX and content women and men, who shared with me their insights, experience and screenshots: Jasmin Galker Vaisburd of UniqUI; Shani Polanski, Leah Kraus, and Naama Shapira of PTC; Elinor Mishan Salomon and Idit Peled of the Ministry of Justice; Galia Engelmayer of NICE; and Assaf Trafikant of QuickWin

IN THIS CHAPTER

A definition of complex systems

The value of microcopy in complex systems

Why complex systems need voice and tone design

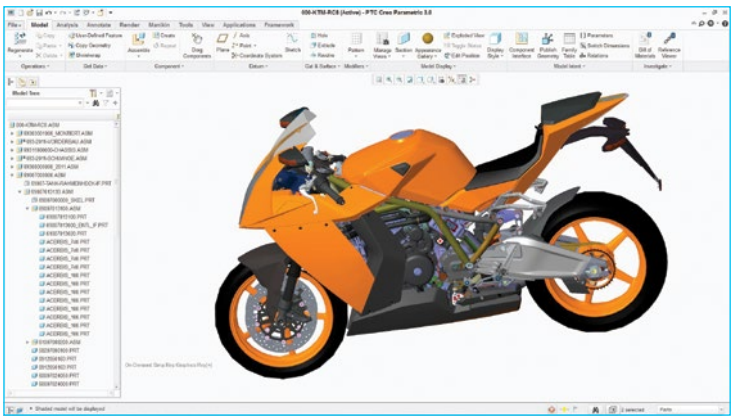
What are complex systems?

In the context of this guide, complex systems are systems that users must use for functional or professional needs, and that have many components related to each other. These systems are not linear – that is to say that users don't enter a system in one place and leave at the other end when they have completed the task – rather they access them again and again, for various tasks, and they use many components with multiple and consistent relationships to each other.

Types of complex systems

1. Expert systems

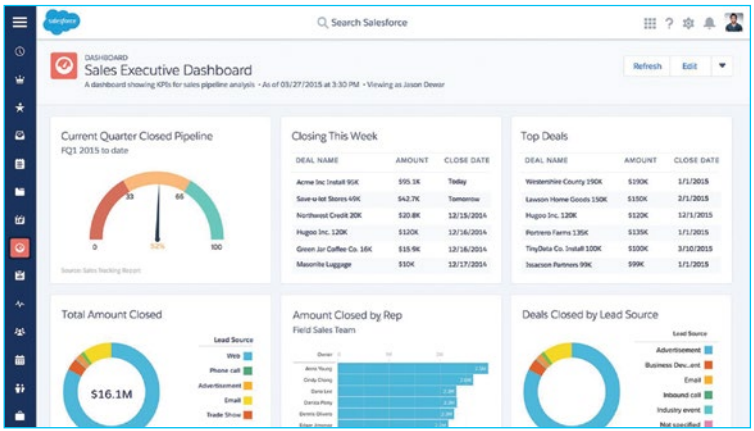
These are aimed at professionals, such as a log for genetic researchers, a graphic design program, a modelling program for engineers, a communication system for telemarketers, or a system for garage mechanics to identify car problems.



Screenshot of the program Creo Parametric from PTC, an expert system that is super professional and that engineers use to draw three-dimensional models

2. Intra-organizational systems

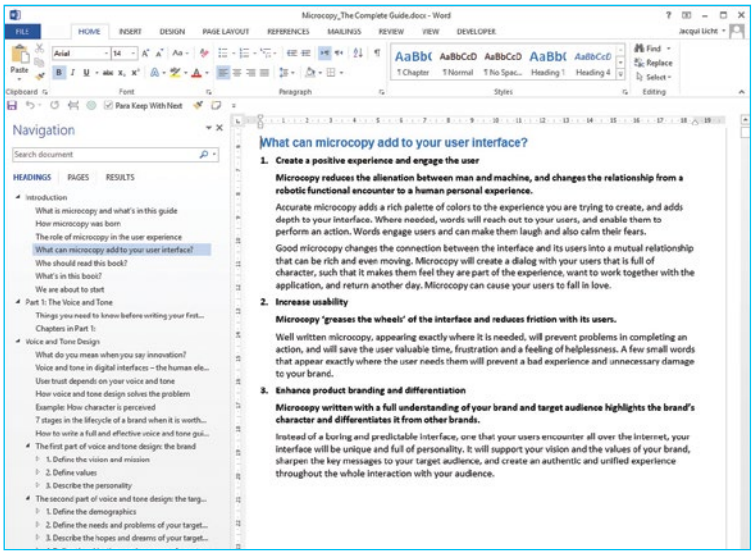
These are meant to organize and manage knowledge or processes, such as a payroll system, management of medical records, customer management, sales tracking, or project management.



A screenshot of Sales Cloud – A CRM by Salesforce

3. Functional systems for the general public

These are designed to perform useful tasks, for example, word processors or a bank account management application.



Microsoft Word is also a complex system, even though it is aimed at the general public

How most complex systems are used and the effect on microcopy

Before we dive into complex system microcopy, I must emphasize that in spite of the general reference to complex systems, there are those dedicated to NASA engineers, others to manage call centers by 24-year old shift leaders, still others for designers or developers working in an agile environment, systems for medical secretaries, and more and more. Here I'll provide guidelines to writing microcopy that is common to most of them, **but each system has its own voice and tone, according to the target audience, work environment and system goals.** I'll write more about it in the last part of this chapter.

Professional but practical

For expert systems, the users are dependent on the system to implement and use their professional skills, and also to demonstrate their professionalism when around their peers.

Therefore the microcopy needs to be professional. In contrast to the iron rule of microcopy for the general public, where you need to find a way to simplify professional or technical terms, here the use of professional terms is **necessary** for two reasons:

a. Usability – so that the users will find easily whatever they are looking for using the terms they are used to in their work environment.

b. Proof of professionalism – so that users understand that the system has been developed specifically for them by people who are experts in their field, that it understands the profession and can execute any professional task in the best possible way. The system needs to sound professional to the extent that it enables its users to completely rely on it and entrust their professionalism to it.

BUT professional does not mean high and pompous, but rather simple and precise.

Why? First of all, in most cases, we are talking about tasks performed as part of a work day, in other words – with some level of pressure. So the microcopy needs to be practical – short, direct, clear, understandable in a split second, and enabling the quick and smooth performance of tasks.

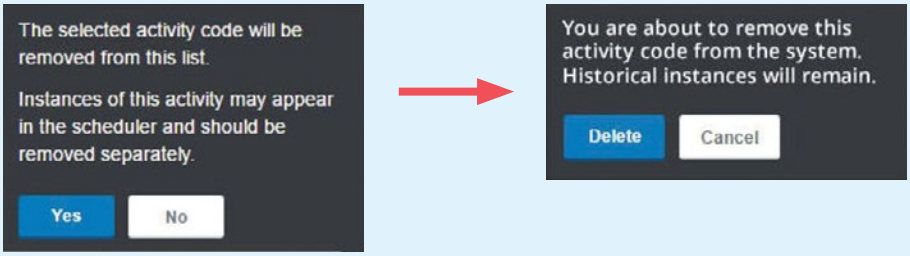
Your technologically complex system is in daily use in the 21st century, and if it sounds like an ancient dictionary, it will be harder for your contemporary users to understand. Complex systems require complicated explanations, so you need to avoid using academic, outdated, or irrelevant language that complicates things even more (read all about it in Chapter 2 of this guide).

This "high" language isn't evidence of professionalism but of fixated thinking. It is really worthwhile to be super clear and write **simply, precisely, in a practical and accessible language.** The rule is: write as a professional in the field would **talk**, and not as if they are writing their doctoral dissertation.

The second reason you should write as simple as you can is to adapt the system to the varying levels of professional understanding: beginners and experts, bright and average. Therefore a simple professional language is always preferable to a complex professional language.

Examples

Alert from a **NICE** call center management system: Shorter, more active, more direct, and the buttons say exactly what they do.



Notification from the **Ministry of Justice** system (translated from Hebrew). Read only the new version before reading the old one. Is there anything unprofessional, offensive or unacceptable? Hint: No. It's excellent. It is possible to be professional and use everyday words. And it is also good for accessibility!

Before

Please note that a file already exists for the ID number entered. This fact confirms that you have already performed tasks related to us in the past. As a result, after clicking the confirmation button, you will be forwarded to an identification screen in order to generate an initial password.



After

Your ID number already exists.
Please login or recover your password

The title of a feature on the **RealMatch** system for tracking performance of job ads was:

Ad Distribution Trends and Examples

But now it is much clearer and obvious, written in simple terms:

Where does your ad appear?

Give your users a hand

Complex systems are, as the name suggests, complex, and they usually require studying and gradual immersion. The principle that the interface should explain itself is not always possible here, because of the proliferation of features, possibilities and elements that are related to each other.

Thus you could say that "our users are intelligent, they'll understand", "we'll solve it with training", "let them call the support desk", "they should look at the user guide". But it is possible to tackle it in another way, probably more effectively, using microcopy to help your users.

1. Titles

Pay special attention to the menus, field labels, feature names, graph titles, categories, options in drop-downs, and column headings in tables, and make sure that they are clear and simple, that they explain exactly what appears or needs to be typed, are easy to understand quickly and unequivocal.

2. Placeholders and hints

Do you want to provide a short explanation about a field? Write the explanation as a placeholder inside the field (if the user doesn't need to remember it while typing), or as a short sentence above it, or in a tooltip (**see Chapters 10** and **14** for best practices). These small but powerful tools will help you educate your users without making them turn to the user guide.

3. Tooltips

If you want to explain something complicated about the field or about another element in the interface, put a small i icon next to the label, that when hovered over displays a tooltip with the explanation (as short and simple as possible, but still including all the required information that will save a call to the help desk or a search in the user guide). Complex systems have many more tooltips, and they are longer, compared to simple systems aimed at the general public, and that's just fine.

See Chapter 14 for more about how and when to help users.

Examples

This is an effective and complete tooltip for a column heading in a table on the **RealMatch** expert system. It explains what the users need to know about the statuses they currently see in the "status" column, but also explains about other optional statuses, thus it educates the users about how to use the system.



Tooltips can also convey the value of the feature, thus helping the users to get the most out of it.



TIP

27

You again?!

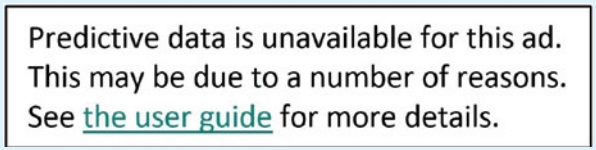
Users will access your system daily, often a few times a day, and there are professions where all the work activity is centered on one system. At some stage the users stop reading the text and perform the actions automatically.

So don't be too clever with the microcopy of frequently performed tasks. Even if there is a place in your system for clever text, it is better not to use it on those tasks that users perform routinely. The first time they'll laugh, but what about the second time? And the third? And the 30th?

4. Explicit referral to the user guide

If the explanation is long and complex, and in those places where it is clear that users must read the guide to fully understand, don't leave them to get upset about their knowledge gaps and search for the solutions by themselves. Show them that you are aware of the complexity and refer them to the exact place in the guide, as part of the system, and if possible as a direct link.

Example



RealMatch expert system

5. Error messages

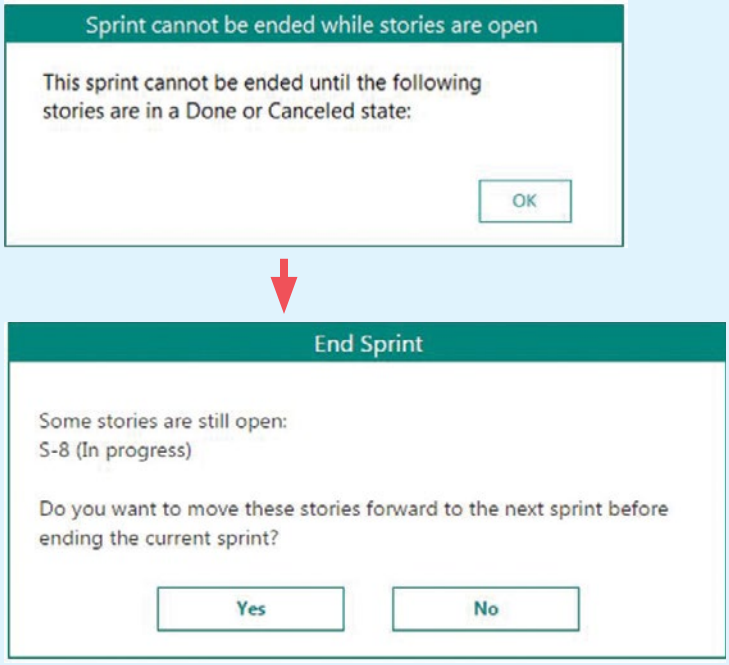
Error messages are annoying, and if users are in the middle of a complex process and running out of time, then errors are also seen as frustrating and demoralizing. Needless to say, all error messages must be simple and effective (**see Chapter 7**), but in complex systems even more so. So explain the problem concisely, and guide the users on how to solve it so that they can continue. Use understandable words that are not threatening, express the problem calmly so that you don't scare the users, and add instructions that can be implemented easily.

Very important: Present the problem from the point of view of the users, not of the system and not of the developers. For that you should understand exactly what the user was trying to do, what went wrong, and how to fix it – not only technically, but also professionally.

Example

Following is an error message from the **PTC AgileWorx** system for managing work processes in an agile environment. In such an environment, the team works for set periods (sprints), and at the end of each sprint they should have completed all the stories assigned to them for that sprint and close them in the system. If the team decides to leave a story open, it needs to be reassigned to the next sprint.

This error message appears when the group tries to close a sprint when there are still open stories assigned to it. The earlier version of the message provided a technical explanation to the users about how the system works, what it allows and doesn't allow. The new version was written from the point of view of the users and with the professional understanding that what they want to do in an agile environment is to go back or to move the stories to the next sprint. Even the wording is more fluent, active, and practical, and suitable for the dynamism of agile processes.



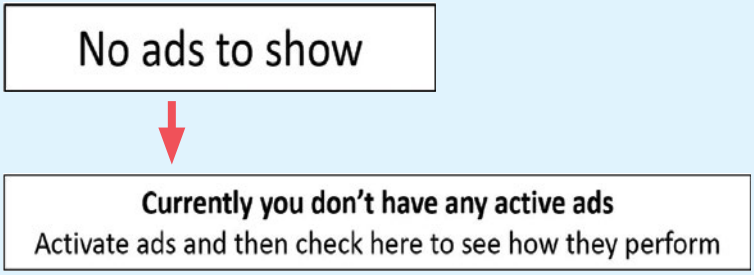
6. Empty states

Empty states in complex system are golden opportunities to educate your users and let them know how the system works. Instead of leaving them at a dead end, use this vacant space to explain what they can or should do, how this feature is supposed to work, what should be here, or how to progress.

Examples

Instead of a frustrating "Data is unavailable" (or in other words "There's nothing to see here"), the **RealMatch** system tells the users what will be here, when, and what they should do now. In this example that is simply to wait.





Note that despite the humane and friendly voice and tone of these messages, the professionalism of the brand is not harmed. On the contrary, the new sentence is much more professional, complete and precise.

But we've been doing it for 30 years now!

Complex systems with hundreds of features and 30 years of experience in the market, provide users with what they have already learned and got used to. On the one hand it's incredibly convenient, but on the other hand the gap between the interfaces they use outside of work and their expert system is widening. Outside of work they enjoy using new interfaces that are comfortable, written in contemporary language, and that are clear and interesting. Then a new work day begins, and they go back through the time tunnel to when their system was developed, with a language left over from the days when developers wrote all the microcopy, and everyone thought it was reasonable to let users decipher the logic of the system on their own.

The problem with veteran expert systems is that it's really hard to change the voice and tone legacy, and if you DO decide to change it – there's no way all the features can be dealt with in one go, not visually and not the microcopy. On the other hand, if we change the microcopy only for the new features, it'll create inconsistency within the system.

So what can be done? If you want the system to advance at some point, you have to start somewhere: write contemporary microcopy for every new feature, and update the microcopy for any old feature that is being updated to a new version. Naturally, you need to make sure that users are easily able to link between similar elements written for a new feature compared to the old, despite the voice and tone differences. Luckily, a change in a complex system can't be so overwhelming anyway, because the professional terminology stays, even if the surroundings become more contemporary.

Before starting this process of change, it is highly recommended to design a comprehensive voice and tone, and then decide what stays and what changes. This will ensure the continuity of the professional language and of the general character of the system and still enable regeneration. This process, in cooperation with different parts of the organization, will also facilitate the acceptance of change among employees and managers (thanks to Shani Polanski of PTC for this important insight from her experience).



A captive audience is still a target audience

Most complex systems have some level of competition, but the massive resources required to transfer a whole organization to a new system results in many organizations continuing to tolerate a reasonable or even a less than reasonable system for many long years, just so that they won't need to go through the process of change. And there are systems where the audience is really captive, such as government agency systems, so why do we need to invest resources in improvement? They'll manage, they **have** to.

If you are concerned about user experience, and if you strive to provide your users with the best user experience just because that in itself is important enough to you, you'll surely identify with the following sentence that Elinor Mishan Salomon, UX and UI team leader in the Israel Ministry of Justice, said to me that summarizes this whole chapter:

"Precisely **because** *they are a captive audience! They want to work, and I want them not to get stuck without knowing what to do next. They shouldn't leave frustrated. They should have tools that are not their best friend but can be relied on to work* **for** *them and not* **against** *them."*

And if your users are happy, they use your system more, purchase add-ons, spread the word, and renew the contract. Here's your ROI.

Why complex systems need voice and tone design

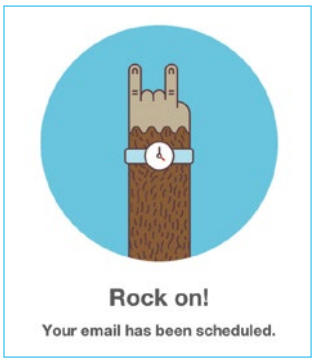
Writing microcopy doesn't mean that you have to write funny or cute text, instead you should design a voice and tone that will suit your users and the context in which they operate (**see chapter 1**). In other words, it's incorrect to say that correct and dry microcopy doesn't have character, it does, but it is a dry and correct character, and when dealing with complex systems, it is quite possible that it's exactly what your users need. Even more so if your users are exposed to a lot of uncertainty, pressure, responsibility, deadline or anxiety. Just give them microcopy that is as simple and clear as possible. This is the most empathic thing you can do for them, more than a sad smiley.

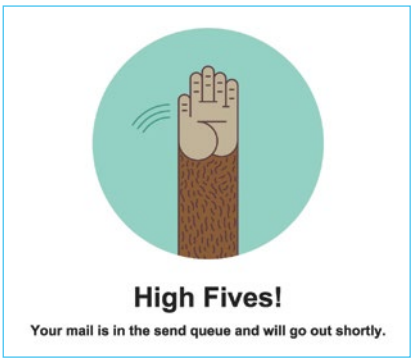
Does this mean that complex, professional or business-to-business (B2B) systems need always to be serious and correct?

Well, no, it doesn't.

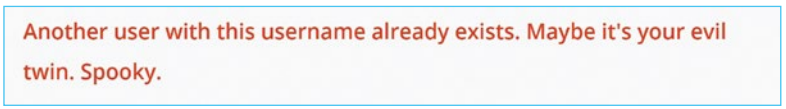
Make fun of work

MailChimp runs a B2B system that is friendly, humane and funny with **millions of business users**. Here are two of their confirmation messages.





And even their error messages are sometimes humorous:



MailChimp's users are very reliant on the system: we are talking about millions of businesses that use the system to manage their mailing lists

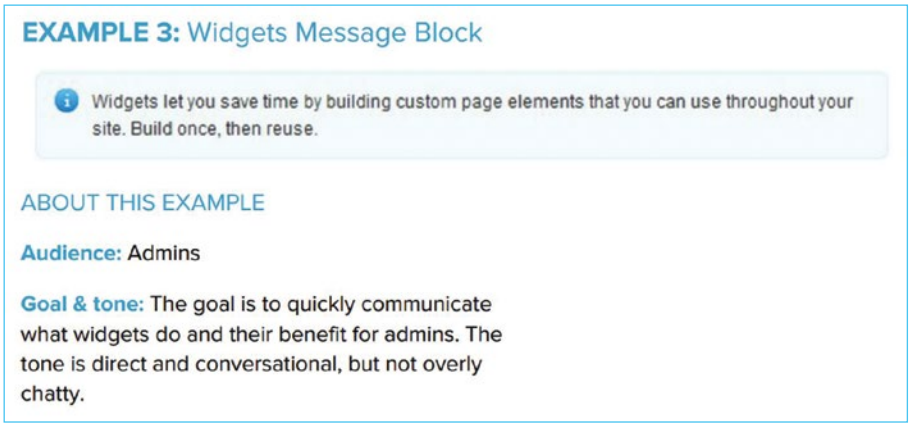
and email campaigns. This also involves a high level of uncertainty, tough competition, apprehension, and technical complexity. And a lot of money is at stake. This is a serious subject, worrying, complex and critical.

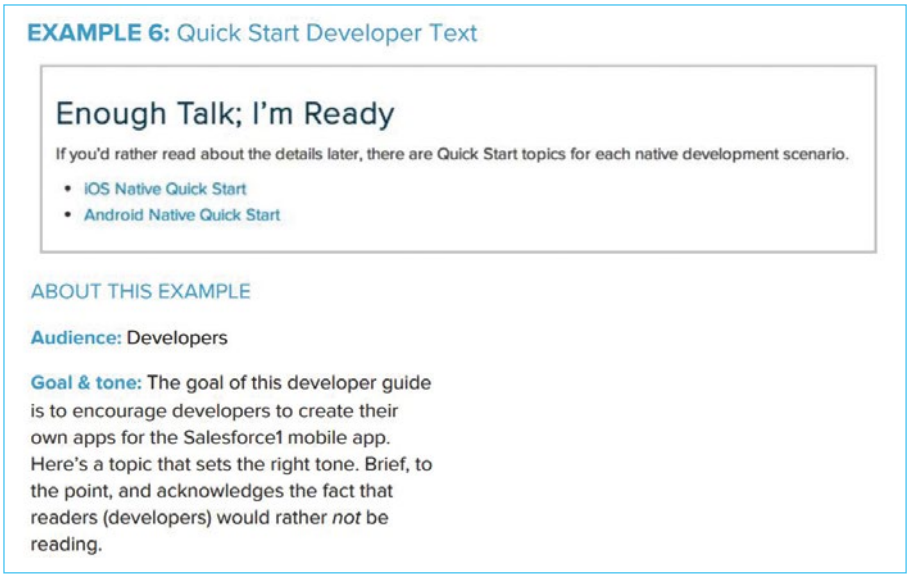
How come that MailChimp allows itself to be frivolous? And how come that their users are crazy about them? And how did their voice and tone design become the shining example for content writers?

Fact. It is possible to be humane and friendly even in a psychologically complex and technically demanding environment.

True, to do so successfully you need loads of sensitivity to the different scenarios that users face and the context in which every word is spoken, and a well-defined voice and tone. But it's possible. Check out **Slack** for communicating within a team, and **Trello** for managing project teams. They did it too.

A highly recommended B2B voice and tone design, that is super professional and contemporary, is the one for **Salesforce**. Just google "Salesforce voice and tone" and enjoy. Here are two appetizers:





The screenshots are from the brilliant voice and tone design of **Salesforce** on www.lightningdesignsystem.com/assets/downloads/salesforce-voice-and-tone.pdf

That doesn't mean you must be liberated and light in every system, definitely not. However, **there is no such thing as a single voice and tone that fits all professional or complex systems**. The brand and its goals, the target audience, the relationship between them, and work environment alter it a lot. Whether you're writing microcopy for consumers or experts, you always need to first specify the voice and tone. Yes, always.

Luckily, there's a full step-by-step guide to design your own voice and tone in Chapter 1 of this book you have just finished reading. It's time to get to work.

Microcopy is the text we find in digital products – buttons, sign-up forms, assistive copy, error messages, etc. – that motivates users, helps them perform tasks easily, reinforces brand engagement, and in general, turns boring old messages into interesting, valuable conversation.

Microcopy: The Complete Guide (2nd edition) gives you the knowledge and tools needed to write smart, effective and helpful microcopy for your digital product. It includes principles, practical tips, and hundreds of screenshots from actual products by corporations, start-ups and SMBs.

And no, you don't have to be a copywriter. Anyone with an aptitude for words and technology can write microcopy. Everything you need is right here in this book.

Who will find this book useful? Microcopy (UX) writers and copywriters; UX designers; UI designers; product managers; website and app owners; digital marketing professionals; small business owners; bloggers; advertisers; sales personnel, and more.

Fascinated by the words that light up interfaces?
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Kinneret Yifrah



Runs **Nemala**, the leading microcopy studio in Israel. She has been writing content and microcopy for digital products for over 10 years, and designed the voice and tone for businesses of all kinds and sizes. Kinneret manages the Israeli microcopy community and gives talks and workshops.

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